

My Husband Wept for Her at Our Vow Renewal

A Marriage-in-Crisis Second-Chance Grovel Romance

Wren Blackspire

My Husband Wept for Her at Our Vow Renewal

Copyright © 2026 Wren Blackspire

All rights reserved. No part of this publication may be reproduced, distributed, or transmitted in any form or by any means, including photocopying, recording, or other electronic or mechanical methods, without the prior written permission of the author, except for brief quotations in critical reviews and certain other noncommercial uses permitted by copyright law.

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, businesses, places, events, and incidents are either the products of the author's imagination or used in a fictitious manner. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, or actual events is purely coincidental.

First edition 2026

Contents

Part One — The Truth.....	5
Chapter 1 — The Runner.....	6
Chapter 2 — Cornish Hens.....	15
Chapter 3 — Department Meeting.....	21
Chapter 4 — The Price of It.....	28
Chapter 5 — The Thursday Table.....	34
Chapter 6 — The Facts.....	41
Part Two — The Listening.....	49
Chapter 7 — The Moravec Method.....	50
Chapter 8 — The Binder.....	56
Chapter 9 — Walter and Esther.....	63
Chapter 10 — Thanksgiving.....	69
Chapter 11 — The Hour.....	78
Chapter 12 — The Table, Again.....	83
Chapter 13 — Eight to Midnight.....	89
Part Three — The Showing Up.....	96
Chapter 14 — The Thread.....	97
Chapter 15 — What Isla Saw.....	106
Chapter 16 — A Chair for the Second One.....	113
Chapter 17 — Callum's Tuesday.....	122
Chapter 18 — The Car.....	129
Chapter 19 — The Agenda.....	134
Chapter 20 — Everything Printed.....	142
Part Four — The Carrying.....	149
Chapter 21 — The Closet.....	150
Chapter 22 — Potatoes.....	157
Chapter 23 — Say It In Front of Me.....	164
Chapter 24 — The Binder, Again.....	169
Part Five — The Staying.....	174
Chapter 25 — Christmas Eve.....	175
Chapter 26 — The Pulpit.....	184

Chapter 27 — Come In.....	191
Chapter 28 — The Back Row.....	197
A Note Before You Go.....	202

Part One — The Truth

I'll tell you the truth, even the small ones.

Chapter 1 — The Runner

The runner was two inches off true, and Thea Moravec was on her knees in a wedding dress fixing it.

“You are the bride,” Dimitra said from somewhere above her. “That’s the whole job today. You stand still and let other people be competent.”

“Other people laid this.” Thea pinched the ivory canvas where it had wandered off the chalk line she had snapped at seven that morning and walked it back. Ninety chairs, forty-five a side, each squared to its neighbor with the steel ruler from her go-bag, and behind the last row the boathouse windows were full of lake, flat and gray as a serving tray. “It’s two inches off, and Mrs. Haskell’s cane catches on two inches.”

“Mrs. Haskell is eighty-one and has a hip she’d like to meet you with. She’ll be fine.” Dimitra Kallis held out her hand, palm up, the way you hold it out to a toddler with scissors. “Walkie.”

“I’m not holding a walkie.”

“It’s in your bouquet, under the eucalyptus.”

It was. The bouquet lay across the front-row chair, white anemones and seeded eucalyptus, and in the middle of the stems sat a black handset with its antenna folded down.

“You asked the florist for a wider wrap,” Dimitra said. “You said it was for the stem count.”

“It was for the stem count. Brides do not carry walkies down the aisle.”

“This one has a coordinator who has run forty-one weddings and a goat, and has never once been told to calm down, so give it here.”

Thea sat back on her heels. The dress was ivory crepe with a plain bateau neckline and long sleeves, nothing a camera could argue with. “It’s not my first time in this room. I know where everything is.”

“That’s what scares me, and you know it.” Dimitra’s voice went soft, which it only did when she had stopped arguing and started winning. “Ten years ago you got married here with forty people and a borrowed cake knife. Today you get to be the person it happens to. I have the cake and the cars, and Odessa is in the kitchen threatening a hen. Go sit in the bridal room and eat a cracker.”

“I’ll sit when the quartet’s in.”

“The quartet is in and tuning, and the cellist says it’s a Michigan A, whatever that means.”

“It means it’s flat, Dimitra.”

“Then it matches the lake. Walkie.”

Thea got up, scuffed out the two gray ovals her knees had printed on the canvas, and put the handset in Dimitra’s palm. Her hand was light afterward.

“Thank you.” Dimitra tucked it into her back pocket and plucked something from Thea’s hair on the way past. “Is this a *pen*?”

“It’s a pen.”

“Under the veil.”

“It was already in there.”

“Cracker,” said Dimitra.

At the front of the room Pilar Duarte, sixty-three, silver hair cut like a helmet and a plum stole over her black robe, was testing the microphone clipped to her lapel, tapping the little black capsule with one finger as if testing a melon. “Check. Check, one, two. Is it too hot?”

“A little high,” Thea called. “Move it down an inch. I want the back row to get every word.”

“You told me that at noon, and again at one. I have officiated more than two hundred of your weddings, Thea, and this is the first one where you’ve micromanaged my lapel. Let it be slightly bad.”

“Nothing about this is slightly anything.”

“That,” said Pilar, “is the most honest thing you’ve said all week,” and she moved the microphone down an inch.

The bridal room was the old net loft office, with a radiator that knocked and a window onto a brick wall. Thea did not sit but went through the go-bag, tape and pins and the sleeve of crackers, and found it all there.

“Radio check,” Dimitra said in her left ear, the one earpiece Thea had insisted on keeping, which Dimitra pretended not to know about. “Photographer wants the lake at three-twenty. Please do not go look at the lake.”

“I’m not looking at the lake.”

“You’re at the window.”

“It has a view of a wall.”

“Then stop looking at the wall, sit down, and let someone bring you water.”

“I’ll sit down when it’s time to sit down.” Thea took her forehead off the glass. In the spring she had made a list in the back of her planner, two columns. The first held ten years of other people’s ceremonies: three hundred and eleven weddings, nine anniversary parties, one very large retirement, a

goat. The second held a single entry in her own handwriting, *this*, with nothing under it.

Margit came in without knocking, which was how Margit came into every room, and shut the door with her hip. She was sixty-eight and five foot one in her good shoes, in plum wool, and she carried a small paper bag folded over twice at the top.

“Sit,” she said.

“I can’t sit in the dress. It creases.”

“Then stand and be creased.” Margit put the bag on the radiator shelf and unfolded it. Inside was a white handkerchief, very old, the hem done in blue thread by hand. “Josef’s mother’s. She carried it at her wedding in Szeged. I carried it at mine. I did not carry it at Nolan’s, because you said no old things, you wanted a clean look.”

“I said the photographer hated them. It’s very old, Margit, it’s beautiful, I’ll give it back after the photos.”

“It is for carrying. And you said clean.” Margit pressed the handkerchief into Thea’s palm and closed her fingers over it. Her hands were small and dry from forty years of dishwater, and the cafeteria had given her forearms like a ferryman’s. “Ten years is a long time to stay married to a man who tells jokes when he is frightened.”

“He’s not frightened.” Thea looked for the planner’s word and didn’t find one. “Nervous. He asked for a pause.”

“Mm.” Margit looked at the sleeve of crackers on the shelf. “He did not eat his breakfast. I made eggs, and he moved them.”

“He was nervous.”

“He was nervous at breakfast too. I counted the forkfuls.” Margit had been counting the meals of Moravec men since 1986. Then she did something Thea had not seen her do in three years: she touched Thea’s face, quickly, with two fingers, the way you check a loaf. “You look like you have not slept.”

“I slept four hours. It’s a respectable number.”

“It is a number. And this is not even your wedding. You did that. You were twenty-eight and you cried in the car.” Margit’s mouth twisted. “Your brother-in-law would have made a speech. A terrible one. He would have thanked the caterer by name and then the lake.”

She never said the name. *Your brother-in-law, their father, my other son.* For three years she had stepped around that one word the way you cross a floor

with a loose board, and Thea had walked beside her, and neither of them had mentioned the walking.

“He would have thanked the lake,” Thea said.

“He would have asked it to dance.” Margit patted her cheek once, brisk. “Don’t cry, the photographer will have to do something. Eat a cracker.”

“Everybody keeps saying that.”

“Because it is good advice.” She went out, and the radiator knocked. Thea stood holding the old handkerchief, the blue thread coming loose at one corner, her fingers wrapped so tightly around it that her hand ached. She folded it small and pushed it into the cuff of her sleeve, where it lay against her wrist like a second pulse.

The knock was two quick taps and then a pause, which was how Nolan knocked.

She opened the door and he was standing in the corridor in the charcoal suit that no longer fit him across the shoulders, holding Biscuit under one arm. The beagle wore a bow tie. It was eating the bow tie.

“He got into the hens,” Nolan said. “Odessa’s furious. She says he’s disqualified from the ring pillow.”

“There’s no ring pillow.”

“That’s what I told him.” He set the dog down, and Biscuit trotted in and lay across her go-bag, as he always did. Nolan stayed in the doorway, six foot three and still carrying some of the high school wrestler he’d been. In ten years she had watched him go through a hundred doorways as if afraid of breaking them, and today he stood in this one as if it might not hold him.

“Where’s your boutonniere?” she asked.

“Biscuit had it for a snack. He was hungry, and I was nervous, and we reached an arrangement.”

“You’re pale, Nolan.”

“I’m fine.”

“You said that at the dentist, and then you fainted.”

“The gas did that. You’re the color of the runner.”

“It’s Odessa’s lights. They make everyone look like soup.”

“You look—”

She waited, because he had always been good with a sentence and this one sat in his mouth and wouldn’t leave.

“Like a fire hazard?” she offered.

“Like the first time.” He laughed, a little too loud for the corridor, and it stopped. “I’m going to cry in the first minute. Fair warning.”

“It’s in the run-of-show.” She had laminated it, like everything. “Pilar gives you a pause after the second promise, and it’s on the sheet. 3:35 Nolan tears, permitted. I left eight seconds.”

He looked at her for a long moment, longer than anyone had ever looked at her without saying something. She took it for love.

“Eight seconds,” he said.

“I’m generous.”

“You are the most generous person I know.” He stepped in and put his arms around her, carefully, around the veil, and she put her face against his collar. It smelled of starch and, underneath, of burnt old coffee, an urn on its warming plate since breakfast. It was the smell he’d brought home last Thursday, and the Thursday before. A department meeting. She had meant to ask which colleague made the coffee that bad, and then a client had called.

“Did you eat?” she asked into the collar.

“Odessa made me a hen. I couldn’t.”

“Did you write the remarks? Pilar needs the cue for the ring exchange, and I’ve asked you three times.”

“It’s in my head.”

“A physics teacher with an unwritten speech.”

“Best kind. No errors in transcription. Nobody can check it against anything.” He let go of her and, instead of stepping back, held her by the upper arms and looked at her face as if it were a page he was trying to learn by heart. “Thea.”

“Mm.”

“I—” His mouth worked. Down the corridor the quartet started something with a lot of cello. “Never mind. After. I’ll say it after.”

“After is on the run-of-show too. Four-forty, remarks.”

He laughed again, quieter. “Of course it is.”

She straightened his tie, which did not need it, and pushed the bow tie off the dog, which did.

“Is it straight?” he asked.

“It was straight when you came in. Now it’s loyal.”

At 3:27 Dimitra’s voice came through the earpiece again. “Margit’s seated, front row, holding her handbag like somebody might steal it. She asks me to tell you the rose on her corsage is crooked. I told her it’s a feature.”

“Did she like that?”

“She said, and I quote, ‘Hm.’ Isla’s in the green dress and hates it, Jonas clipped his tie on crooked and won’t let anyone touch it, and Odessa’s at the back with a dish towel looking smug. Also the cellist has found a second Michigan A.”

At 3:31 the first notes of the processional filled the boathouse, and he gave her his arm, and they walked down the aisle together on a runner that lay true under both their feet.

Isla sat beside her grandmother, sixteen and unimpressed, and Jonas, thirteen, was hoping to become a very small piece of the floor. At the back Odessa grinned. Mrs. Haskell and her cane were in the seventh row, both of them arrived without incident.

Pilar waited for the music to stop. “Welcome,” she said, and her voice came out of the speakers soft and clear. “We are here because ten years ago, in this room, on a Tuesday night, two people stood up in front of forty friends and a very nervous caterer and made five promises. They wrote them on the back of a diner menu. I have seen the menu. It has a coffee ring on it. Today Thea and Nolan will say them again, and then they will eat, because Odessa Wynn has informed me that I am not allowed to keep you from the hens.”

A ripple of laughter. Odessa raised her dish towel like a flag.

Thea felt Nolan’s arm go rigid against hers, and then loosen.

“Nolan,” said Pilar. “You asked to go first.”

He turned to face her and took both her hands. His were cold, colder than the heated room explained, so she folded her fingers around his to lend him some heat. Margit’s handkerchief lay in her cuff against her wrist. The planner’s eye never really shut. It ran at the back of the room like a refrigerator, tracking the quartet, the loft stairs, the doors.

“Hi,” he whispered.

“Hi. Breathe through your nose,” she whispered back.

“I’ll tell you the truth,” Nolan said.

His voice was fine. It was the one that had read her the weather forecast in bed for ten years because she liked how he said *isobars*.

“I’ll tell you the truth,” he said again, and stopped.

Somebody in the third row made the small sympathetic sound people make when a groom loses his place. Thea squeezed his hands, one, two, three. She had done this for three hundred and eleven couples: three counts, then a look that said *take your time, nobody here is in a hurry*. She gave him the look.

“Whenever you’re ready,” Pilar murmured. She had stepped in close to say it, the way she did with every groom who lost his place, near enough that the black capsule on her lapel was a hand’s width from their joined hands.

He was looking at her face, and then he wasn’t, quite. His eyes went somewhere just past it, as if a person were standing behind her, and his mouth opened, and the sound that came out had no word in it. She had heard her husband cry three times in ten years, at a movie about a horse, at the end of a school year, once at a card from a student, and it had never sounded like this. It sounded like something being torn out of a wall.

“Hey,” she said, low. “Hey. You’re early. You have eight seconds, so use them.”

Nolan bent forward until his forehead nearly touched their joined hands. His shoulders were shaking. In the front row Margit half rose out of her chair, handbag in both hands. “Nolika?”

“Leona,” he said.

He said it to the floor, in a whisper meant for no one on earth, a whisper that could not have carried six inches in an open field, and Pilar Duarte was leaning in over his bowed head with a microphone clipped to her lapel because Thea had told her twice she wanted the back row to hear every word.

“Leona,” Nolan said. “I’m sorry. Leona, I’m sorry, I can’t.”

The speakers carried it like a bell.

After that there was only the lake working at the pilings and the cellist, who had not yet lowered her bow.

“Is that in the program?” a woman near the aisle asked her husband.

“Who’s Leona?” That was Mrs. Haskell, from the seventh row, in the stage whisper of someone who stopped hearing herself at seventy.

“Hush,” someone said, and the quiet closed again, worse.

Thea felt the room the way a tongue finds a missing tooth, ninety faces with a hole where the name had been. She knew every name in his life: the department, the neighbors, the boys on his old wrestling team, the woman at the bank who always asked after Biscuit. She went through them in a second and a half, as she would go through a vendor list for a missing deposit. There was no Leona.

Pilar’s hand went to the capsule on her lapel and found it live. “Thea,” she said, barely, and the speakers took that too. “Say the word and I’ll close this.”

“Give me one second.” Thea did not look at her. Isla’s face had gone like a screen switched off at the wall, Jonas was studying his own hands, and Margit stood with her mouth open on a word she had not decided on. “Nolan.”

He looked up, and she had never seen his face with nothing in front of it, no joke ready and no shrug, only red eyes and a mouth that would not hold still. He looked at her, a woman he had known eleven years, as if she were standing on the far shore of the lake.

“I’m going to let go of your hands now,” she said.

She said it gently, in the voice she used to tell a bride it was time to step into the hallway. She did. His hands stayed where they were a second, curved around nothing, and then fell.

She picked up her bouquet from the chair, white anemones and the wider wrap, and set it down on Margit’s empty seat. “Eat something,” she told her mother-in-law quietly, because she had to say something and it was the only thing in her head. Margit’s eyes, black and horrified, came up to hers. “Thea,” Margit said. “Thea, *kicsim*—”

Thea turned to the room.

Ninety people looked back at her. An audience was a set of exits and a set of needs, and she had never flinched at one. She found her ordinary voice, the one she used when a tent was leaking, and it was there, and she was almost grateful.

“Thank you all for coming,” she said. “We’re going to stop here. Dimitra has cars for anyone who needs one, and she’ll be at the door. Dinner is at five. Odessa’s Cornish hens are the best thing I’ve ever served, and I’d hate to see them go to waste, so I hope you’ll stay and eat. The bar is paid for.”

Someone laughed, a terrible, grateful sound, a room being given something to do. Nobody else moved, and she did not smile.

She stepped off the platform and walked up the aisle, forty-one feet from the front row to the doors; she had measured it herself. The runner lay true under her shoes, and her heel did not catch once. “Lovely and straight, dear,” Mrs. Haskell said as she passed the seventh row, as if nothing had happened. Behind her a chair scraped, Margit’s voice rose, and Nolan said something low and broken that she did not turn around to hear.

“I have the doors,” Dimitra said in her ear. “Cars are staged and Odessa has the back row. Just keep walking, and I’ll do everything else.”

At the back Odessa had let the dish towel slide off her shoulder, her face wide open. “Thea. Honey. Who the hell is Leona?”

“Later. Keep the hens warm,” said Thea, and went through the service door.

The corridor behind the boathouse kitchen was the part of the building nobody photographed, all stainless shelving and folded linens, with the walk-in cooler humming to itself like a patient animal. Thea walked as far as the dish pit and stopped with one hand on a steel shelf.

Her earpiece crackled, and Dimitra’s voice came through it, very calm, too calm. “Thea, tell me what you need. Say ‘copy’ if that’s all you’ve got.”

Beside the pit the spare walkie sat in its charger, a small red light on. She took it down. The channel was open, a faint hiss, and she could hear Dimitra breathing a hundred feet away, waiting for her to say what happens next.

Thea held the button down. She had a cue for everything. She stood with the channel open and could not find one.

Chapter 2 — Cornish Hens

There were fourteen bobby pins in the veil, and Thea had found eleven.

She stood at the front window of the studio with both hands in her hair, counting by touch the way she counted chairs at the end of a night. Twelve came out with a small hiss of hair, and she dropped it into the coffee mug on the sill, where the others had each landed with a tick. Haskell's Hardware was dark below her. She had passed its window coming up the stairs: Mrs. Haskell's pyramid of snow shovels, red handles out, put up on the first of November by a woman with a view on the winter.

She had been up here five hours with the overheads off. The streetlight was enough to sort by.

The dress was still on. Thirty-one covered buttons ran down the back, each with its own thread loop, because she had picked it for how it looked from the aisle. She had put brides into dresses for ten years, and at twenty to ten on a Sunday night she could not get herself out of one. She had the seam ripper from the go-bag in her left fist and was reaching behind her with it when boots hit the stairs, two pairs, and a metal tray clanked against the rail. A key turned in the door.

"It's us," Odessa Wynn called. "Don't throw anything."

The overheads came on, and Thea stood in the white glare with one arm bent behind her back like a woman being arrested by her own clothing.

Dimitra was in the doorway in her black work clothes, the coiled wire of her earpiece still hanging from her collar. Behind her Odessa filled the frame in her chef's whites, a foil-covered hotel pan on one forearm and a dish towel over the opposite shoulder, exactly where it had been at the back of the boathouse five and a half hours ago.

"Put it down," Dimitra said.

"It's a seam ripper."

"I know what it is. Desk, and then turn around."

Thea put it on the desk and turned around, because the body remembers a fitting, and faced the sample boards, where the gray-green Hana Vos had rejected four times hung at eye level. Dimitra's fingers started down her spine. She undid buttons the way she did everything, fast, with a click of the tongue for each one.

"Thirty-one," Dimitra said, somewhere around the ninth. "Who picks thirty-one?"

"The camera likes a clean back."

“The camera went home at six.” She clicked her tongue. “Last guest out at nine-ten and every car ran. I stayed until the linens were counted, and they came out even, so that’s a miracle and I’d like it filed as one.”

Odessa set the pan on the cutting table with a crackle of foil and said, to the room, with no windup at all, “Is it a woman?”

Thea looked at the swatches. “It’s a name, and I don’t know it.”

“Names come with women attached.”

“I went through everybody, Odessa, I do it for a living. There’s no Leona.” Her voice came out flat as a call sheet.

It was the first time she had said it aloud. It went into the room and nobody picked it up. Behind her Dimitra’s tongue clicked and went on clicking.

“Okay,” said Odessa. “Okay is what I’ve got. I had a speech in the car. It had a lot of swearing in it. I’ll save it for when it’s useful.”

“How long have you been up here?” Dimitra asked, with a glance at the swatches.

“Five hours.”

“They’re alphabetized. The ribbon drawer is sorted by color.”

“Both were overdue.”

“Sleeves,” Dimitra said. Thea held out her arm, and as the fifth little cuff button came free something white slid out of the crepe and dropped to the floor with no sound at all.

Dimitra picked it up, folded small and creased in a square, the blue hem thread loose at one corner, and held it a second longer than she needed to.

“Margit’s,” Thea said, and put out her hand. “Give it here.”

She zipped it into the front pocket of the go-bag with the safety razors. Biscuit’s dent was still in the canvas where he had lain on it. “I don’t remember taking this out of the net loft.”

“It was on the passenger seat of your car,” Dimitra said. “I put it there.”

“Did I say anything?”

“You said ‘Cars,’ and I said ‘Handled,’ and you drove away like it was a drill.”

The dress went over the clothes rack in a long ivory slump. In the emergency wardrobe Thea found a navy fleece with MORAVEC EVENTS stitched over the heart and a pair of Dimitra’s black trousers, two inches short in the ankle. She put them on and looked down. “I look like I’m wading.”

“You look like staff,” said Odessa, “and staff eats.”

“Report,” Thea said, pulling the fleece across herself where it would not button.

“Sixty-one stayed for dinner and twenty-nine left before the soup.” Dimitra said it to her clipboard, which Thea had not noticed her bring. “I walked them to their cars, and eleven of them cried. I counted, because I count. Bar ran dry at 7:40.”

“I ordered for ninety, Dimitra. I checked it three times.”

“You told sixty-one people the bar was paid for and they believed you,” Dimitra said, turning the page. “A man in a green vest asked what happened. I said family emergency a dozen times, and by the thirteenth I said groom’s nerves, and he said he’d had the same thing at his own. So that’s one satisfied customer.”

“Pilar cut the cake and said it was blessed. Mrs. Haskell had two slices and told me you looked beautiful and walked the aisle the way you walk everything.”

“How’s that?”

“Like it owed you money.” Dimitra clicked the pen. “Nolan left at four-forty with the dog. He apologized to the quartet individually, and the cellist told him it was fine and he said it wasn’t and shook her hand.”

“Did he say anything to you?”

“He said thank you for the chairs.” Dimitra looked at the clipboard. “Margit took the kids home herself. She said to tell you the hens were perfect and to call her.”

“Is that what she said.”

“No. She said call her. I added the hens.”

“Tomorrow,” Thea said. “She’ll have a list for me, and I want to be holding mine first.”

The phone was on the desk, face down, where Odessa must have found it in the go-bag and set it. It had been buzzing since the stairs, a small insect sound against the wood, stopping and starting.

“How many?” Odessa asked from the cutting table.

Thea turned it over and read the screen. “Forty-one missed calls.” The same name ran down it in a column, the one she had kept in her phone for eleven years as *Nolan, Do Not Lose*.

“Voicemail?”

“None. He’s never been able to talk to a beep. Margit at four fifty-two says, *Where are you. Call your mother-in-law*. No question mark.”

“She’s never trusted them,” Odessa said.

“And Pilar, which I did not expect,” Thea said, reading it flat. “*I have the stole and the mic and no opinions. Call me whenever or never. P.*”

“She texts like she’s carving it,” said Dimitra. “You don’t have to answer any of it tonight.”

“I won’t,” Thea said, and turned the phone face down. It began to crawl across the desk, and she put a hand on it until it stopped. “I need a list.”

“On it.” Dimitra tore a sheet off the legal pad and put the pad in front of her, and a pen on the pad, and Thea’s reading glasses on their cord on top of the pen, in a neat stack that made Thea want to put her forehead on the desk. “I’m going back to the boathouse, because the rental company won’t sign until every chair is counted. Ninety guest chairs plus the head table’s eight is ninety-eight on their sheet, and the truck’s at nine Monday.”

“The head table never sat down. Tell them those eight are practically new.”

“They charge by the chair, not by the sitting. I’ll be here at seven, so tell me what you need before I go.”

“A bathroom with a door that locks.”

“You have one, tiny and entirely yours.” Dimitra stood there with the clipboard against her chest, and for once she had nothing shorthand. Then she said, “Odessa,” and Odessa said, “I’m staying,” and Dimitra went.

The studio bathroom was the size of a wedding-cake box. Thea scrubbed her face with the pink cucumber soap until the stylist’s noon work came off in gray streaks. The woman in the mirror had hair in hanks and a long face, and her eyes, when Thea leaned in to check them, were dry. She pulled the last pin out of the veil, number fourteen, from behind her left ear.

When she came out Odessa had unwrapped the foil.

“Fourteen,” Thea said, and held it up. “It was there the whole time. I was counting the wrong side.”

“Ten years of weddings and you can’t find your own ear.”

“I can find anybody’s ear but my own.”

“Sit,” Odessa said. “Eight hens from the head table, plated and never touched, because nobody sat down to them.” She had a fork in each fist, and her face said she wasn’t joking. “I thought, they’re yours, and I don’t know why I thought that, so eat something.”

Rosemary and lemon, and the skin gone dark and glossy at the edges where the apricot had caught. Thea sat at the cutting table in her borrowed

trousers, put on the glasses, cut a piece of breast from the nearest bird and ate it.

It sat in her cheek and would not go down. She held it there until she put the napkin to her lips, took it out, and folded the napkin over it.

Odessa watched the napkin.

“It’s very good.”

“I know it’s good, I made it.” Odessa took the other fork and pulled a leg off a different hen and ate it standing, in three bites, looking at the wall. “Rude not to,” she said, with her mouth full.

Thea pulled the legal pad toward her, pushed up the glasses that had slipped, and wrote 1. and a line.

1. *Chair rental pickup, Mon 9 a.m. truck (90 + the head table’s 8 = 98, count twice).*

2. *Return lav mic and body pack to AV.*

3. *Pay quartet for the full hour, not the twenty minutes.*

4. *Hana Vos: seating chart, rev. 7.*

5. *Call Walter Ames back re: Thursday the 19th.*

6. *Order gaffer tape, white, two cases.*

7. *Oil change, Subaru.*

8. *Descale kettle.*

She capped the pen. Odessa read it over her shoulder, chewing.

“Number eight is a kettle.”

“It’s furred up and you can’t make tea in it.”

“Honey.”

“It’s on the list because it needs doing.” Thea tore the sheet off, squared it against the edge of the desk, and propped it against the lamp. There was nothing on it about the man whose forty-one calls lay under her hand, or the six-foot-three of him sitting in the house on Alder Street with a beagle.

“I could call him,” Odessa said. “I wouldn’t say anything. I’d just breathe.”

“He’d know it was you.”

“Everybody knows it’s me. It’s my best quality.” She was turning the couch cushion over. “You want the couch?”

“You take it, I’ll sit up.”

“I’ll take it because I’m not a fool, and you’ll sit up for twenty minutes and then lie down on the floor in your coat, so I’m leaving you the blanket.” She kicked off her clogs. The couch was a green velvet one Thea had bought for

brides to cry on, and it received Odessa's whole length without complaint. "I texted my husband, who has the van, and he had some things to say about Nolan."

"Please don't repeat them."

"Wouldn't dream of it, they were creative."

The radiator ticked and the streetlight laid its orange stripe across the floor. Odessa's breathing slowed. Thea turned the lamp low and sat in the dark with the foil tray going cold at her elbow, and did nothing at all for what the clock said was an hour.

The phone lit once under her hand.

She turned it over. It was one text, from Nolan, and for once there was no column of calls behind it.

I'm at the house. I'm not asking you to come home. Biscuit's fine.

She read it twice. She read the dog's name. Her thumb hung over the empty box while the cursor pulsed, and after a while the screen dimmed and went black and showed her a woman in a navy fleece with her glasses on.

She set the phone down and reached for the lamp.

"Leave it on," Odessa said from the couch, not opening her eyes.

Thea took her hand off the switch.

Chapter 3 — Department Meeting

“Chairs, linens, the cake stand, the guest book, and somebody’s good scarf, which I am holding for ransom,” Dimitra said from the doorway, reading it off her phone. She had one arm in her coat and the other still hunting for the sleeve. “Truck’s at the boathouse at nine. I’ll be there until one.”

“Count the chairs onto the truck.”

“I counted them going in. Ninety-eight with the head table. You squared them yourself.” Dimitra found the sleeve. “What do I tell the florist about the anemones?”

“Nursing home on Third. Tell her to leave them off the invoice.”

“And you’ll be here all day.”

“I’ll be here all day.”

“Doing what, if I may ask?”

“Work, and the Vos seating chart.”

“Mm,” said Dimitra. Downstairs the bell over Haskell’s Hardware rang for somebody buying something made of iron. From the stairs she called, “If you want to know who she is, I’m very good. I once found a florist’s husband’s second family in forty minutes.”

“No, but thank you for the florist’s husband.”

“I’m only saying I have skills.”

“You do. I don’t outsource facts.”

When the street door had banged, Thea sat down at the big monitor and opened the family calendar.

She had built it herself, the winter Margit got her first smartphone and began calling to ask whether an appointment on a screen was a real appointment. Thea was teal, Margit plum, Isla orange, and Jonas a blue he had picked from a paint chip with great ceremony. Tuesday dinners cut a plum stripe across every week, and Biscuit’s heartworm pill on the first of the month repeated there, never once missed. Nobody in the family could find a dentist without it.

Thursdays were green.

She clicked the nearest one. *Dept mtg. 6:00 to 9:00 p.m. Repeats weekly. No end date.* Under it, in the gray type nobody reads: *Created by Nolan Moravec, Nov 16, 2023.*

The funeral had been the twenty-eighth of October. She did the subtraction twice, as if it might come out different. “Nineteen days,” she told the monitor.

She scrolled back and the green block went on ahead of her like a fence line, every Thursday for three years. Three had been struck out of the series, and she could account for each: the flu, twice, when she had made soup, and one parent-teacher evening when she drove a thermos to his classroom herself and watched him eat a quarter of a sandwich standing up.

Her phone buzzed on the blotter. Dimitra, from the boathouse, with gulls behind her.

“The rental man wants your signature on the damage waiver. I told him Thursday, because Thursday’s the one night you’re up here and not answering the door.”

“Thursday’s fine. Tell him Thursday.”

“I told him you do the books Thursdays. He said, who does the books on a Thursday night? I said Thea, obviously. He said, and I quote, ‘On purpose?’”

“It was a schedule.” Thea looked at the green block, three days off, six to nine. “Nolan is out on Thursdays, and the bungalow is empty and the studio isn’t, so I did the books.”

“Huh,” said Dimitra, who seemed to be walking. “Are you okay up there, by the way?”

“I’m just reading a calendar.”

“Is it a good one?”

“It’s color-coded, and I built it myself.”

“Then it’s perfect, and I’m sorry. Seventy-one chairs on the truck so far, and I’m counting the other twenty-seven twice. Thursday it is, then. Eat something.”

Thea put the phone down. She had written his absence into her own week the way she wrote in a load-in time, and a calendar was where she kept what was true.

She pulled the legal pad toward her and wrote *THURS* and then nothing after it.

• • •

She reconciled the joint account on the first Sunday of every month, and had for nine years, in a spreadsheet with a column labeled *Category* that was entirely hers. She pulled the export and filtered by the word *church*, because it was the only word she had.

One line came back: *ST BRENDAN PARISH HALL COFFEE FND.*, five dollars even, every Thursday since November 2023.

She counted the rows twice. A hundred and fifty-two, seven hundred and sixty dollars, about what she had once spent on an ice sculpture of a swan. In the one cell she had ever typed into, the Category said *Donations*. The spreadsheet had filled in the other hundred and fifty-one without asking her.

For about four seconds she thought of a church basement with an urn and a sign-in sheet. Nolan had one beer at Christmas and left half of it. The thought would not sit on anything she knew, and she set it down like a chair that rocks.

Burnt coffee on his collar. She had been proud of him for putting up with a department that couldn't make decent coffee.

At 2:55 she called Gus Pelletier, who had bus duty on Mondays, because a man on a curb with a whistle couldn't think too carefully.

Behind him she heard diesel and about four hundred teenagers. "Hold on, hold on. Walk! Nobody's leaving without you, walk." A whistle blast, and then, lower: "Thea."

"You said that like you've been practicing it, Gus."

"Since yesterday. Are you okay?"

"I'm fine, and I need a small favor. It's logistical." Her voice went bright and she let it. "I'm sending the department a thank-you for putting up with Nolan this fall. I'd like it to land on a day when you're all in the room. What time does the Thursday meeting actually start?"

The buses went on without him.

"Gus?"

"Thea." The whistle was out of his mouth now. "There's no Thursday meeting."

"The department meets Thursdays."

"We went to email the fall Callum died. By November. Nobody's had a Thursday meeting since, not me, not anybody." He cleared his throat. "I'm sorry. I thought you knew. I mean, I didn't think you knew, I thought..."

She wrote on the legal pad in block capitals, the way she would write *NO LOADING DOCK ACCESS. NO THURSDAY MTG.*

"You texted me last March," Gus said. "You asked if the meeting was running long, his phone was off. I said yep, you know how it is. He'd asked me to, a few days before. If Thea ever asks. I didn't ask him why."

"I remember that text." She remembered what she had sent back, too, which was a thumbs-up.

"I figured it was a woman. I figured it was none of my business, and I'm sorry. He's looked gray since the fall, Thea. I thought it was Callum."

“So did I.”

“Do you want me to say something to him?”

“No, please don’t. Thank you, Gus, that’s what I needed.”

“Are you sure you’re okay? Are you...”

“I have a client at three.”

She didn’t have one. She set the phone on the blotter and looked at it as if it were an invoice with a number on it she disagreed with. Then she wrote *Gus: March, one text, one cover* under the first line and drew a box around it.

• • •

The name was next, and she had only the one word, which she gave to every system she owned.

The guest list for Sunday held two Leonards and no Leona. The Moravec Events client database, three hundred and eleven weddings deep, returned one Leona, a bride’s great-aunt from 2019. “Requested the chicken,” Thea read off the file. The school staff page, no. The parish directory, no. She typed *Leona Port Ellery Michigan* and got a realtor in Marquette and a 2011 obituary for a woman of ninety-four. “Come on,” she told the search bar. “Somebody has to be her.”

She had circled LEONA on the pad three times when Dimitra came back at four with a bag of lemons and a face that said she had been briefed on nothing. Dimitra looked at the pad and set the lemons on the filing cabinet.

“Nobody asked for lemons,” Thea said.

“Nobody asked for ninety-eight chairs, either, and here we are. Have you eaten?”

“I had coffee.”

“That’s a beverage.” Dimitra took her coat off and put it back on. “I have vendor calls. In the back.”

“Thank you.”

“With the door shut.”

“That’s... yes.”

“Take your time,” Dimitra said, very gently, and shut it.

• • •

By six the windows had gone to black glass and the lamps on Water Street had come on one after another like a cue list.

“Go home,” Thea said, handing over a tray of lemon bars from the client fridge. “Don’t come in before nine.”

“I brought you lemons and you’re sending me away with lemon bars.”

“That’s what a trade looks like.”

“You’ll call if you need me.”

“I’ll call if the building’s on fire.”

“Is it on fire?”

“Not yet. Go home, Dimitra.”

When Dimitra had gone, Thea read the legal pad over, two pages now, like a call sheet for an event that had already happened.

At 6:40 the third stair creaked.

It was the only one that did. Mrs. Haskell, who owned the building, had been promising to oil it since 1994. Thea knew that weight from two hundred climbs, carrying lunch in a paper bag and once, memorably, a lamp.

Two quick taps, and a pause.

Through the frosted glass she saw a large dark shape and, across its chest, the gold letters of MORAVEC EVENTS, backward, and she opened the door.

Nolan stood on the landing with his shoes on the edge of the mat, in the gray fleece he wore to grade papers. His face was swollen around the eyes and shaved too closely, as if somebody had told him to make an effort and he’d done it with the wrong hand. In his left fist was Biscuit’s red leash, looped in thirds, clip on top.

She checked the set out of habit: one door, one landing, one stair, and the two of them in the only way out.

“Hi,” he said.

“Hi.”

“I’m not coming in.”

“I didn’t ask you to.”

“I know. I wanted to say it first, so you wouldn’t have to. I got past Mrs. Haskell. She says she’s not on anybody’s side, she’s on the side of the hardware. I think that’s a good policy.”

“It’s her policy for everything. Did she try to sell you a shovel?”

“She tried. It’s November. I said I’d think about it.”

“Where’s Biscuit?”

“In the car with the heat on. He’s got the window.”

“My mother’s called me twelve times,” he said then, as if it followed.

“She’s called me nine.”

“What do you tell her?”

“I tell her I’ll call back.” Thea kept her hand on the door. She had been bracing since the boathouse for the confession with a beginning and an end, and he stood there with the leash in his fist and did not make it. “Say whatever you came to say, Nolan.”

“Ask me anything.” It came out all at once, short. He had gone to short sentences, the way he always did when it was real. “Anything you want, whenever, and I’ll tell you. Not tonight.”

“Why not tonight?”

“Because I’ll fall apart. And then you’ll have to manage it.” His eyes came up to hers. “You’d get me a chair. You’d get me water. I don’t want you to have to do that.”

She had been about to ask. The list she’d printed in block capitals all afternoon rose in her, *who is she, how long, where*, and out came:

“Then don’t.”

It went into him like a nail into drywall. He took it as a ruling, and a reasonable one.

“That’s fair,” he said.

He didn’t move, and neither did she.

“Did you eat today?”

“Go home, Nolan.”

“That’s a no.”

“It’s a go home.”

“I’ll tell Biscuit you said hi.”

“Tell him to leave the mail alone.”

“He doesn’t listen to me, either.”

He turned and went down. The stairs took his weight, the third one giving its single complaint. She heard the street door. She did not hear it close, because he held it, the way he always held it, so that it would not bang.

She shut her own door. Her hand came off the knob and brushed nylon.

The leash hung over the outside knob, red, clip on top. She hadn’t seen him hang it, and she had watched his hands the whole time. She took it down and found it warm from his fist.

“If I want the dog, I say so,” she told the empty studio, and held the leash up as if it might argue. He would be at the foot of the stairs in ten minutes with Biscuit under his arm. She did not pick up her phone.

She went to the window with the leash wound once around her hand.

The CR-V idled at the curb, then at the corner its brake lights held, and the beagle looked back up at her light.

Chapter 4 — The Price of It

“Initial where the yellow tabs are,” Bernadette Roy said, “and sign at the bottom. It isn’t the engagement letter. It only says we’ve met.”

Thea put on her reading glasses and read the whole page. She read everything; once she had found a clause in a tent contract that made the client liable for rain. The form was one paragraph saying that nothing she told Bernadette would leave the room, and she initialed it four times.

“You read it,” said Bernadette.

“I read everything.”

“Most people don’t. They sign wherever there’s a tab and then call me at midnight about page six.” She took the form back, squared it against a legal pad, and capped her pen. She was fifty-four, with gray hair cut short enough to ignore, a putty-colored cardigan, and the kind of voice that arrives at the end of a sentence on purpose. Her office was the second floor of a brick building across from the county courthouse, and behind her the window held the courthouse’s side door and a man smoking beside it.

Thea had taken in the room in the first four seconds, from habit. One client chair, angled toward the window and away from the door, so you would not watch yourself leave. A clock on the wall behind the client’s head, where only Bernadette could see it. Thea would have set it up the same way.

“I heard about Sunday,” Bernadette said.

“Everyone did.”

“I don’t need Sunday. I don’t need how it felt. I need what you know, in the order you know it, and I need you to leave out the adjectives. Go.”

Thea used the voice she kept for a vendor who had lost a deposit. “Every Thursday for three years, six to nine, he’s had a department meeting. It’s on the family calendar; I built the calendar. A colleague of his told me yesterday there hasn’t been a Thursday meeting since the fall his brother died. The joint account shows five dollars every Thursday to the St. Brendan’s parish hall coffee fund, about a hundred and fifty rows if you scroll back. And at the ceremony he said a name into a lavalier microphone, twice, with an apology.”

“A name.”

“Leona. No last name. I looked.”

“For how long?”

“Four hours, Monday afternoon. There’s a Leona at a dental practice in Tucson and a Leona who sells soap.”

“The microphone,” Bernadette said. “Whose idea was the microphone?”

“Mine. I wanted the back row to hear.”

“Of course you did.” Bernadette wrote something down. It was one word, and Thea could not read it upside down. “Do you know whether it’s physical?”

“No.”

“Does the answer change what you’re about to ask me?”

“I don’t know.”

“Then we proceed on what we know, which is nothing about her. Ask.”

Thea had practiced it in the car, with the radio off and again with it on, and she had a version with a preamble. What came out had no preamble.

“What does a divorce cost?”

It came out in her work voice, the one that said *what does the upgrade cost* and *what’s the overage on the linens*, and the word sat in the room just as flat as those had. It sounded like a line item.

Bernadette only turned a page on the legal pad. “Good. That’s the hardest word in the file. The rest is arithmetic. Children?”

“No.”

“Michigan is no-fault. You say the marriage has broken down and there’s no reasonable likelihood it can be preserved. You don’t have to prove anything about Thursdays. With no minor children, the waiting period is sixty days from filing.”

“Sixty days.”

“That’s the floor. Nobody lands on the floor. Figure three months if you both behave and a year if one of you doesn’t.” She tapped the pad with her pen. “The house on Alder Street. Whose name?”

“Both. We bought it in 2018.”

“Then it’s both. Michigan doesn’t do fifty-fifty by statute, it does fair by a judge, and fair usually lands near half. You’d either sell it or one of you buys the other out. I’d want an appraisal. The studio?”

“Mine.” It came out faster than she meant. “Moravec Events was a going concern for three years before I met him. The LLC is in my name and so is the lease, upstairs from Haskell’s Hardware. I pay Mrs. Haskell on the first.”

“Then it starts out yours, on what you’ve told me, and I’d like to see the paper before I say more than that. Formation documents, the lease, ten years of returns, and anything that ever moved between the business and the joint account in either direction. A business you owned before the marriage can still grow during it, and growth can be argued over. So can money that crossed.”

She wrote again. "From today, business money stays in the business account. Not a dollar crosses to the joint one, not even to cover a bill."

"He won't make a claim."

"People surprise me every week," said Bernadette. "Not usually pleasantly. I don't promise outcomes in the first hour, Thea. I promise to read everything." She turned the pad toward Thea, a column of figures in a hand so even it might have been typed. "Retainer is thirty-five hundred. Uncontested, with a house to split and no children, you're looking at six to nine thousand all in, and three months. Contested is double that and the better part of a year, and I'd advise you not to enjoy it."

Thea read the column through her glasses twice. The numbers were smaller than she had braced for.

"That's it?"

"In dollars, yes. In weeks, yes. Those are the two things I can bill." Bernadette took her own glasses off and held them by one arm. "Now the question I ask everyone. Answer it or not. Do you want to leave him, or do you want to stop being the last to know?"

A radiator ticked under the window. Outside, the man by the courthouse door dropped his cigarette and stepped on it.

"Those cost different amounts," Thea said.

"They do. One of them is cheaper."

"Which?"

"I won't tell you that. I'm not paid to." She said it without unkindness. "People come in here sure it's the first and discover it's the second, and the other way around. The first one I can do with forms. The second one I can't do at all."

"I didn't ask you for the second one."

"No. You asked what it costs. I'm telling you the other question is an honest one, and nobody has asked it yet." She slid a second sheet across the desk. "Here's what I do want. Nothing impulsive. No texts you'd read aloud in front of a judge. Don't move money out of the joint account and don't empty it, either. He has the same right to it you do; you don't lock him out of it, you watch it. Turn on every alert the bank offers. Anything that's yours alone, your email, the business, change those passwords today. And that calendar you built. Keep a record, a paper notebook, not on a device, dates and what was said. Post nothing. Sign nothing he sends you, however nicely. And if the other woman reaches out, don't answer."

"I don't have her number."

"Good. Keep it that way. Who knows you're here?"

"Nobody. Dimitra thinks I'm at the dentist."

"Does she believe it?"

"She believes anything with a time on it. I told her ten-fifteen."

"Keep it a dentist for a week or so. This is a small town, and I've watched a lawyer's parking spot do more damage than the lawyer. Your husband will hear you saw someone, from somebody who means well. I'd rather he hear it from you, in your own order, when you've chosen one."

"I haven't chosen anything."

"Then it's still a dentist."

Thea wrote *notebook* on her own pad, on the line under *passwords*. Her handwriting was small and square, a planner's hand, the same as any other day. She kept writing anyway.

"There's a family," she said.

"You said no children."

"Mine, no. His brother died three years ago. Cardiac, he was thirty-four. He left two kids, sixteen and thirteen, and their mother lives in Portugal and comes twice a year. My husband's mother is sixty-eight and hasn't been alone in a room on a holiday in a decade, because I host. Thanksgiving, Christmas Eve, Easter. I keep a binder. Thanksgiving is sixteen days from now. I don't know what happens to them."

"What would you like to happen to them?"

"I'd like someone to tell me what the court says."

"The court says nothing about them. You aren't their guardian and you aren't a party to anything they own." Bernadette had put her glasses back on, which made her look more tired, not less. "That's not a legal question, Thea."

"It's the only one on my list I have no plan for."

"Then it's the one to look at first. I can tell you what a divorce costs in dollars. I can't tell you what happens to a family when one person stops coming to dinner."

Thea took her glasses off, and the cord swung against her chest. Across the street the courthouse door opened and a woman in a blue blazer came out hugging a banker's box and stood on the step looking at the sky.

"Do I sign the retainer?"

"Not today. You've been awake since Sunday. Come back when you've slept or decided, and I'll bill you for this hour regardless." Bernadette stood

and held out her hand, which was dry and let go on time. “Call before you come. I’m booked through Friday.”

• • •

The Subaru was parked two blocks over in front of a bakery with a Thanksgiving-pie sign in the window. Thea got in, shut the door, and sat with her hands at ten and two, not starting the engine.

She did the passwords first, because they were a list and a list could be finished. Her email, the business accounts, alerts on the joint account for anything over fifty dollars, and the calendar she had built in a weekend three years ago on a laptop in the car outside Margit’s house with the heat running. Every Thursday on it was a thin green stripe. She changed the password and logged out every device she could find, and a small window said *4 sessions ended*. One was his phone and one was the CR-V. She had not known the car was on the calendar.

Then there was nothing else on the list.

She tried the rest the way she would try a budget. The bungalow: half, or the whole thing less a number. The studio and the Subaru were hers, and so, obviously, was the go-bag in the back. She could have it itemized by lunch. Then, without her asking, the other column started up, the one with no dollar signs, and it did not come as a list.

Margit’s kitchen seated nine. She had counted it once, the first Christmas, with a tape measure while Margit watched with her arms folded. Nine chairs, the ninth a piano bench. On Tuesdays it was five, six if Jonas brought a friend, and the plates came out in the same order every week and Thea sat in the same chair. Nobody had assigned it. She had never assigned anything; she had only been there on Tuesdays, with a dish in her hands, long enough that the dish had become a seat.

Then Isla’s essays: a laptop open on the Alder Street kitchen table on Sundays, a sixteen-year-old with her feet up on the second chair, saying *don’t be nice* and then reading Thea’s red pen as if it were weather. They had done four drafts, and the fourth was about a goalkeeper’s gloves.

She sat with that.

It was an ordinary Tuesday on Water Street. Somebody came out of the bakery with a pie held flat in both hands, the way you carry something you are afraid to tilt. A bus went by, and the rear-view mirror gave her back her own

face, gray at the temples now, the mark of her glasses still pressed across the bridge of her nose.

Divorce, she said, to nobody, to the windshield.

It sounded exactly as it had in the office. It sounded like a thing that could be done by a Friday.

The phone buzzed in the cup holder. She did not want it to be Margit, and it was not; she was reading the preview before she had decided to.

Dimitra: Hana's florist just called. Short forty stems on the white ranunculus, the ones in the bridal bouquet and the arch. She's offering cream. Do we fight her?

Her mouth, she found, had gone to a shape it hadn't held in two days. She started the engine and checked the mirror, and the florist's cream stems rose up in her head, a pale, apologetic color, wrong for the arch by exactly one shade. She had stood in Hana Vos's living room and been shown the swatch. Hana had held it up beside a ranunculus and said nothing for a full minute.

She typed with her thumb, still parked, and sent it before she could improve it.

Fight.

Chapter 5 — The Thursday Table

The door at the foot of the stairs was propped open with a folding chair, and that told Thea three things before she looked past it. Somebody expected latecomers and did not want a door shutting behind anyone. Somebody had done this often enough to stop apologizing for the chair.

She stood on the bottom step at six twenty-five with her keys in her fist. Up on the church lawn a sandwich board had said GRIEF CIRCLE, THURSDAYS 6:30, SIDE DOOR DOWNSTAIRS, COFFEE, YOU DON'T HAVE TO TALK in marker, by a person who had never been taught about margins. She had driven here with a woman in her head, a hotel bar or a flat in a good building, and the sandwich board had not been in any of those versions.

Then the smell came up the stairwell and found her: burnt coffee, an urn left on its warming plate since breakfast. It was in last Thursday's shirt, and the Thursday before. She had assumed a fundraiser.

The room was what a church basement is: water-stained ceiling tile, linoleum the yellow-gray of old piano keys, a fluorescent tube stuttering above the radiator. Twelve brown folding chairs stood in a ring, PROPERTY OF ST. BRENDAN'S stenciled on every seat back. On a card table the forty-cup urn had shortbread at one end and saltines at the other, as though whoever had been told to bring something had not known what grief required. In the exact center of the ring, on a stool, sat a box of tissues with one pulled up into a peak. She would have put it on a side table, but someone had decided that every eye landing on it was kinder.

Nine people were in the ring already, and none of them turned around. The tallest sat with his back to the wall. He stood, and it took a while: thin, past seventy, a wheat-colored cardigan buttoned one hole off, reading glasses pushed up into white hair. He crossed the linoleum to her without a glance at the clock.

"You must be Thea," he said.

Her mouth was already open on the speech she had rehearsed in the Subaru. *I'm so sorry to intrude, I think there's been a misunderstanding.* It had a second clause, which went away.

"Who told you?"

"Nolan did. He said if you ever came, you would be five minutes early and you would sit by the door." His voice was slow and deep and had no edges on it. "It is six twenty-five."

"He told you what I'd do."

“He told me what you were like. I am Abel, and he has not come since last Thursday. Would you like to be introduced to the room, or would you like to be a chair?”

“A chair.”

“Good, then that one.” He tipped his head toward a seat by the coat rack, a yard behind the edge of the ring, where she could see all of them and they would have to turn to see her. “We leave it for the person who is not sure. You may talk or not. Most people do not, the first night.”

“And the fortieth?”

“Some do not, the fortieth.”

“Which chair is his?”

“The one by the radiator. Nobody has taken it this week.” He went back to his place.

She had sat in the back row of every room she had ever worked, because that was where the doors were. This room had no back, only the ring and the one chair outside it, and she sat in that chair with her coat on and her keys in her hand while the clock above the door moved to six-thirty.

Nobody said welcome and nobody read from a card. She waited for the cue, and none came. She had never allowed forty seconds of nothing in a run-of-show, and her whole body leaned toward the front of the room to fix it. Nobody was looking at the exit; every gaze rested on the middle of the floor. Only the woman across the ring, in a navy fleece with a lanyard tucked into the zip and her hair in a clip going gray at one temple, looked at her, once and steadily, before she looked down.

“I found Carol’s glasses,” said a man in a quilted vest.

He was seventy-something, with enormous hands that he held out as if he had been asked to show he wasn’t carrying anything.

“Harold,” said Abel, mildly. “Go on.”

“In the door pocket of the Buick. Third time I’ve cleaned out that pocket since March, and there they were, the tortoiseshell ones. She looked for them four months. She’d say, Harold, have you seen my glasses, and I’d say, Carol, they’re on your head, and they never once were.” He turned the hands over. “I stood in the driveway twenty minutes. I thought, I’ll go in and tell her. I had my hand on the storm door.”

“What did you want to tell her?” Abel asked.

“That I found them.” Harold’s hands closed and opened. “That she was right. They were never on her head.” Then, lower: “I put them on her side of the bed, by the lamp.” He laughed, and there was no breath in it.

The woman beside him slid the tissue box off the stool and onto his knee without looking at him.

Thea wound the cord of her reading glasses twice around her finger until the tip went white, and unwound it. She had four suggestions ready by the time Harold stopped, and she kept them.

“I bought two of everything again,” said a woman in a Michigan State sweatshirt. “Two milks, two of the good bread. I stood in the aisle and I could not put one back.”

Abel said “Mm,” and nothing else was done about it.

“I can’t take the truck out of the driveway,” said a boy of about twenty. “I get to the end and I put it in park.”

A man said he did not have anything tonight, and Abel said, “Then you have said it,” and the man’s shoulders came down an inch. Thea listened to the end of each sentence, because nobody was going to interrupt it.

At eight o’clock the clock said so and Abel said, “We will stop there. Thank you for staying.”

That was the end, with no closing remarks. They stood the way people stand in a hospital corridor, carefully, and Harold folded his chair and leaned it on the rack.

“Coffee’s terrible,” he told Thea on his way past, buttoning the quilted vest. “Nobody says so, and it’s the one thing we all agree on.”

Nobody hugged, and the woman in the fleece took her coat from a hook and went up the stairs without looking back, slowly enough to give someone time to follow.

At the coat rack Abel was beside her again, his arms folded into the cardigan.

“One question. You do not have to answer it.”

“Go on.”

“If he had told you, the first Thursday, where he was going,” Abel said. “What would you have done?”

She opened her mouth, and the urn ticked as it cooled. She wound her scarf around her neck twice and tucked the end under, slowly, for something to do.

“Good night, Abel,” she said.

“Good night. The door will be open.”

• • •

The cold in the lot came off the lake. The Subaru sat in the second row, nose out, the go-bag lying in the back, and she had not yet unlocked it when footsteps came across the gravel.

“Thea.”

Up close the woman was older than she had looked in the ring, forty or so, and tired in a way that predated today. The lanyard had come out of the fleece: a pharmacy badge, the photo turned in.

“I’m Leona,” she said. “Would you sit in my car? It’s warmer, and I’d rather do this sitting down.”

“I’ll stand.”

“You’ve been sitting for an hour and a half.” The woman said it without any edge. “I’d say you’re due.”

It was a green Forester, parked three spaces from the door, and clean in the way of a car that belongs to someone with a nine-year-old and no time: a child’s glove on the dash, a travel mug in the cup holder. Thea got into the passenger seat because there was no good reason not to, and found it run back on its track as far as it would go. She was five-ten, and it had not been adjusted for her.

“The lever’s under the front edge,” Leona said. “You can move it.”

“I’m fine.”

“You can put those down, you know,” Leona said, of the keys.

“I’ll hold them.” She left the lever alone too. Leona got in on the other side and put both hands on the wheel without starting the engine, looking through the windshield at the basement door.

“Do you want me to say it,” she said, “or do you want to ask?”

“Ask what?”

“Whatever you came to. You drove here in a good coat and sat by the door for ninety minutes and never unbuttoned it. You came with a question.”

“I came to see the woman.”

“And you’ve seen a dozen strangers and a coffee urn.”

“Eight,” said Thea. “Nine with you.”

Leona gave her travel mug a quarter turn in its holder. “Nine, yes.” Her eyes were gray and exact, red at the rims. “He told me about you every

Thursday for two years and more. I want you to know that first. It isn't a gift, it's just the case."

"He told you about me."

"About the funeral you ran." She took a breath. "Callum's."

She said it flat, as if reading a name off a label, and Thea felt it arrive in her chest like a hand laid there. She had last seen that name in her own sixteen-point type on the cover of a program.

"Six days," Leona went on. "Two hundred and some people. A slideshow you cut together yourself. A florist who cried, so you replaced her with one who didn't. And he stood in the receiving line for four hours and said *I'm fine* to every single person who came through, and you were beside him the whole time with a clipboard." More quietly: "He told it like he was proud of you. He'd get all the way through the list and then he'd just stop talking."

"He never said that to me."

"I'm sorry for that part too."

"I got a department meeting. Six to nine."

"I know what you got."

The heater was off and the glass had begun to fog. Thea's eyes went to the glove on the dash.

"Did you sleep with my husband?"

She asked it level, in the tone she kept for invoice disputes.

"No," said Leona.

"That's what you'd say."

"Yes, it is." There was no hurry in it. "It's also what happened."

"Then what happened?"

"I let him sit in this car." Leona's hands were still on the wheel. "Thursdays, after, an hour or sometimes two. That's worse, in a way you'll decide for yourself."

"Worse than what?"

"Than a hotel. A hotel is something you can point at."

Thea made a sound through her nose that might, in a different week, have been a laugh. "Why?"

"Because he was the only one in that room who never tried to make me feel better." The answer was ready, which meant she had been asked it, probably by herself. "My husband died in February and I had a six-year-old at home who needed me to be fine, and I'd never in my life been so tired. And Nolan was fine in front of everyone and then in the lot he wasn't, and he didn't

need me to do anything about it. Neither of us needed the other to do anything. I thought that made it safe.” She looked at Thea at last. “I’m a pharmacist. I spend my days telling people how much is too much and when to stop. I know what a slow overdose looks like. I didn’t stop him, and I didn’t stop me.”

“Why tell me any of it?” said Thea.

“Because you came. And because if you drive home with nothing but a coffee urn, you’ll build the rest yourself. I know what people build out of a car and a closed door.

“There’s more than the car. Ask him. It has to come from him, all of it, in order. I won’t hand you a piece at a time in a parking lot.”

“I’m asking you.”

“The answer’s the same.” She closed her eyes for two seconds. When she opened them they were steadier. “One more thing, and then you can go. I told him to bring you. Eleven months ago.”

Thea sat still.

“December, in this seat. I said, *Bring Thea*. He said he would. He said it so many times that I—” She stopped, and made herself start again at a different place. “I told him, that’s all. I’m not asking you to like me. I’m not asking for anything.”

“Good,” said Thea. “I haven’t got any.”

December was Margit’s Christmas Eve, which Thea had run from a laminated schedule taped inside the cabinet door: ham at four, the kids’ gifts at six-thirty, coffee at eight. Nolan had carved, thin even slices fanned on the platter, and everyone had said how well he looked.

She found the door handle.

“Thea,” said Leona. “He doesn’t know I’m saying any of this.”

“Then that makes two of us who don’t know what we’re doing.” She got out and shut the door with care, because a slam is a performance and she was done performing for the evening. Then she bent to the glass, and the woman inside looked back at her, small and gray under the dome light, and Thea said, in the tone she used to close out an invoice, “Thank you for your time.”

Leona took it without looking at it.

Thea straightened and turned toward her own car, and there was the CR-V.

It sat at the far edge of the lot beside the chain-link fence, past the last light pole: a gray shape, headlamps off, engine running, a thread of exhaust standing straight up in the cold. It had not been there at six twenty-five; she had scanned every vehicle in the lot before going down. It was nose out,

facing the basement door, because he always backed in. She had told him once it was the only exit strategy he'd ever had, and he had said it was physics, it was easier to drive forward than to reverse out, and they had both laughed in the parking lot of a Kroger.

She crossed the gravel counting, because counting gave her legs something to do, and her shoes had gone loud on the stones by sixty-one.

He saw her at about forty, and she watched his shape in the driver's seat go still. When she got to the door his hands were on the wheel at ten and two and his face in the glow off the dash was wet and swollen at the eyes, a face that had been at it a while. His mouth moved, and the glass took it. His hand went to the window button, and she shook her head, and the hand went back to the wheel.

The passenger door was four steps away, and she knew the seat behind it was hers. She did not take the four steps.

She bent until her mouth was a hand's width from the glass and used the voice she gave cues in over a headset, low and level, built to carry through a pane and no further.

"Studio," she said. "Tomorrow night at nine. Bring all of it. The small ones too."

Chapter 6 — The Facts

Thea carried the last folding chair to the brick wall, stacked it on the others, and wiped her hands down her trousers.

That left the green one. It was dark leather with brass tacks, bought out of an estate sale in Holland the year she opened the studio, and couples sat in it to hear the price while fathers sat in it to avoid hearing it. She had set it eight feet from her desk with its back to the brick, so that whoever took it would look straight down the room at the frosted glass of the door and the stairs behind.

Downstairs, Haskell's Hardware had closed at six, and the neon sign out front buzzed through the window and laid a red stripe across the floorboards. Over the evening it had crept from the stacked chairs to the foot of the green one. She squared the corkboard of Hana Vos's swatches, where sage and oyster sat beside a gray Hana called fog that was exactly the gray of the lake, and took a yellow legal pad from the drawer and set it on the desk, and then moved it to her knee.

At 8:58 she stopped fussing with things.

The knock was two taps and a pause.

"It's open."

He opened the door the way you open a door on a room where somebody is sleeping. He was still in what he had taught in, a gray sweater and brown cords with chalk on the thigh, as if he had sat in them all evening waiting, the lanyard still around his neck with PORT ELLERY HIGH on it and his own face laminated at the bottom, six years younger. He had shaved and missed a stripe under the left side of his chin.

"You said nine," he said.

"It's nine."

"I've been in the lot since eight-fifteen."

"Of course you have."

He took that where it landed. He lifted the lanyard over his head and stood holding it, a man with nowhere to put a lanyard, and looked at the stacked chairs and then at the green one set out alone on the boards like a witness stand.

"I thought about bringing a pie," he said. "Then I thought, that's a bribe."

"It is a bribe."

"So I brought nothing, and I had a speech in the car, a good one with a structure." He rubbed the back of his neck. "It died at the bottom of the stairs."

"Sit."

He sat, and the leather took his weight with a long sigh. He was too big for it, with his knees up and the lanyard across one of them, and he looked down the length of the room at the door. "You put me facing the door."

"Yes."

"So I can see it."

"So you can see it."

He considered that with his head tilted, the way he did with a student who had given the right answer for what he privately thought was the wrong reason. "That's fair."

"Here's how this goes," Thea said, and clicked the pen. It was a second one, from the drawer, since the one in her hair was staying where it was, and she held it above the pad. "I ask and you answer. You start at the funeral and go in order, and you don't leave out the parts that make you look bad, because I'll find them. Gus took me one phone call."

"Gus called me."

"I'm sure he did."

He looked at the lanyard. "He covered for me once, in March. I asked him to say we'd been in a meeting if you called, and he said fine, and I don't think he knew what he was agreeing to."

"He thought you had a woman."

"Yes."

"So did I." The pen touched the paper. "Dates."

"The funeral was Saturday, October twenty-eighth."

"I know when the funeral was, since I ran it."

"I'm starting there because it starts there." His hands lay open on his thighs, and he kept looking at them as if somebody had lent them to him. "The line was four hours and ten minutes, and you'd allowed three."

"Three and a half, because people linger."

"They lingered, and I said 'I'm fine' to every one of them. A man from the Elks. A woman who used to cut Callum's hair. A guy who sold him his first truck, who cried on my shirt, and I patted his back and said I'm fine, and I could hear myself. It was like somebody had wound me up and set me down in a hallway."

She wrote *10/28/23, then 4 hrs.*

"Three weeks later it's a Thursday, the sixteenth of November. I'm driving home the long way, past St. Brendan's, and there's a sandwich board on the lawn. *Grief Circle, Thursdays 6:30, coffee, you don't have to talk.*"

“And you went in.”

“I sat in the car for forty minutes. Then a man came out to bring the board in, and he looked at my car and then at me through the window, and he said, ‘The coffee’s bad, but there are chairs.’”

“Abel.”

“Abel.” He breathed out through his nose. “I went in and sat down and didn’t say a word for four weeks. The first thing I said was ‘My brother was Callum.’ That’s all. I said it to the floor.”

“And what did they say?”

“Abel said, ‘Tell us one thing he’d have done in this room.’ I said he’d have fixed the urn.”

Thea did not laugh. She looked at the pad. She had been taking it down in full sentences, in her ordinary neat hand, as if it were a client’s allergies, and she stopped.

“And you told me it was a department meeting,” she said.

“That night, in the kitchen. You were on the phone with a florist. I said I’d be late, department thing, and you gave me a thumbs-up.” He lifted his own thumb off his knee, absurdly, and set it down again. “You didn’t look up. I noticed, and I’m not saying it to put it on you, because I kept going anyway.”

“How many Thursdays?”

“About a hundred and fifty-two. I missed two for the flu and one for the parent-teacher night.”

“A hundred and fifty-two.” She wrote it down, and because the number would not stay a number, she said, “Go on.”

“Leona came in March of 2024.”

“I know what she’s in the room for. Get to what you did.”

He took it without argument, though his voice had begun to shorten, the sentences coming off in pieces. She had sat across the ring from him for a month, he said, and neither of them had spoken. Then in April, after group, he was walking to his car and she was in hers at the edge of the lot with the engine running, and she put the window down and said, “Do you want to sit?”

“Forty minutes, then an hour. We talked about Callum and her husband. About whether you’re allowed to still be angry at a person for dying in the middle of something.”

“What was the something?”

“A game. Callum’s was a Sunday, on the sideline. Hers was a Friday, in her kitchen.” He looked at his hands. “That was the spring. In August she gave me her number, and the messages started that night.”

Thea put the pen down on the pad. Her hand stayed on the paper beside it with the fingers a little spread.

Since he walked in she had known where everything was, down to the nineteen feet from his chair to the door. Now she couldn’t have said what was pinned to the corkboard. She looked at the red stripe on the floor and it stayed a red stripe.

“August,” she said. “Go back to August.”

“She gave me her number in case she couldn’t make a Thursday. That’s what she said, and that’s what it was for about six hours. I texted her that night.”

“From where?”

He took too long to answer. “Nolan. From where?”

“The bathroom, with the fan on.”

She had left a ginger ale on the tile outside that door once, last October: a can sweating onto the grout and a sleeve of saltines, because he’d been in there so long she thought it was his stomach. He had said thank you through the wood in a voice so tired and so grateful that she had gone downstairs and thrown out a whole carton of milk for no reason, to have something to do with her hands.

“Every night,” Nolan said. “Nine, ten o’clock, in the garage mostly, with the door shut. Sometimes in the car in the driveway before I came in, so I’d come in light. You said once I seemed lighter. You said it like a good thing.”

“It was a good thing. I thought so, I was glad.”

“You were.” He said it gently, and it was worse for being gentle. He took his phone from his back pocket, thumbed it open, and held it out across the eight feet at the full length of his arm. “It’s unlocked. All of it’s in there, both sides. Read it tonight, read it next year. I’m not going to change one word.”

She looked at a black rectangle, a little bright at the edge, with the corner cracked that he’d been meaning to fix since September.

“Not tonight,” she said. “Put it down.”

He lowered it to his knee, faceup, like a plate someone had refused, and when the screen had gone dark he put it back in his pocket.

“I’ll give you the worst one myself,” he said, “so you don’t find it.” He stopped to breathe, and she heard it. “In March, this March, I wrote her, *You’re the only place I can breathe.*”

Thea was holding the pen again, with no memory of picking it up. In March she had been in Detroit three nights for a convention, and then home, and in the evenings she had sat on the couch with her laptop while he graded lab reports beside her, his foot against hers under the blanket. She had thought that was the place he breathed.

“And the worst one,” she said. “You said that was the worst one.”

“No, that’s only the second worst.”

“Say it.”

“A few weeks after, I wrote, *I think I’m in love with how I feel in your car.*”

The neon buzzed. Down on Water Street a truck went by with something loose in the bed.

“With how you feel,” said Thea.

“I wrote it that way because I couldn’t write the other way. I’ve thought about it more than any sentence I’ve ever written.” He wet his lips. “It’s true, that’s the thing, and I’m telling you because you asked for all of it.”

“I asked for dates.”

“Then I’m over the limit.”

It was a frightened joke. She let it lie, and he sat in the green chair with the joke gone off him like a coat.

“Did you touch her?” she said. “I asked her, and now I’m asking you.”

“Once.”

She heard it land in her.

“One hug. February, last year, the Thursday before Rafael’s first anniversary. She came out to the lot after and she was shaking, and I put my arms around her at the door of the parish hall, and she let me, and that was all.” He looked straight at her. “It isn’t nothing, I know that.”

“What else?”

“Nothing. I never kissed her. Never her house, never a coffee, never a restaurant. I’ve never been anywhere with her except the lot and the car. Never where anybody could see.”

“Don’t offer me that as a point in your favor.”

“I’m not.” He closed his eyes and opened them. “I know what it is, and it’s worse.”

She wrote *Hug, February 2025, door*. The handwriting had gotten smaller. She put a line under the date, and then a second line, and made herself stop and turned the pad face down on her knee.

“Eleven months ago she told you to bring me. Why didn’t you?”

“I meant to. Every Thursday I’d drive there thinking, tonight. And you’d have a wedding on, or a vendor, and I’d think, not tonight. And then I’d kept it so long that the lie was bigger than the thing I was lying about.”

“That isn’t what I asked. I’m asking about the first Thursday, the sixteenth of November. You could have said, ‘I’m going to a grief group.’ Six words. I’d have driven you.”

“You would have.”

“So why didn’t you?”

He looked at her, his eyes red at the rims and entirely steady, and she saw that this was the answer he had rehearsed longest, the one he had carried up the stairs.

“Because you’d have made a plan,” Nolan said.

It was not said cruelly. She tried it for cruelty, turning it over the way you test a chair leg, and found none in it, only that it was true. She could see exactly what she would have done: a list of groups sorted by wait time, a column for insurance, a laminated card for his wallet with Abel’s number and the late-night line, a ride schedule in case he’d had a drink, and a note on the family calendar. *N, Thurs, support*. She would have had it done by Friday, and it would have been excellent.

She sat with the pad face down on her knee and found nothing to put in the space where her answer went.

“All right,” she said finally.

“Thea, I’m not saying it was a bad thing. It’s the best thing about you.”

“Don’t.” Her voice came out level, and she was grateful to it. “Don’t give me that part tonight. I can’t hold it yet.”

“All right.”

She turned the pad to a fresh page. She had written on it at four that afternoon and again at six, in neater handwriting, and she read from it now so her voice would have something to stand on. In the red light it looked like a run-of-show. She hadn’t meant it to. It was the only form she had ever had for anything.

“Terms. One, I’m not coming home, and that’s not a question for this week. Two, I’m not planning Christmas, or Thanksgiving, or your mother’s

birthday, or anything with a date on it. That's yours. Three, you may text me one line a day. One. No questions in it, nothing that needs a reply, nothing that's a feeling. Tell me about the dog."

"One line about the dog."

"Four. You tell your mother, all of it, yourself."

His face moved. "She thinks I have a woman."

"Then she's wrong, and she's been wrong in front of ninety people for five days, and you fix that. Not me, not Odessa, not Isla guessing. I won't give you a date, and I will know if it isn't done."

"Five." This was the one she had rewritten, and the pen had gone through the paper where she'd crossed it out. "You don't go back to the Thursday Table until I tell you I'm ready to watch you do it."

"Watch me."

"I want to see the room. I want to see where you sit and who's across from you and what you do with your hands. Until then you stay out, and that's the whole list."

"Then I need somewhere else to put it till then." He said it to the lanyard. "Not you. And not a parking lot. I'll find it myself."

She had a name for him already; she had found three grief counselors on her phone in the bakery lot on Tuesday without meaning to. She kept the names where they were.

He sat with the lanyard on the floor where it had slid. She had expected him to argue. He had a physicist's habit of looking for the hole in a proposition and a husband's habit of finding it, and she had a line ready for each.

"I agree to all of it," he said.

"You haven't heard what I'll add."

"Then I'll agree to that too."

"That's not how terms work."

"I'm sorry. I don't know how they work, only that I'm done doing it the other way."

Somewhere under the floor the furnace came on with a long breath. He got up out of the green chair, slowly, and it let him go with the same sigh. Instead of leaving he stood in the middle of the room with the red stripe across his shoes and took hold of the back of the chair with both hands, as if it were a lectern.

"I'll tell you the truth," he said. "Even the small ones."

He said all of it, to the last word, in his plain teaching voice, and the breath he took afterward was long and unsteady, like a diver's coming up.

It would have been so easy to say yes.

"Don't," said Thea, and he looked at her. "Not yet. You don't get to say it until you've done it." She laid the pen across the pad. "You said it once with ninety people watching and you couldn't finish. I won't hear it again until it's already true."

He stood there and took the whole of it, with no argument and no shrug. "That's right," he said.

He bent for the lanyard and straightened with it in his hand, holding it a moment as if he had forgotten what it was for. At the desk he stopped and touched the pocket the phone was in.

"Whenever you want it," he said. "I'll bring it."

"Go home now, Nolan."

"Goodnight, Thea."

He went down the stairs. She listened to him go: the third step that always creaked, then the door, then Water Street taking him. She did not go to the window. She sat at her desk with the yellow pad and her five terms in her own tidy hand, and did not move for a long time.

Her phone lit once, a gray square on the dark wood, and went out.

Part Two — The Listening

I'll listen to the end of the sentence.

Chapter 7 — The Moravec Method

Thea had the third sheet of butcher paper against the back wall and a strip of tape between her teeth when Dimitra came in with two coffees and a Monday face.

“It’s crooked,” Dimitra said.

“It’s level.” Thea took the tape out of her mouth. “It’s level to the floor.”

“The floor is a hundred years old. Nothing in here is level. You flipped the cushion on the green chair.”

“It was worn on one side.”

“It’s been worn on that side since Holland. Friday’s the first you noticed.”

“It was worn on one side,” Thea said, and took the coffee. The seat had held a dent the size of a large man, and now it held the underside of a cushion. She drank half of it standing up, while under the floor Haskell’s Hardware ran the key machine, a whine she had worked above for years and never once heard until this morning. “Hana and Rowan at ten. Do we have the vow drafts?”

“They emailed them as a PDF, color-coded, with a legend.”

“Of course there’s a legend.”

“You good?”

“Fine.”

Dimitra looked at her over the lid of her cup for exactly as long as it takes to decide against a question. “Printing,” she said, and went to print.

• • •

Hana Vos was twenty-nine and came through the door as if entering a meeting she had already won. Dark bob, camel coat, a leather portfolio with tabbed dividers under one arm. Rowan Sutter followed a step behind, tall and rumpled, with a cardboard tray of four coffees, one of which was clearly for Dimitra, which Thea decided to hold against nobody.

“We got oat, we got whole, we didn’t know,” Rowan said. “Sorry, I’ll just, is there a place?”

“Desk,” said Thea, “anywhere on the desk.”

They sat, and Hana put the portfolio on her knees without opening it and tilted her head, and Thea knew what was coming, slow and certain, like a rain cell on a radar loop.

“First,” Hana said. “We heard about Sunday, everyone has, and I’m so sorry.”

“Thank you.”

“And if you need space, if it would be easier to hand us over to Dimitra, we are totally fine with that. No judgment, and we’d understand.”

“Dimitra is excellent,” said Thea. “I am also excellent, so you get both.”

“But are you—”

“I’m fine.”

“Because we could move the date,” Rowan said. “If you wanted, if that’s —”

“Rowan.” Hana did not look at him. “We are not moving the date. The deposit on the ballroom alone is a used Honda.”

“I was being considerate.”

“You were being a used Honda.” She turned back to Thea and her whole face went professional again, as if someone had pressed a lever. “So, vows.”

They had printed them on legal paper, two copies each, and slid the pages across the desk. Thea lifted her glasses off the cord and put them on. Hana’s pages were highlighted in four colors: pink for pauses, yellow for eye contact with Rowan, green for smile, and blue, in the margins, for breath. At the top of the first page, in a tidy box, was the legend, and at the bottom of the third was a running time: 3 min 40 sec.

“Would you read it aloud?” Hana said. “I want to hear it in a voice that isn’t mine. The timing’s off when I do it.”

Thea read it flat, the way she read a contract.

“Rowan, from the moment I met you, I knew I had found my partner in every sense. I promise to prioritize us. I promise to communicate before I assume. I promise to meet you at the intersection of our calendars with grace.”

She stopped, and Rowan had gone very still.

“The intersection of our calendars,” Thea said.

“It’s a metaphor.”

“It’s a Tuesday.” She turned the page to six more promises, all of which would have survived a lawyer. “What does he do at seven in the morning that you wouldn’t trade?”

“He leaves the cabinet doors open,” Hana said, and then closed her mouth.

Rowan looked at his knees, his ears red. “I do, every one,” he said. “I’m sorry.”

“That,” said Thea, “is the vow.”

“It’s not on tone,” said Hana. “We agreed on tone: elevated, warm but elevated.”

“Then put the cabinets in warm and save the elevated for the end.”

Hana held a pen over the page, and Thea watched the pen decide. It put a small, neat asterisk in the margin and came away. “I’ll think about it,” Hana said. “Read his.”

Rowan’s were in green and blue only. Thea read down through *safe harbor* and *best friend* and *always saying thank you* and came to the fourth line, which said, *I promise never to go to bed angry*.

She read it in the same voice as the rest, and turned the page a fraction before it needed turning.

“Everyone writes that one,” she said.

“Is it wrong?” said Rowan.

“It’s very popular,” said Thea, which was not an answer, and he seemed to know it.

Her phone buzzed against the blotter, once, and she did not look at it. In the doorway Dimitra’s own phone had been going for a full minute, and when it started again she mouthed *hotel* and held up one finger.

Thea was halfway out of her chair before she had decided to be.

“Mine,” Dimitra said, not loud. She put out a flat palm and went into the stairwell with the phone against her ear.

Thea sat back down with the glasses still in her fist, the cord having left a red line across her thumb.

Hana said, “Is everything okay with the hotel?”

“It’s a hotel,” said Thea. “Something is always happening at a hotel. Let’s do the processional.”

• • •

By eleven-forty the Sutter-Vos wedding had a processional order, a seating chart with a placeholder for the groom’s father’s new girlfriend, and a rain plan for an indoor ceremony, because Hana wanted one. They left in a cloud of tabbed dividers, Hana first, already on her phone. Rowan hung back in the doorway with his tray of cold coffee.

“The cabinets,” he said, low. “Thank you for that.”

“It’s your vow, I just asked where you were in it.”

“She’s not cold, you know. She gets scared of the part where it’s only us saying a thing.” He tried a smile and put it away again. “I’m told the legend helps.”

“It helps everybody,” Thea said. “That’s why people make them, so go, she’s idling.”

He went out holding the door for nobody.

Dimitra came back in with a yellow sticky note held between two fingers.

“Rotary,” she said, and stuck the note to the monitor. It said, in her square hand: *Rotary → mezzanine; our load-in 11:00 holds; cost 40 croissants*. “The hotel double-booked the ballroom for the fifth. The banquet manager’s wife loves Odessa’s croissants. I’ll put it in writing for him at two, and you’ll be on a vendor call.”

“I don’t have a vendor call at two.”

“You do now.”

Thea read the note twice. Her mouth was already open on the first instruction, which was to call the banquet manager herself, and she closed it. “That’s good,” she said.

“Look at you.”

“Shut up.”

“Making a note of it.” Dimitra took her coat off the hook. “I’m getting lunch, you want some?”

“I’m fine.”

Dimitra’s eyebrows went up and stayed there until she had gone down the stairs.

Thea turned her phone over. One new message, from the number she had saved eleven years ago in a diner, on the third week of dating him, with a coffee ring on the table between her hands. She had typed *Nolan, Do Not Lose* as a joke and had never once changed it.

Biscuit ate a sock. He’s fine. I’m fine.

She read it twice, standing in the middle of the studio, and her eye caught on the third sentence.

I’m fine. She had heard it two hundred times in a row in the receiving line at the church hall, and stood three feet away and counted. This one came with the quotation marks left on.

She had said it three times since breakfast, twice to Dimitra and once to Hana, and hers had come without any.

The stairs thumped, and Odessa came up them the way Odessa came up everything, with her whole body, in her black chef's jacket with the sleeves shoved to the elbow and a deli container held out in front of her. She got to the desk and dropped it. The lid jumped off and a little chicken-and-rice broth went across a Vos seating chart.

"Soup," said Odessa. "Chicken, rice, too much dill, so eat it."

"I'll eat it later."

"You'll eat it now, and I'm going to watch you, and then I have to go, because I have forty covers at four." She righted the container, mopped the seating chart with a napkin from her pocket, and looked at the phone in Thea's fingers. The screen had gone dark, and Thea's thumb woke it again. "That him?"

"Biscuit ate a sock."

"Is that code, or is he fine?"

"He says he's fine."

"Which one?" said Odessa. "The dog or the man?"

"Both."

Odessa looked at her a while. "Does he say anything else?"

"He's not allowed to. One line a day, no questions."

"Whose rule?"

"Mine."

"Huh," said Odessa, which from her was a paragraph. "You've woken up that phone four times since I walked in."

"Twice."

"I count for a living, honey. Covers, mostly, but I'm versatile." She pushed a plastic spoon across the desk. "Eat the soup, then decide whatever you're deciding. But eat the soup."

"I haven't decided anything."

"I didn't say you had." Odessa pointed the spoon at her. "I said eat."

She went down the stairs and the door at the bottom banged.

Along the back wall the master timeline for the fifth of December ran down three sheets of butcher paper, the whole of Hana's wedding in black marker in five-minute blocks. There was a line at 6:42 that said *TEARS (opt.)*, and beside it, in Thea's own handwriting from the week before, *Pilar — cue soft music*.

Hana's Saturday had a backup for the backup. Thea stood in front of the wall and thought of a bungalow on Alder Street, where nothing had a time written next to it.

She opened the container and took one spoonful standing up, then another, and the broth was just hot enough that she could not do anything else.

Dimitra came back with sandwiches at twelve-thirty and stopped at the timeline, a pen in one hand and half a pickle in the other. "Tears are at 6:42," she said. "You want a hard cue, or a soft one?"

"Is that Odessa's soup?"

"Is that a yes on the cue?"

"Soft," said Thea. "Pilar doesn't do hard."

"Hana will want the tears on the mark, with a run-through."

"Hana can want."

Thea took the pen and stood in front of the butcher paper for a while, and then she uncapped it.

Next to 6:42 *TEARS (opt.)* she wrote *window: ten minutes*, and under it, smaller, *(eight seconds did not hold)*.

Dimitra read it upside down. "I'll tell Hana the ten minutes is hotel policy," she said. "Nobody argues with a cancellation fee."

Chapter 8 — The Binder

“You’re not scanning it,” Thea said.

“I’m not scanning it.” Dimitra had the copier lid up and the binder open flat on the glass, three inches of navy vinyl with the spine gone white at the crease from ten Novembers of being opened to the same pages. She hadn’t pressed the green button. One hand lay on the first page as if the binder might get up. “I’m reading it, and reading is free.”

It was Tuesday night, nearly nine. His line had come at six: *Biscuit sat at the back door an hour waiting for your car. I sat at the table and didn’t go out to the garage.* The studio smelled of toner and of the soup Odessa had left on the windowsill, a strip of masking tape across the lid that said EAT in marker. Thea stood by the coat rack, car keys in her fist.

“Tab one, birthdays,” Dimitra read. “Nine people, plus Biscuit, plus ‘Dara: card by the fifth, she will not call.’ Tab two, Pills, where you color-coded Margit’s blood pressure.”

“She can’t tell the white ones apart.”

“Tab three, Lisbon flights, with a note about which side of the plane. Tab four, allergies, and then tab five.” She turned the page and her mouth went flat. “‘Thanksgiving, 2016 to present.’ Thea, there’s a gravy timeline with *minutes*.”

“Twenty-three is mostly in pencil.”

Dimitra looked at the page and let that one go, which was the kindest thing she had done all week, then flipped on. “Seating, with notes: ‘Two cousins, never adjacent.’ ‘Jonas does not carry the good gravy boat.’ There’s a tab called Contingencies, and it has a *sub-tab*.”

“Oven failure and power failure, plus Margit’s back.”

“You’ve got a plan for Margit’s back.”

“It’s a very bad back.”

“If you hand over the only copy,” Dimitra said, “the first time somebody needs to know who can’t eat walnuts, it’ll be midnight and you’ll be lying awake with it.”

“Jonas, and it’s in tab four.”

“And when it’s *you* who remembers?”

“Then I’ll remember,” Thea said, “and I won’t do anything about it, so no copy.” Her voice came out level, the voice for telling a groom the cake had fallen.

Dimitra took her hand off the page. She shut the lid without pressing anything, squared the binder's corners, and held it out. "Your binder, back in one piece."

"I put it on the postal scale, and it weighs eleven pounds."

"Of course you did," Dimitra said, watching her take it and hold it against her ribs. "Want me to carry it down?"

"It stays up here tonight. I'll take it in the morning."

"Margit at four tomorrow, Walter and Esther at ten on Thursday. I put the binder in the calendar as an event. It says *Drop-off*, because I didn't know what else to call it."

"That's fine."

"It's a terrible word, though."

"It's the right one," Thea said, and set the binder on the desk by the door, where she would have to step around it in the morning.

• • •

She had belted the binder into the passenger seat of the Subaru, and now, at the curb on Cooper Street, she could not make her hand undo the buckle.

Margit's house was a narrow two-story the color of putty, with a plastic pumpkin still on the porch step because nobody in the family could be the one to throw it out. The porch light was on at ten to four in the afternoon. In the kitchen window the curtain moved once and fell back.

Thea freed the binder and hauled it up into her arms. The key to this house had been on her ring ten years, next to the key to the studio, and she climbed the three steps with both hands full and rang the bell.

The door opened before the chime finished.

Margit said, "Since when do you ring?"

"I didn't want to walk in."

"Ten years you walk in. I stand at the stove, I hear a bell, I think, who is selling what." She was in her house cardigan with the pockets stretched, a wooden spoon in one fist like a baton. She looked at the binder and then at the doorframe, as though the binder were hot. "Shoes off, and come in."

The kitchen seated nine, as Thea had counted once, with a tape measure, her first Christmas: the long oak table with its leaf permanently in, eight chairs that never matched and a piano bench for the ninth, the cherry oilcloth, the stockpot big enough to feed a middle school. Margit had run the cafeteria at Port Ellery Elementary for twenty-six years and never learned to cook for

fewer than twelve. The room smelled of paprika and onions, and under that, of the lemon cleaner she used on the counters every night.

Jonas was at the near end of the table with an algebra worksheet and a pencil he had taken apart. A pair of headphones hung round his neck, the cord ending in a loose plug against his chest, connected to nothing.

“Hi, Jonas.”

“Hi, not listening,” he said, without looking up.

“The headphones aren’t plugged in.”

“Still not listening,” Jonas said.

Margit put a bowl down at the end chair, the one that had been Thea’s since her first Thanksgiving: chicken paprikás, the nokedli cut small and ragged with the back of a knife, a dish of cucumbers in sour cream beside it. “Sit and eat, then we talk.”

“I can’t stay long, I have a call at five.”

“Sit.”

Thea sat and laid the binder on the oilcloth beside the bowl, where it took the space of two place settings. Margit glanced at it, then at the stove, and kept her eyes on the stove.

“You sleep at the studio.”

“Who told you that?”

“Nolan tells me nothing, he comes to my door and stands on the mat with his hands like this.” Margit folded her own in front of her, a boy at a recital. “He says he is fine. I put soup in his hands, and then I called Odessa.”

“Odessa had no business telling you.”

“Odessa says it’s a good couch.”

“It’s a very good couch.”

“A couch is for guests, and you will eat.” The spoon went into the pot and out again.

Thea, who’d had a coffee at eight and half a protein bar at noon, hadn’t known she was hungry until the second mouthful, when she had to set the spoon down and look at the oilcloth for a while. The paprika was the sweet kind Margit’s cousin mailed from Szeged in a tin. Margit stirred a pot that did not need stirring, her eyes on Thea in the dark glass of the oven door.

“Slower,” she told the glass, “nobody is taking it.”

When the bowl was half gone, Thea pushed the binder four inches across the oilcloth toward the empty chair beside her and said, “I brought you this.”

Margit didn’t turn around.

"It's everything: birthdays, pills, the school calendar, Dara's flights. Thanksgiving is in tab five. The turkey is ordered for pickup Wednesday at two, and the slip is clipped inside the front cover. The sides are on the grid. Christmas Eve is behind it. I won't be running Thanksgiving or Christmas Eve. I know that's a week out for one and five weeks for the other, and I'm telling you now so it isn't a surprise."

"A surprise," said Margit.

"I'm sorry."

"You come with a binder to tell me there will be no surprise." She laughed once, a short dry bark with nothing in it, and set the wooden spoon on its rest. She looked past the binder, out the window at the driveway and the bare maple and the neighbor's blue recycling bin lying on its side. "You will not ask my son to leave the house. You will not tell me what he did."

"He's going to tell you himself."

"When?"

"I asked him to. It's his to say, not mine."

"Mm," Margit said, and turned the burner down a quarter inch, then turned back and faced Thea down the length of the table, hands flat on the oilcloth. She did not ask why; in sixty-eight years it had always been answered by the time she reached the kitchen. "Who will do it?"

"I don't know."

"You don't know."

"I don't know, and that's the point." It came out harder than she meant. "Somebody else has to find out."

"That is not a point." Margit's voice did not rise. It dropped, and that was worse. "That is a hole: you dig a hole and you say, look, a hole, now we know where it is."

"Margit."

"Three years ago I sat down. I sat at this table and I did not get up. And you took the spoon." Her chin lifted toward the pot, the cardigan, the spoon on its rest. "I let you, and I was grateful. I know what it was. And now after three years you carry it here in your arms and put it in front of me, and the pot is hot."

"I'm not trying to hand you something hot."

"Then what?"

“I’m trying to put it down.” Her voice split on *down*, and Jonas’s pencil stopped on a number. “I can’t carry it and be any good to anyone, not right now, not for Christmas.”

“Eat,” said Margit.

“I need you to hear—”

“You are shaking, so eat. I am still angry, and nobody gets angry on an empty stomach in my kitchen.” She set the cucumbers down beside Thea’s bowl and took the spoon out of the pot again, and her hand on the handle was steady as a mason’s. Thea picked up her own spoon. It ticked once against the rim of the bowl, and she laid it down.

The back door banged, as it always did when it stuck, and the whole house knew Isla was home.

“It’s me. It’s four, so who’s dead.” Isla’s voice came from the mudroom, flat and reasonable, then a backpack hit the floor and a boot came off, and then she was in the doorway in her school coat, one boot on and one off, and said, “Hi.”

“Boots,” Margit said, “in the box.”

“The door sticks, and I heard some of it.” Isla looked at the table: the binder in its navy vinyl, Thea’s half-eaten bowl, her grandmother’s hands on the oilcloth. She was a tall girl, sixteen, built like Callum, with his black eyebrows and none of his noise. Nothing in her face moved. “You’re not doing Christmas Eve.”

“Isla, sweetheart.”

“That’s what I heard, ‘Christmas Eve’ and ‘I can’t.’” Isla pulled off her other boot, carefully, without looking, and set it beside the first. “So we lose you too?”

Nobody moved.

A minute ago the kitchen had been a set, and Thea had read it the way she read every room. Now she couldn’t have said where anything stood, and the oilcloth cherries swam. Jonas’s pencil lead snapped on the worksheet with a small dry click, and he put the pencil down and went still, his eyes on the number.

“You’re not losing anyone,” Thea said, and stopped, because it was a promise and she had no idea whether she could keep it.

Isla waited.

“I’m not going anywhere, I’ll be around.”

Isla said, “Okay,” without any edge at all, the way she had said *thank you for coming* down the receiving line three years ago, level and polite. “Is there any food, Grandma?”

“There is always food, so sit.”

Isla sat at the other end of the table, as far from the binder as it allowed. Margit put a bowl in front of her, and Isla did not pick up her spoon.

Thea looked at the binder, its tabs sticking out like a row of small colored teeth, and thought she should explain it. You didn’t drop a three-inch binder on a family without a briefing.

“Tab two is your pills, Margit. The Tuesday and Friday ones are the pale blue, because the white ones all look alike. The cardiologist’s number is inside the front flap.”

“I know where my pills are.”

“I only meant—”

“I know what you meant.” Margit’s hands had come off the oilcloth. She did not touch the binder. She put them behind her back, one gripping the other wrist, and stood very straight at the head of the table, her eyes full and her mouth gone white at the corners.

Thea stood and pushed in her chair, because you push in chairs. She took her bowl to the sink, rinsed it, and set it in the rack, and the whole kitchen was watching her do it.

“Leave that,” Margit said.

“It’s one bowl.”

“Leave it,” Margit said, already reaching a yogurt tub down from the cupboard. She filled it with paprikás, pressed the lid on, and held it out, and it was hot through the plastic when Thea took it. “That’s for tonight, and you will not have it with a cracker standing up.”

“Thank you, Margit.”

“Don’t thank me, take it, and go home and sit down on something that is not a couch for guests.”

“Bye, Isla, and bye, Jonas.”

“Bye,” said Isla, to her bowl. Jonas lifted two fingers off the pencil.

At the door to the hall Thea stopped and looked back at the three of them: Jonas with the broken pencil, Isla with the untouched spoon, Margit at the stove with her back to the room. The binder lay at the corner of the table, where nobody had touched it and nobody did.

“Close the door,” Margit said, not turning around. “You are letting the heat out.”

She drew the door to and stopped short of the latch. In the gap the light lay across the oilcloth and the binder.

Chapter 9 — Walter and Esther

Walter Ames unwrapped his wife from a blue-checked dish towel and stood her on the easel. Then he stepped back with his hands behind him, as if he had delivered a package to the right address.

The photograph was an eight-by-ten in a plain oak frame. A woman in a green cardigan stood on a marina dock holding up a perch no longer than her hand, laughing at whoever held the camera.

“That’s her,” Walter said. “Nineteen eighty-nine. She caught the one fish and told people for a year it was a walleye.”

“It’s a handsome perch,” said Thea.

“It’s a sardine. She’d want you to know that.”

He was seventy-six and long in the bone, with a retired lineman’s forearms and a gray crew cut so even it looked sanded. He had arrived at ten sharp in a pressed shirt and a tie with small anchors on it. Thea had set the studio for him that morning, clearing the worktable, descaling the kettle, pulling two chairs up on the client side. The green leather chair she had turned to face the wall, and Dimitra had said nothing about that, loudly.

The third stair complained. Walter’s head came up.

Esther Baptiste backed into the studio shouldering the door, a second frame held against her chest in both arms. She was seventy-four and small, in a navy wool coat, her white braid pinned round her head. She had taught piano in Port Ellery for forty years and still stood as though there were a bench behind her.

“Your third stair wants oil.”

“Mrs. Haskell has been promising it since 1994.”

“Then she is a woman of her word.” Esther turned around. “Where do I put him? He doesn’t like to be held for long.”

Thea took the frame. A man in a Tigers cap squinted into a low sun, mid-sentence, one hand raised as if to correct somebody. She set him on the second easel beside the woman with the perch, squared both to the table edge, and tore a length of gaffer tape off the roll at her wrist.

“Facing the guests or facing you?” It was the first question she asked every couple about every object: who is this for.

“Us,” Esther said.

“Facing us,” said Walter, at the same time. They looked at each other.

“Then they sit on the table beside your chairs, angled in, so they can see you and the room sees them in profile. Tape under each foot, so nobody’s

grandson knocks him into the punch.” She pressed the strip down with her thumb. “Is there a window behind where the table goes?”

“West windows,” Walter said. “Four of them.”

“Four o’clock in December, with glass in front of him. He’d be a white flash for the whole ceremony. We move the table.”

“Table moves,” Dimitra said from the end of the worktable. She was typing without looking at the keys.

Walter had taken a folding rule out of his shirt pocket. He opened it along the table edge, between the two easels, and frowned at the numbers.

“Thirty inches,” he said. “Can they be thirty?”

“They can be anything. Is thirty a number?”

“It’s what we had between the chairs at the church supper. Esther’s husband’s funeral lunch. I sat down, she sat down, and afterward I measured it in my head. Thirty inches from my elbow to hers.” He folded the rule in sections, one, two, three. “I didn’t touch her. I just wanted to know how far.”

“Thirty,” Thea said, and wrote it. “Anything else I should measure?”

“Not unless you can do the dead,” said Walter, and Esther laughed, a bright, short note, like someone hitting a key.

“Is that the sort of thing you think about?” Esther asked.

“All day. It’s most of the job.”

“And the rest of it?”

“Making people think I wasn’t thinking about it.” Thea sat and uncapped her pen. For ten years of weddings she had opened with the same line, *Let’s start with what you’re afraid will go wrong*, and she opened her mouth for it now and it was not there. She had a legal pad and a perfectly good mouth, and nothing stood behind either one.

“Guest count,” she said instead.

“Fifty-two,” said Walter. “If Esther’s cousin from Escanaba doesn’t change her mind.”

“She’ll change her mind,” said Esther.

“Fifty-two, fifty-one.” Thea wrote 52? and underlined it. The pen hesitated over the underline, and she let it sit.

“We heard about Sunday,” said Esther.

“Esther,” Walter said. “We agreed.”

“I agreed not to bring it up, and I haven’t. I’m telling her we heard, so she needn’t spend this whole hour wondering.” Esther folded her hands on the

table. Hers were big-jointed, with short nails, a pianist's. "Port Ellery has forty thousand people in it and a dozen opinions. We have none of them."

"Thank you," Thea said. "The twelfth stands. I don't move dates."

"We never thought you would."

"Good," Esther said, and stood up. "Then I want you in my kitchen. You can't plan us from a table in an office. Come and look at where they live. They live in my kitchen, mostly. I have a cake and it will not eat itself."

"We have a ten-thirty." Thea looked at Dimitra.

"You have nothing till two," said Dimitra. "I looked."

. . .

The two houses stood side by side on Birch Street, thirty feet apart, with a strip of grass and a shared gravel driveway between them. Esther's was yellow. Walter's was white, with a lawn cut to a quarter inch. His kitchen window faced hers across the strip, so near that Thea, getting out of the Subaru, could see a coffee mug on his sill and a saucer on hers.

"I can see her light from my kitchen," Walter said, with some satisfaction, as if he had arranged it. "Thirty-one years we've been neighbors. I waved to her over the hedge. She waved back. That was our whole conversation for twenty-nine of them."

"You didn't wave. You nodded."

"I waved on Sundays."

Esther's kitchen was yellow too, with a clock shaped like a teapot, and on top of the refrigerator, where the light caught it, a smaller print of the man in the Tigers cap. A plain pound cake sat on the counter under a glass dome, its top split down the middle the way a good one should. Esther cut it with a knife she wiped on a towel between slices.

"Eat," she said, like Margit, an order that happened to be kind.

Thea ate, and it was dense and buttery, with sugar crunching on the crust, and she took the first bite standing at the counter and the second sitting down. Dimitra took a slice in one hand and her phone in the other and moved to the corner by the back door, which was how she took notes in other people's houses, out of the way.

"She brought me a casserole," Walter said, with a tilt of his chin toward Esther. "The week my wife died. Hers was the first one on the porch. Tuna noodle. I ate it four days running and thought it was the best thing I'd ever put

in my mouth, and I was ashamed. A man buries his wife and he's thinking about noodles."

"He was ashamed of the tuna," said Esther.

"I was."

"He stood at my door on the fifth day and said, 'Esther, I'm very sorry, I liked it,' and handed me the dish washed." She smiled at the cake knife. "I told him to bring it back full."

"That's the entire courtship," Walter said. "Two years of tuna."

Thea laughed. It was a small, ordinary laugh, and it surprised her. She put her pen down next to the 52? and picked it up again.

"Tell me about the ceremony. What do you want it to feel like?"

"Like us," said Walter.

"Dear, that's not an answer," Esther said, kindly. "Walter, tell her about the girls."

"Her daughter," Walter said.

"Not the girls. My daughter. Singular. She's very good, she drives up from Grand Rapids every month, and she thinks I'm replacing her father."

"Are you?"

"I'm not replacing him." Esther set the cake knife flat on the towel and said it to the knife, quite evenly. "I'm adding a chair."

The teapot clock ticked. In the corner, Dimitra had stopped typing.

Thea looked at the legal pad. She had been holding the pen over the next line for some time, and nothing was on it but a date, the number fifty-two and a question mark. She had registers for this, the warm one for a weeping mother of the bride and the dry one for a groom who wanted an ice sculpture of a bass. She reached for each in turn, and her hand closed on air.

"Is it the same chair?" she said. "Or a new chair?"

"A new one," Esther said. "I bought it. It's in the front room. It's too tall for him."

"Too tall for who?"

"For me," said Esther. "I sit in it and my feet don't reach. I keep telling myself it's the chair."

Walter had gone to look at the clock. He was reading the face of it closely, with his back to everyone.

"I'm sorry," Thea said. "I'm usually better than this at the start."

"You are very good," Esther said. "You moved the table before I'd asked for anything."

“Who gives the cue?” That was something she could hold. “At the start. Somebody has to nod at the officiant, and she’ll be looking at somebody for the word to go.”

“Nobody,” Walter said, turning from the clock.

“There’s always a cue.”

“We’ll just start,” said Esther. “When we’re ready. We’re seventy-four and seventy-six. It’s a little late to wait for a nod.”

Thea held the pen. She thought of a navy binder on Cooper Street, three inches thick, in which nobody began anything unless she counted them in.

“Then I’ll leave a window,” she said. “Ten minutes at the front, and nobody counts.”

“What do you do with the ten minutes?”

“I stand at the back and don’t look at my watch.”

“Is that hard for you?”

“I have no idea,” Thea said, looking at the pad. “I’ve never done it.”

“Well,” said Esther. She cut another slice and put it on Thea’s plate without being asked, and Thea ate that one too. “Then you’ll have an interesting afternoon.”

• • •

Dimitra got into the passenger seat of the Subaru with a foil parcel of pound cake and her phone in her fist. She set the parcel in the cup holder. The go-bag sat on the back seat, zipped, its strap looped through the headrest.

Thea put the key in and did not turn it. The windshield showed her a yellow house and a white one, a strip of grass, a gravel drive, a mug on a sill.

“Fifty-two or fifty-one,” said Dimitra. “I have the cousin from Escanaba as maybe. Do you want me to call the daughter?”

“Yes.”

“Table, west windows, matte frames. Do you want me to send the officiant the ten-minute window?”

“Yes. No. I’ll do the officiant.”

Dimitra nodded, and the engine ticked. Up the street a man was running a leaf blower, and it rose and fell, rose and fell.

The dashboard had nothing on it to read. She thought: now. She thought of the receiving line, four hours and ten minutes, her own hand on a clipboard, and of a man in a kitchen who had been ashamed of the noodles, and of a chair

too tall for the woman in it. She waited, and her face did nothing at all. It was like pulling the cord on an outboard with no fuel in it.

“Okay,” she said, to the windshield. “That’s okay.”

“Do you want me to drive?” Dimitra asked, and Thea shook her head. “Do you want me to get out and stand on the lawn?”

“There’s nothing wrong with the lawn.”

“I only mean I can stand on it.” Dimitra looked straight ahead, at the same house. “I can be a person who is somewhere else.”

Thea said nothing. Dimitra twisted around, reached over the seat back, and unzipped the left side pocket of the go-bag, which she knew better than Thea’s own purse. She found the packet of tissues in its plastic sleeve and set it in Thea’s lap, square in the middle.

Thea looked at it. It was small and blue and ridiculous, and the sleeve said *Kleenex Pocket Pack* over a picture of a daisy.

She laughed.

It came out sideways, a short bark and then another, high, from somewhere up under her ribs, with nothing in it she could use. She put her forehead against the top of the wheel and it went on and on, and her shoulders did what shoulders do while her eyes stayed dry.

Dimitra had stopped looking at the house and was studying the glove compartment with great attention, one hand braced on the dashboard as if the car might tip.

She laughed until her ribs ached. Then she folded a tissue into quarters and set it in the cup holder, beside the cake.

Chapter 10 — Thanksgiving

The pie was pumpkin, from the bakery on Third Street, in a white box tied with red-and-white string, and Margit looked at it for some time.

“You bought,” she said, and Thea said she had.

“Good, because a woman who is not cooking should not bake out of spite.” She tested the box’s weight in both hands and set it on top of the refrigerator, out of the dog’s reach. “You have one hour, not a minute more.”

“One hour,” Thea agreed, and meant it.

That was the deal from the phone on Tuesday night: *You are not running anything. I am asking you to eat a plate of food in my kitchen on the day people eat plates of food.* Then Margit had hung up before Thea could agree, which was how she won negotiations. It was ten past one and dinner was at two, so Thea thought she could be out by three.

“Where are all the cousins?” The kitchen was too quiet for a table of nine.

“I did not call the cousins.”

“They always come, they’re in the binder, they’re never adjacent.”

“This year they are adjacent to nothing.” Margit turned the water on and off again for no reason. “Read the room, Thea, go on, I know you want to.”

So she read it: the kitchen window had fogged solid and the oven dial stood past four hundred, and on a chair pulled up like a lectern the binder lay open to tab five, with Isla bent over it, a pencil behind her ear and a phone timer in her fist.

“T-minus forty, pour off drippings, begin gravy,” Isla read. “It’s one-twenty, so I’m late, and the bird’s been in since ten-thirty.”

“The bird is not done,” Thea said, before she could stop it.

Isla’s pencil stopped on the page. “The book says forty minutes.”

“The book says forty if the bird comes out at two, and there’s a note.” It was in the margin in her own pencil: *If bird is late, move EVERYTHING. Do not move only the gravy.* “Down by the grid.”

Isla ran a finger down the margin. “That’s very small, you write really small.”

“Sit,” said Margit, without turning round. “She is following the book.”

Thea sat in the chair that had been hers for ten years and put both hands under her thighs.

“Why do you sit like that, like a girl on a hot stove?” Margit said.

“I’m fine.”

“Mm, everyone in this house is fine. There will be coffee, and it is the coffee I make for people I am angry with.”

“Is that a warning?”

“It is a menu.”

• • •

The mudroom door banged and Nolan came in sideways with a stack of folding chairs under one arm, though the table seated nine and there were five of them, and Biscuit trotted behind him in an orange bandana printed with small turkeys.

“Hi,” Nolan said, and when she said it back he leaned the chairs against the wall. “He picked it out himself.”

“He did not.”

“He stood very still while I tied it, which is a vote.” He poured a mug from the pot on the burner, carried it down the table, and set it at her place with the handle turned toward her hand. His fingers came away before hers could arrive. “Margit says the coffee is terrible.”

“It’s a menu.”

He stood longer than there was any use for, in the blue shirt from school picture day, a crease ironed down each arm. “I’ll carve when it’s time.”

Thea nodded, and he went away from the table, and the dog went with him, then came back and lay down on her feet instead.

Her phone lay face up beside the mug. At 7:41 that morning, outside the bakery, it had said: *Biscuit has a bandana. He’s fine. I’m telling her today.* She had read it twice with the engine running.

At the counter Jonas stood on a step stool with a wooden spoon and a dish the color of a traffic cone, orange Pyrex with the glaze worn off the rim in two pale crescents where thumbs had gone. Callum had brought it every November of his life, full of sweet potatoes under a roof of marshmallow he called structural. It had lived behind the roasting rack for three years, and somebody had taken it down. An index card leaned against the flour canister, soft with grease.

Thea looked at the card. “Is that his recipe?”

“It’s his,” Jonas said, without looking up. “He wrote ‘enough’ for the butter, and I don’t know how much that is.”

“Your father put in too much,” Margit said from the stove.

“He wrote *enough*.”

“He did not know the word.” She had finally put down the potato. “Nine tablespoons, I told him for thirty years, and he said, Ma, it’s a feeling.”

Jonas looked at the card, then at his grandmother’s back, and very carefully put in another tablespoon. Before the marshmallows went on he spooned a little into one of Margit’s flowered teacups and set it on the windowsill behind the canister.

“For tasting,” he said, when Thea looked. “He always kept the taster. He said the cook gets the first one.”

• • •

The bird came out at ten past three. The skin was the color of a violin and rattled when Margit knocked on it, and the thermometer Isla pushed into the thigh read two hundred and one. The gravy had gone to gray paste.

“What’s it supposed to read?” Isla said.

“A hundred and sixty-five,” said Nolan, who had come in from the hall at the sound of the oven door.

“It says two-oh-one.”

“It is resting,” said Margit.

“Tab five says thirty minutes.” Isla bent to the margin. “Does it say what it does while it rests?”

“Nothing, that’s the point of resting,” Thea said.

“Huh, I’d have liked that as a kid.”

Jonas lifted the dish in two oven mitts shaped like fish and carried it toward the table, both arms out, tongue between his teeth. Biscuit lay across the doorway to the hall, which was where Biscuit lay when he wanted to be stepped over.

Jonas stepped. Biscuit rolled.

The Pyrex went out of the fish mitts as if it had been shot. It hit the linoleum and did not bounce, and the sound was enormous and thin, like a window going. Orange glass skated under the stove and the table, and the sweet potatoes slid across the floor in one piece and stopped against Thea’s shoe.

Then Jonas made a sound she had never heard from him, small and high, and folded down onto his hands and knees and under the table, and the cherry oilcloth swung once behind him and hung still.

“Jonas,” said Margit, the turkey lid still in her hand. “Come out of there, there is glass.”

“Grandma, please don’t,” Isla said.

Thea had stood, holding a dish towel with no idea what it was for. The kitchen had stopped reading. It was a floor with glass on it and a boy under a table, and she did not know where to put her feet.

Nolan was four feet from the back door.

She saw it because she had seen it every Thanksgiving for ten years. Past the door was the mudroom, and past that the garage, where he had gone for a wrench nobody needed, for a bag of ice. She had written it in the margin of tab five in the third November: *N: garage, 20 min. Let him.* His hand was on the knob of the door that stuck, his weight on the front foot. She knew exactly how long it took to cross a driveway.

He took his hand off the knob.

He came back along the clean side of the floor, around the glass, and went down to his knees and then to sitting, six foot three of him folded against the table leg. He lifted the edge of the oilcloth with one finger, and Biscuit went in past his elbow like a guest.

Thea had watched him leave a hundred rooms. She had never seen him go under a table.

“Go away,” Jonas said, from inside.

“Can’t, I don’t fit anywhere else.”

“It was his, and I wasn’t even carrying it wrong.”

“Biscuit got you.”

“Don’t make it a joke.”

“No jokes, I promise.” Isla had gone for the broom and was sweeping the near edge of the glass in short strokes, not looking up. “Your dad dropped that dish once, you know, in the driveway.”

“He did not.”

“He ate the sweet potatoes off the lid and called it a rustic presentation.”

Something small and wet came out of the oilcloth that might have been a laugh. “I used to hear that story.”

“Not from me, I never told it right. I used to go out to the garage when it got like this.”

“Everybody knows, you’d come back with ice.”

“We never needed ice.”

“We never needed ice,” Jonas said, and his voice had loosened a quarter turn. “Are you going to go?”

“No.” It came out in one piece. “I’m going to sit here until you want to come out. Could be a while, and my leg’s asleep already.”

Margit lowered herself onto Jonas’s step stool with the lid on her knee and both hands on the lid. Her lips moved on something that was not English.

The stove clock said 3:19, then 3:26. At 3:31 Thea’s knees sat her down, and Isla, finished with the broom, sat beside her.

“He’s been under there twelve minutes,” Isla said, watching Thea’s mouth. “You’re counting.”

“I can’t stop.”

“Me neither,” Isla said, and put her hands between her knees.

At 3:41 the oilcloth lifted and Jonas came out on his hands and knees with a smear of orange on one sock and a beagle at his heels.

“I’m going to change my socks,” he told the floor.

“I’ll come,” said Isla.

“The teacup,” Nolan said, from under the table. “On the windowsill. The taster never went near the floor, if anyone wants to know.”

Jonas stopped at the foot of the stairs. “How much is in it?”

“Enough.”

Jonas went up the back stairs with Isla’s hand between his shoulder blades.

Nolan came out in stages, rubbing his knee, and looked at his mother.

“Ma.”

“Wait until after the turkey.”

“No,” he said, not loudly. “Now, while they’re up there.”

Thea had her coat off the hook and over her arm. She stood in the hall doorway, where at twenty-eight she had been introduced to a family, and when Nolan looked at her across the kitchen she did not say *I’m going*.

“Stay, please,” he said. “You can go after. I’d like it if you heard that I said it.”

“Is it a woman,” Margit said.

“Not like you think.” He took hold of the back of a chair. “Ma, I’m going to say all of it, and I need you to let me get to the end.”

Margit did not say yes. She set the lid on the counter and folded her hands.

“Thursdays,” Nolan said. “For three years I told Thea it was a department meeting, and there isn’t one. There’s a group in the basement at St. Brendan’s for people who’ve lost someone, for Callum, for me. I went the first time three

weeks after the funeral. I sat in the car forty minutes in the lot and then I went in."

At the name, Margit's hand moved on her apron and went still.

"There's a woman named Leona, and her husband died. After group we sat in her car and talked, and then we texted every night for two years. I never touched her, I hugged her once at a door, and that isn't the point."

"What is the point," said Margit.

"I could say it to her. I couldn't say it to you or to Thea. I stood at his funeral four hours saying I was fine, and I said it for three years after, and I wasn't, and I let you believe it. You put soup in my hands and I said thanks and ate it. I'm sorry, and that's all of it."

"And her?" Margit's voice was very even. She did not look at the doorway.

"Thea found out in front of everybody, and I did that. I only wanted you to hear it from me and not from a microphone."

"Hm." Margit turned around and pulled a long sheet from the roll of foil by the stove, and it tore like paper out of a book. She laid it over the turkey, crossed a second over the first, then a third, and tucked the ends under with her thumbs until the bird was a silver loaf, sealed against the room.

"Carry," she said.

Nolan lifted the platter with hands that were not steady. "Where?"

"Table."

He set it at the head, as he always did, and Margit looked past him at Thea.

"You knew."

"Since the thirteenth."

"You came to my table with a binder and said nothing."

"You told me not to tell you what he did."

"I did," Margit said, and her mouth worked and settled. "Sit. A person does not leave before the pie."

"Margit, I shouldn't be here for this."

"You are here, so sit."

• • •

They ate at four-fifteen, on the good plates, at the kitchen table, five and a dog. Margit spoke to no one for the first minutes, and then only to Nolan, and only in the imperative.

"Carve."

He unwrapped the foil, and the slices would not stay slices; they came off the knife in dry tan flakes.

“It crunches,” Isla said.

“It is a crisp bird,” said Margit. She said “Plates” and he passed the plates, said “Salt” and he passed the salt, and when she said “Sit up” he sat up. It went down the table like a rule being read.

Isla looked around the table. “Does anybody want to say something, like grace?”

“Eat,” said Margit.

“That’s not grace.”

“It is in this house.”

“The gravy has a skin,” Isla said.

“Then we eat the skin.”

“It’s like a lid on a pond,” said Jonas, whose socks were dry and whose voice was thin.

“Don’t,” said Isla.

“A good pond.”

Isla made a noise through her nose that could, with effort, have been a laugh.

The rest of the sweet potatoes had gone into the trash with the glass, swept up in newspaper and carried out to the can by Isla, all of it, because Margit said a cafeteria does not argue with glass. The teacup sat on the table. Margit spooned most of it onto Jonas’s plate herself, not meeting his eyes. “Eat. It’s your father’s. It’s enough.”

He ate all of it, like homework, and when it was gone he said very quietly, “It wasn’t too sweet,” and nobody said a thing.

“Gravy?” Isla held up the boat. “It’s mostly skin.”

“I’ll take the skin.”

“That’s the spirit,” said Isla, without any, and passed the boat.

Nolan sat three chairs from his mother with his hands in his lap between bites. Twice he started a sentence, and twice Margit said “Beans,” and he passed the beans.

Jonas pushed what was left in the teacup three inches toward his uncle. “You can have some of Dad’s.”

“Thanks, a small one.”

“It’s all small, it’s a teacup.”

“Then one spoon,” Nolan said, and took one. Margit took the teacup from him and set it back by Jonas, and her hand on the rim was not steady.

Jonas said “Thea,” the first thing he had said to her since the glass. “Are you coming Christmas?”

“I’m coming for an hour today. I’m not sure about Christmas.”

Jonas put down his fork. “Is the pie any good?”

“It’s from the bakery, so it’s very good.”

“Then it will be eaten,” said Margit, to the pie.

At 5:02 Margit stood and said, “Plates,” and began to clear, and that was the end of the meal.

• • •

It was dark and twenty-eight degrees in the driveway. Thea had her keys out and, in her other hand, a foil bundle Margit had pushed at her at the door with her face turned to the stove. The binder was still on its chair in the kitchen, open to tab five. Nobody had asked her to take it, and she had not asked.

The back door banged behind her.

“Wait,” said Isla, and came down the three steps with her coat open and no hat, and stopped by the CR-V with her arms wrapped around herself. “Grandma talked to Uncle Nolan the whole time we were upstairs. I could hear it through the floor. Now it’s only orders.”

“Isla.”

“Don’t tell me she’s fine.”

“I wasn’t going to.”

“Good, everyone’s been doing it all day. I won’t ask what it was. Somebody will tell me or nobody will, and that’s usually how it goes.”

Isla looked at the lit window, where Margit’s shape crossed with a stack of plates. “You planned Dad’s funeral in six days.”

“I did.”

“Two hundred and some people and a florist you fired for crying. And Uncle Nolan stood at the front of the church like a lamp. Somebody turned him on and everyone walked around him.” Her breath showed, and Callum’s eyebrows didn’t move. “You were standing right there. Did you ever ask him?”

Thea held the foil bundle against her coat, warm through the foil.

“No,” she said.

“Neither did I.” Isla pulled her coat shut. “Are you leaving him?”

“I don’t know.”

“Okay.” She said it like a clerk filing a form. “That’s the first time anybody’s said that to me. Everybody else says ‘we’ll see.’”

“I’m sorry.”

“Don’t be.” She backed toward the steps. “Thanks for the pie, though. It was the only thing today that came out right. I just wanted somebody to say it.” She went up the three steps, and the door banged, and Thea heard the sound of it going through the house, the whole house knowing. She stayed where she was.

Through the window over the sink, Margit handed Nolan a wet plate without turning her head. He dried it and held out his hand.

Chapter 11 — The Hour

The timer was a white plastic dial the size of a hockey puck. Thea had taken it out of the garment-steamer drawer because the wall clock in the studio ran two minutes fast and she did not want to argue with anything tonight. She set it on the corner of the desk facing the client chair and turned it a quarter inch so the sixty sat straight up at the top.

“That’s from the steamer drawer,” Dimitra said from the doorway. She had her coat buttoned to the chin and was not leaving. “I use that for sleeves.”

“I’ll put it back.”

“I could be in the copy room pretending to collate.”

“No.”

Dimitra studied the door frame and said to it, “If it goes past an hour, you call me. I don’t care what time.”

“It won’t go past an hour.”

“Everything goes past,” said Dimitra, and went. On the landing her boots met a heavier pair coming up slow, and the stairwell held still. Thea heard, through the door, “Mr. Moravec,” in a voice with nothing wrong in it, and “Dimitra,” in a voice that had been rubbed raw and put back. Then the street door banged, and the stair that always told on people told on him. Two taps, then the pause.

He came in the way you come into a room where somebody is sleeping. Gray sweater, or its twin. His hands hung at his sides, big and empty.

“I left Biscuit home,” Nolan said. “I told him it’s a listening thing and he’d have opinions.”

“Sit.”

He sat in the green chair, all the way back, hands on his knees. Eight feet of floorboard lay between his shoes and her desk, and the red stripe from Haskell’s neon lay across the planks and up the leg of his cords. She had made peppermint from Odessa’s tin and set the mug on the boards beside the chair leg, not in his hand.

“Rules,” she said. The yellow pad was squared to the edge of the blotter; she had written four lines on it at five o’clock. “One hour. I talk. You don’t. You don’t interrupt, and you don’t defend. You don’t explain, and you don’t fix. If I say something that’s wrong, you let it be wrong.”

“What if it’s not wrong?”

“Then you let it stand anyway. It’s my hour. And you don’t say you’re sorry until the timer goes. Sorry ends things, and I’m not ready for this to end.”

He took the rule the way somebody takes a job he has just been handed. His thumb found a brass tack on the arm of the chair.

“Thursday, in the driveway, Isla asked me if I ever asked you,” Thea said. “At the funeral. How you were.” She kept her eyes on the pad. “I said no. I’m not asking now, either. This is what I’ve got instead.”

She turned the dial to sixty. It began to tick, a small dry sound, like a pencil tapped on a desk in another room.

For a count of ten nothing came. Nolan let the count go by without helping. Then the first sentence was simply in her mouth, plain as a bus schedule.

“The first florist cried,” she said. “Ruth Ann Pruitt. Tuesday afternoon, in her shop, when I read her the order. Her Danny played on his Saturday team, the boy with the braces. She said she’d do it at cost and stood there crying into the buckets, and I thought, I can’t have that at the delivery. So I thanked her and called the next name on my list, a grower in Holland who owed me a favor. Sunflowers and yellow freesia in October. The second florist never cried once. She was early.” Her voice was level. “I never called Ruth Ann back. I buy my ribbon from her. I’ve bought it from her for three years and I’ve never once said his name in that shop.”

The dial said fifty-six.

“Friday night I cut the slideshow at this desk. Two hundred and twelve photographs, eight minutes. At three in the morning I took out the one of him asleep in a lawn chair at Dunmore with a fishing hat over his face. It was the best picture of him there was. It broke the rhythm.” She waited, and the next thing came up without being sent for. “He called me Clipboard. Every Christmas. *Here she comes, Clipboard.* I never once told him I liked it.”

Nolan made a sound with no word in it, like a door being held shut from the wrong side. His hand came off his knee, and she looked at it, and it went back.

“Thank you,” she said.

The dial said fifty-two.

“I allowed three hours for the line. It ran four hours and ten minutes. I stood next to you the whole time with the clipboard, doing the math. The hall was booked until six. The caterer’s overtime started at five-thirty. And you

said it. I'm fine. To the man from the Elks. To the man who sold him his first truck, who put his whole face on your shirt and cried while you patted his back and said it again. I watched you do it two hundred times."

His chin had dropped. He did not wipe his face. It ran into his collar.

"And every time you said it, I was relieved."

The ticking went on.

"It was like somebody taking a box off my stack. I had two hundred people and a caterer to hold up, and I could not have held one more thing, and you were standing right there falling apart in the most polite way a person has ever fallen apart, and I thought, thank God, he's managing." She tapped the blank page once. "I'm not saying that so you'll tell me it's all right. You're not allowed to tell me anything. It's what happened.

"Three weeks after, you said something about a department thing. I was on the phone with a florist and I gave my husband a thumbs-up without looking up." She held up her own hand, thumb out, and lowered it. "And that winter you started coming home on Thursdays like somebody had opened a window in you. You put your keys in the bowl on the first try. You'd come up behind my chair and put your chin on top of my head, and I'd keep typing. I told Odessa in March, he's getting better. I said it like I'd done it. I made Thursday green."

The dial said forty.

She got up. She could not say the next part to his face, and it was a relief to find that out early. She crossed to the glass on Water Street and stood with her toes at the baseboard, and the window gave her the room back, dimmed and doubled: the desk lamp, the ticking dial, the green chair, the man in it.

"And you went to that room because it was easier than me." She turned from the window to say it, flat, straight at him. "You found a woman who had never seen you handle a single thing."

His whole body came forward an inch. It was all in his hands: they closed on his knees, the tendons stood up in the backs of them, and his mouth shaped the front edge of a very large no. He took hold of it with both hands and set it down.

He sat back. Sweat had come through the gray wool at his collar in a dark half-moon. His right knee had begun to jump, and he put his palm on it and held it down, the way he held down a kitchen drawer that wouldn't shut.

"That wasn't fair," Thea said, after a while. "I don't know if it's true. I wanted to see what you'd do with it."

He kept his eyes shut. His head dipped once toward the floor.
She turned back to the glass.

“Last October you were in the bathroom with the fan on. I stood in the hall with a ginger ale and a sleeve of saltines because I thought you had a stomach thing. I could hear the fan. I heard you laugh, once, with your mouth shut.” She tilted her head toward the sound as if it were still coming through the wall. “Then I put the can down on the floor by the door and I went to bed.”

Nolan’s lips moved. He pressed them together until they went white.

“I knew,” Thea said. “I want to be exact. I didn’t know what. I knew a man who comes home from a department meeting humming has not been at a department meeting. I knew it by the first winter. I put it where I put everything I can’t schedule, and I did not ask, because I was afraid of—”

She stopped.

The sentence stood in the room with its end cut off. She had the word. It was sitting behind her teeth, and she put her palm flat on the glass to look for it there, and the glass was cold and gave her nothing.

He did not finish it for her. Every kind thing was in him, lined up at the back of his mouth, the best sentence-finisher in Port Ellery, a man who had talked her down off three hundred ledges with a joke and a hand on her arm. In the black window he sat with his thumb on the brass tack and his wet face turned up, and he waited.

She counted, because she counted. Ninety seconds. He let every one of them go by.

“—the answer,” Thea said.

It came out small, not her work voice. She said it to the window.

“Not that it was somebody. That there would be an answer, and it would need something from me, and I’d have to find out if I had it. So I took the hum. I took the chin on my head.” She turned around at last and pushed her hair off her forehead with the back of her wrist; the pen she had forgotten was in it slid sideways, and she left it. “You lied to me for three years. And I didn’t ask. Those are two separate things, and I won’t put them in one pile so it’s easier for either of us. The lie is yours. All of it. The not asking is mine.”

The dial said nine.

“That’s what I have. It isn’t all of it. It’s what fit.”

She stopped talking. He did not move, and she did not make him. The white pointer came around toward the zero by slow clicks, like the minute hand on a hotel clock at the end of a ten-hour load-in, and she wanted it to get

there and did not want it to. The last minutes went by with a man's breathing, ragged at first, then slower, then even.

The bell went off like a bicycle.

Nolan took his thumb off the tack. His hand opened on his knee, palm up, red from the pressure of the brass.

"I'm sorry," he said. His voice was a ruin; he stopped, and fixed it, and said it again so she would get all of it. "I'm sorry I made you the only one who didn't get to know. I did that. On purpose, every week."

She sat down at the desk very slowly. She had braced for *I'm sorry for what I did*, which she could have put in a box. This one had no box.

"I'm still not coming home," Thea said.

"I know."

"Is there something you want me to do with it?" His voice had come back in pieces. "With what you said. I don't know what to do with my hands."

"Not tonight. Don't make a plan. Don't write me a list of what you'll do differently." She heard whose sentence that was, and let it stand in the room anyway. "Go home. Know it."

"Okay."

She tore the top sheet off the pad, folded it in three, and put it in her pocket without reading it. She carried the timer to the drawer and shut it in. The mug sat on the floor by the chair leg, untouched, the mint long gone cold.

He stayed in the green chair, hands open on his knees, until she said, "You can get up." Then he got up.

Chapter 12 — The Table, Again

The CR-V had parked nose in.

Through the Subaru's windshield, at ten past six, it sat gray and dark-windowed with its tail hanging out toward the road, so that a driver leaving would have to back up. In ten years he had never parked that way.

The driver's door opened. He got out in sections, as he got out of everything, and crossed the gravel toward her with both hands out of his pockets and in plain view. He tapped twice on her window, and she lowered it three inches.

"Forward," she said.

"Forward." He looked back at the CR-V as if it belonged to a colleague. "I figured if I could leave fast, I'd think about leaving. So I made it hard."

"It's a lousy plan."

"It's the only one I've got that you didn't write."

She let that sit. He had shaved all the way under the chin this time, and a thread was coming loose from the cuff of his coat that she did not reach for.

"The rules," she said. "You sit where you sit. You don't look for me. You don't talk because I'm there."

"What if I don't talk at all?"

"Then you don't, and Abel says that counts."

"What do I do with my hands? Honestly. I've never had an audience that wasn't looking at the clock."

"I want to see what they do." She said it plainly. "I'm not there to catch you. I'm there to see it."

He nodded and did not go. His breath fogged the three inches of open glass.

"One more thing, and it isn't about tonight." He looked at the roof of the Subaru instead of her. "The ninety. At the boathouse. What do they think happened?"

She had not expected it, and her hands knew it before she did; they went to the wheel. "Dimitra told them groom's nerves."

"And what do they think you did?"

"Walked out on a man crying at the altar." It came out flatter than she meant. "Hana Vos offered to let me hand her wedding to my assistant. Two women in the bakery stopped talking when I came in, and one of them was a bride from 2021. I said family emergency to a florist on Tuesday, and she said,

oh, honey, I heard, in a voice I've used on brides." She looked at the dashboard clock. "It's my work, Nolan. I sell people the day going right."

He took it standing still. "That's mine," he said. "I did that in your room, in front of your people. I'd like to put it right in whatever way you want it put right. Not a way I pick. You tell me, and I'll do it."

"I don't know what I want."

"Then tell me when you do. It doesn't expire."

"Go in, Nolan."

He went, and his back crossed the lot and stopped at the top of the basement stairs, where the burnt-coffee smell would reach him first. His shoulders came up around his ears. Then he went down, and the folding chair that propped the door took his shadow and gave it back.

At six twenty-four she locked the car.

• • •

Someone had changed the fluorescent tube. It hummed steady now over the ring, and without the stutter the room looked older and more honest.

Nolan sat in the chair nearest the stairs, coat on, a paper cup in his hands that he had not drunk from. He had moved from the radiator.

Abel crossed the linoleum at his own speed. "You are five minutes early."

"I said I would be."

"Ring or chair?"

"You came back," said Harold, from the ring, not getting up. He had a shortbread in one huge hand and was holding it like a bird.

"I was told the door would be open."

"He says that to everybody." Harold considered the shortbread. "It's true, though. That's the aggravating part."

"Ring," Thea told Abel. "I came to see."

"It is a good reason to sit in a ring. It is not the usual one." He pointed with two fingers at a gap between the woman in the Michigan State sweatshirt and the boy who could not take the truck out of the driveway. "There. You may say your name or nothing. They are used to guests. They have all been one."

She sat. The boy moved his chair an inch away from her, out of manners, and then an inch back. From that chair all of Nolan's face was in view, and the empty chair directly across from his.

"Three Thursdays," Abel said across the ring, as mild as a forecast.

Nolan's cup tipped a degree. "Yes. I'm sorry."

“The urn has not been fixed.”

“I could take a look at it.”

“You could sit,” said Abel.

Harold made a sound in his nose that was almost a laugh.

At six twenty-eight the stairs creaked and Leona Hale came down them with her lanyard in her fist and her coat still buttoned. Her eyes found Thea in the ring. Her stride broke for the length of one step and did not break again. She crossed to the chair opposite Nolan, set a travel mug on the floor by her foot, and folded her hands.

Nolan looked at the tissue box. Leona looked at the tissue box. It sat on its stool between them and took both looks.

At six-thirty nobody said welcome, and Thea did not lean toward the front of the room, because there was no front. She kept her eyes on Nolan’s feet.

“I would like to ask something tonight,” Abel said. “You may answer it or not. What did grief make you leave? A room, a habit, a chair at a table.”

“The table,” said the woman in the sweatshirt. “I eat at the counter. Standing up, like somebody’s about to call me away. Since March.”

“School,” said the boy beside Thea, to his knees. “Not officially. I still have the parking pass.”

“The bedroom,” said Harold. His big hands lay open on his thighs. “I sleep in the recliner. Carol’s side’s got her glasses on it. I can’t get in past the glasses.”

“What is on the recliner with you?” said Abel.

Harold looked up as if he had been caught at something. “Her cardigan. The blue one. It still smells like the car.”

“Thank you, Harold.”

Across the ring Leona turned her wedding ring a quarter inch on her finger and turned it back. She said nothing, and nobody asked her to.

Then came a long stretch with no one in it. Thea kept her hands on her knees, pressing, so they would be somewhere.

“He wasn’t supposed to be the one who left,” Nolan said.

He said it to the floor. The coffee in his cup made small rings, like a glass on a table when a truck goes by. His voice was low and flat, with no joke ahead of it and none behind.

His weight came forward in the chair and his heels lifted off the linoleum. Thea knew that lift from their kitchen table and the studio doorway, the first half of every room he had ever left.

She did not move or say his name, because she had told him she would only watch.

The heels came down, slowly, flat. He set the cup on the floor between his shoes as if it were full to the brim, put his hands on his knees, and stayed.

“Thank you, Nolan,” said Abel. That was all of it.

A woman near Abel, who had not spoken before, said, “I have nine Pyrex dishes in my front hall. Masking tape on the bottoms, everybody’s name. I can’t take them back. If I take them back, nobody has a reason to come by.”

Thea had once kept a spreadsheet of those, and column F was return dates. At eight Abel said, “We will stop there. Thank you for staying.”

• • •

They stood up the way people stand in a hospital corridor, bracing on the chair backs. Thea took her scarf off the hook. Leona had her coat on already and was at the foot of the stairs when Nolan said her name.

“Leona.”

It was not loud, and it was not lowered. He had not moved toward her. He stood by his folded chair with his hands where everyone could see them.

She turned on the bottom step.

“I’m going to say this once, and I’m going to say it here, so it’s been said in front of somebody.” His voice was short, the way it went when it was real. “I haven’t written you since the eighth. I won’t. I blocked the number in the car tonight before I came down. I won’t wait in the lot.” He swallowed. “And I’m coming two more Thursdays, because I told Abel I wouldn’t just vanish on the ring, and then the chair’s yours. I’m going somewhere else.”

Leona did not answer at once. Harold, halfway into his coat, went very still with one arm in a sleeve.

“You were here first,” she said.

“I was. You were here because you needed it. I was here because I needed it, and because you were across from me, and I can’t sort out which one it was anymore.” He looked at the folded chair. “So I’m the one who goes.”

Leona’s hand tightened on the rail. “That isn’t yours to give me.”

“It’s mine to stop taking.”

Something moved in her face and was put away. She checked her watch with the quick exact glance of a woman who counted doses. “Then I’ll take the chair. Don’t ask after Felix. If you need to know I’m alive, ask Abel.”

“I won’t ask.”

“Say it anyway. You’ve earned the right to be useless.” She looked past him then, to the coat rack and the woman with the scarf hanging from one fist. Leona gave one small nod, and Thea returned it. Neither looked away first, and then Leona went up the stairs with the travel mug in her hand and the lanyard swinging against her thigh.

Nolan crossed three paces and stopped an arm’s length from Thea, looking at the hooks.

“I didn’t tell you I was going to do that,” he said, low. “I didn’t want it to be for you.”

“Was it?”

“Some.” He did not dress it up. “Not most.”

“Where will you go?”

“There’s a woman in Holland. A counselor, Mondays at five. Abel gave me a list the week you gave me the terms, and I called the second name myself.” His mouth went crooked. “You don’t get the name. I’m sorry. I need one thing you can’t make better.”

She found that she did not want the name, and the not-wanting surprised her so much she nearly laughed.

“Back out slow,” she said. “Watch the fence.”

“I teach physics.”

“That’s why I said it.”

He went up the stairs, each step heavy and deliberate and loud enough that she would know exactly where he was, until the door at the top let in cold air and shut.

• • •

The room emptied: Harold, then the sweatshirt woman, then the boy, who said “Night” to the floor in her general direction. Thea took the nearest chair, folded it, and carried it to the rack, because there were chairs and there was a rack and she did not know what else to do with her hands. Abel did not stop her. He poured the dregs of the urn into the corner sink, slowly, as if there might be an argument.

She had folded eight before he spoke.

“The first night you came, I asked you a question, and you did not answer it.”

"If he'd told me the first Thursday." The ninth chair clanged against the eighth. "I'd have made a plan. A laminated card with your number and the hours, a ride schedule if he didn't want to drive, an insurance column."

"And what would the card have done?"

"Made it mine." She hung the chair on the rack. It swung once and hung. "He could have said no to the card. He had a mouth. He didn't use it."

"That is also true," said Abel, and rinsed the urn.

"He's leaving your Table."

"He telephoned me on Monday to tell me. I asked him whether he was leaving it for you. He said he was leaving it so that it would stop being a place he went instead of home." Abel dried his hands on the cardigan, slowly. "I do not lose people from that ring often. Usually it is because they are better. Sometimes it is because they are honest. This is the second kind. It is also a loss. He loved that chair."

"I know."

"Do you?"

She opened her mouth for the answer she would have given a client, which had the word *absolutely* in it.

"I'm learning it," she said.

"Good," said Abel. "That is a true one."

Eleven chairs hung on the rack. One was left, the brown one by the coat hooks, a yard back from where the ring had been. She had it folded and halfway to the wall before Abel came and took it out of her hands. He shook it open with one flick of his long wrist and set it down where it had been, square to the hooks.

"Leave that one out," he said. "Somebody will not be sure on Thursday."

Chapter 13 — Eight to Midnight

“It’s the lighting,” the florist said.

“It’s a third short, and your cooler went down.” Thea stood in the middle of the empty ballroom with her head tipped back, studying the arch the way you study an X-ray. Six feet of white birch. Cream ranunculus, thick at the bottom and thinning toward the top like a man’s hair.

“It went Thursday night.” The florist wore a green apron and had soil ground into the creases of her hands; she had been up since three. “I cut every stem I had. Hana’s going to see it.”

“Hana’s going to see it if we let her.” It was ten past two, and a porter was running a vacuum down the carpet in stripes. Thea thumbed the walkie and said, “Dimitra.”

“Go.”

“The seeded eucalyptus in the studio cooler, the bucket from the eighth, here in twenty minutes. And ask the banquet manager for the paperwhites in the lobby urns.”

“Those paperwhites are his wife’s.”

“Everything in this hotel is his wife’s. Tell him the croissants are on me again.”

“On it.”

The florist stared at her. “You’re going to wire greens into my arch.”

“Our arch, and is that a ladder?”

“It’s a stepstool.”

“Then hold it,” Thea said. There was a roll of green floral tape and a spool of wire in the go-bag. By the time the eucalyptus came through the service doors in Dimitra’s arms, wet and silver, smelling like a cough drop, Thea had stripped the sample posies to their stems and laid them in a row. “Cut at an angle so they look like they grew there.”

“Did you sleep last night?” the florist asked, handing up a stem.

“Some.”

“That’s not much of an answer.”

“It’s a stem, so hand me another.”

By ten to three the arch had its top back, gray-green against the cream, and Thea came down the stepstool with wire cuts across both thumbs. Hana arrived at three in a robe and hair rollers, her tabbed portfolio under one arm, and walked once all the way around it.

“It’s different.”

"It's the arch."

"It's greener than the rendering. The rendering has no eucalyptus."

"It rained on the rendering," said Thea.

Hana looked at her. "Rowan said I shouldn't ask how you are today. He wrote it on my hand." She held it up: *DON'T ASK*, in blue ballpoint across her fingers.

"He's right."

"I'm asking."

"Then I'm working, which is the better of the two options. Go get your hair finished. Your grandmother's bringing the cake at three-fifteen."

Hana went. At twenty to four she was back in the ballroom doorway with one roller still in, holding her phone out like evidence.

"She said three-fifteen," said Hana, and they both looked at the clock, which said 3:41.

. . .

The grandmother was in the parking lot of the other hotel on the lake road, the one with the same blue awning, standing beside a Buick with its hazards on and a three-tier cake belted into the back seat.

"I was told Harbor," she said.

"This is the Harbor Inn. The wedding's at the Harbor Grand."

"They ought to be more distinct. The girl at the desk didn't know any Hana. She offered me a muffin."

"That was kind of her." Thea folded back the moving blankets in the cargo bay of the Subaru, where two straps and a sheet of shelf liner lay under them as always. "Can you ride with me if I go slowly?"

"I will not leave my cake."

"It rides with us, and you hold the door."

They carried it together, the grandmother at the bottom tier with both palms flat, Thea at the top with her fingertips under the board. Spice cake, from the smell, almond and orange peel. The grandmother climbed in without help and settled her handbag on her knees. She was eighty if she was a day, in a camel coat and a church hat.

"You're the one," she said.

"The planner."

"The one whose husband said another woman's name at his ceremony. Hana tells me everything, so I'm sorry for your trouble." She settled the

handbag. “At my bridge table they say you left him crying at the altar and walked out like a queen. I told them I’d have walked faster.”

“Thank you.”

“In 1971 my husband went to the Elks lodge and came home at four in the morning and wouldn’t say where. He’d sat in a diner parking lot four hours, not doing anything.” The grandmother kept her eyes on the road. “I made a cake every day that month. Seventeen cakes, and we ate every one.”

“Did you ever find out why?”

“He said he couldn’t be in the house. I told him the house had been there a long time and was fine with him.” She lifted one gloved finger. “Slower, please, that’s a speed bump.”

Thea took the whole lake road at nine miles an hour. When she pulled into the loading bay Dimitra was waiting with a rolling cart and a face of perfect calm.

“The photographer wants the cake in seven minutes. I’ve been stalling him with the quartet. Hana’s in the bathroom saying her promises to the mirror in a very flat voice.”

“Roll it in.”

“On it, ma’am. The groom’s father’s girlfriend has your seat, so I’ll put you in the front.”

“I’ll take it,” said the grandmother. “I’m not afraid of her.”

• • •

At 6:31 Pilar Duarte stood under the layered arch in her plum stole and said, “Welcome.” Thea stood at the back wall with the walkie low at her hip and Dimitra on the aisle, and told herself she was only there in case.

Hana read her vows from a color-coded card, her voice so level the back row leaned to look for the seam. “I promise to prioritize us. I promise to stop closing the cabinets behind you,” she said, and looked up, “because it’s the only thing I do that you never notice. And I’d like you to notice.”

Rowan laughed first, then put one hand over his mouth, then the other. In the second row somebody’s aunt said “Oh.”

At 6:42 Pilar found Thea across the room and raised two fingers for soft music, and Thea cued the quartet with a lift of her chin.

The tears ran fourteen seconds. She timed them because it was her job to.

“I budgeted eight,” she said under her breath, and Pilar, who was too far away to have caught it, smiled at the floor.

At the bar afterward Pilar unclipped the mic and handed her the body pack. "Twenty minutes you didn't move. You were holding that wall up."

"I was working."

"I know what you were doing. I asked how you are."

"It's a quarter to nine, Pilar. I have a toast at nine-fifteen."

"There's always a toast, Thea." Pilar touched her sleeve with two fingers, lightly, and took them away. "Drink some water. Standing counts."

• • •

At twenty to one Dimitra's voice came over the walkie from the third-floor suite, where she was counting cufflinks into a velvet box. *Linen's six napkins short, I'm on it, stay out of it, go sit somewhere.*

So Thea sat on the loading dock, a concrete shelf at truck height with a rubber bumper and one sodium lamp, the roll-up door cranked halfway. A stack of folded rental chairs made a bench, and she sat with her legs hanging over the drop and the work coat zipped to her chin, breathing diesel and lake air. Then she took out her phone, found the number she had not dialed since before the boathouse, and put it to her ear before she could organize what to say.

It rang once.

"Who's hurt?"

His voice came fast and breathless from somewhere dark. He sat up, and the headboard knocked the wall.

"Nobody's hurt. I'm on a loading dock."

A long breath went out of him. "Okay, hi."

"Hi."

Behind him was the house she had left in a dress: the radiator under the window, the wet whistle of an old dog sleeping through his own dream.

"I don't have anything to say, and I want that clear," Thea said. "I'm not calling about anything."

"That's fine."

"Say something small."

"Biscuit's on your side," said Nolan. "Has been since the eighth. He puts his chin on the pillow like it's a job."

"He always did that."

"He did it with the lamp off. Now he does it with the lamp on, and I think he's checking."

She laughed, short, and it did not hurt. “Is he eating?”

“He ate a sock on Tuesday.” He said it like a man reading a lab result. “It came out Thursday. The vet said *resilient* four times. The sock is in a bag in the freezer because I couldn’t throw it away.”

“Why is it in the freezer?”

“I didn’t want to be the one who threw out the sock.”

She put her head back against the cold wall. “Is that a physics principle?”

“It’s more of a character flaw.”

She laughed again, and it went thin at the end. “Tell me about school,” she said quickly.

“Friction, with sophomores. I have a ramp and a wooden block, and a girl in third period has decided it’s a personal attack. Did you ever take physics?”

“Earth science.”

“That’s the same thing with rocks.”

“Was that a question?”

“I think it was.”

“Tonight you get one,” said Thea. “Don’t spend it on rocks.”

“Then I’m saving it. Static friction is bigger than kinetic. It takes more to start a thing moving than to keep it moving. Every sophomore writes it backwards on the first quiz. Fourteen of them right now think the block wants to slide.”

“Doesn’t it?”

“Not until you push,” he said, and stopped. “I’m talking too much.”

“You’re not talking too much.”

“I do it when I’m...” She waited, and he did not finish, and she was oddly grateful. “Tell me about your day. It’s not a question, it’s a request.”

“It’s a request,” Thea said. “The florist’s cooler went down.”

She told him about the arch and the grandmother with the cake in a seat belt, then Pilar and the water. She went too fast and then slowed, and somewhere around the speed bump it came to her that he had not said one word since she started. No *that sounds exhausting*, no *you shouldn’t have to*. He was only listening, and the silence had a shape, a man leaning on a counter with his whole weight. Once she lost a sentence halfway through. He waited long enough that she found it again.

“She made seventeen cakes in 1971,” Thea said. “Her husband sat four hours in a diner parking lot and wouldn’t say why.”

Nolan said nothing.

“The house had been there a long time, she told him. And it was fine with him.”

“That’s a good line.” His voice was very even. “I’m going to leave that one alone.”

“Don’t.”

She was quiet long enough that he said her name, once, to check the line.

“I know what I want,” she said. “About the ninety.”

He did not say anything. She heard him sit up straighter, the headboard again.

“Write to them. Every one of them, on paper, in your handwriting. Not her name, and not the group. That it was yours, three years of it, and that I ended the ceremony and I was right to.” She had not known the sentence until it was out, and it was exactly the right length. “Don’t ask anybody to understand. Don’t explain the funeral. Don’t make it about how sad you were.”

“Yes.”

“Dimitra has the guest list. Ask her for it yourself. She’ll charge you her hourly, and you’ll pay it.”

“Yes.”

“I don’t want to read it first.”

“You won’t,” said Nolan. “Ninety. Some of them teach down the hall from me.”

“I know who they are. I seated them.”

“I know you did.” A pause, and his voice went low and plain. “Thank you for telling me what. I’d have done it wrong if I’d picked.”

It was a quarter past one. He told her about a woman in the vet’s waiting room with a three-legged cat in a sweater. She told him the quartet had played the wrong Pachelbel and nobody caught it. She told him about the six napkins. He did not ask to come over or whether she was coming home. She did not say she forgave him, and he did not say he needed her to, and the dock lamp made a small yellow room out of the dark.

At 1:28 the roll-up door went all the way up with a clatter that rang in her teeth.

Dimitra stood in the lit gap in her socks, clipboard against her chest. “Thea, the rental truck’s early. The driver wants a signature or he leaves the chairs on the curb.”

“Coming.”

“Also, the napkins were in the dessert fridge.”

“Of course they were,” Thea said, and put the phone back to her mouth. “I have to go.”

“It’s a work thing,” Nolan said. “Go.”

“Tomorrow. One line, and don’t skip it. Goodnight, Nolan.”

“I wouldn’t, and goodnight, Thea.”

The screen said 50:12. She stood under the lamp until her breath quit hanging, then went in and let the heavy door lower itself.

Part Three — The Showing Up

I'll show up, even when it isn't my turn.

Chapter 14 — The Thread

“The lock’s on Never,” Nolan said. “I went into settings and put everything on Never. It won’t ask you for anything.”

He stood on the landing outside the studio door with Biscuit’s red leash wound twice around one fist and the phone held out in the other, face up, at the full length of his arm. The stairwell bulb had been dead since October, and the only light, ten to six on a Sunday evening, came up from Water Street through the window at the turn of the stairs and fell across the cracked corner and the wiped screen, where the arcs of the cloth showed.

Thea took it, warm from his hand.

“You cleaned it.”

“It had a thumbprint situation.” He handed her the leash, and Biscuit sat down on her shoe. “He’s had supper, and he gets a biscuit at nine.”

“Biscuit gets a biscuit.”

“It’s a lot of pressure to put on a name.” The smile came up and went out before it got anywhere. He turned his left hand over, and across the palm, in ballpoint, it said 9 *BISCUIT*. Under it, smaller, it said 6:14.

“What’s six-fourteen?”

“The thing I came up the stairs to say before you start.” He closed the hand. “It isn’t in the thread. The thread’s messages. On the eighth, at six-twelve, I wrote her one line, and you’ll see it. At six-fourteen I called her. Four minutes. It’s in the call log, under Recents, and you wouldn’t have looked there, because you’d be reading in order. I’m telling you so you don’t find it.”

She stood with the phone in one hand and the leash in the other. “What did you say for four minutes?”

“That I couldn’t do it. She said, then don’t, and tell her why. I said I’d tell you after.” He looked at the dead bulb. “After was on the run-of-show.”

Thea said nothing. Down on Water Street a car went by slowly with its radio on and was gone.

“The other thing,” he said. “Dimitra gave me the list at noon. She charged me sixty-five an hour and timed it on her phone in front of me. I’ve done thirty-one envelopes. I’ll do the rest tonight. They go in the box at the post office tomorrow at six-forty, before school.”

“Thirty-one.”

“My hand cramps at about twelve. I’m doing them in twelves.” He put both hands in his jacket pockets, as if there were something in them he had no

intention of using. "That's all. Nothing's deleted. I haven't opened it since I held it out to you."

"What are you using?"

"The old phone out of the drawer. I moved my card over, same number. And the number's on his tag, if you need me."

"So I call the dog."

"You call the dog."

She almost laughed, and he saw it, and did not take it.

"Don't tell me what's in it," she said. "If you tell me, I'll read it as your version."

"Right." He looked at the stairwell. "I could sit down there, in case you need something."

"I won't."

He started down with a hand on the rail, and on the third stair, the one that complained, he stopped with his back to her.

"Did you eat?" he said.

It was how he had ended every phone call for eleven years. "Did you?"

"A grilled cheese, which was a sandwich in the legal sense."

"Go."

He went, and the street door opened below and, because he was Nolan, he held it so it wouldn't bang.

• • •

She ran it like a load-in. The overheads went off, and the desk lamp went on with its shade tipped to light the blotter and nothing else. Biscuit turned three times on the go-bag by her chair and dropped down with a groan that had a whole opinion in it.

"Don't start," she told him. "I know what it looks like."

On the yellow legal pad she wrote across the top, in capitals, READ IN ORDER, NO SEARCH, NO SKIPPING. Under it she drew a line and wrote *CRUEL*: and left a space after the colon wide enough for a tally.

She opened Recents first, because he had told her to, and there it was, eleven lines down: *Leona*, Sunday, 6:14 AM, 4m 02s. She looked at it for a while. Then she went back to the beginning.

The thread was longer than she had thought a thread could be. It took four minutes of scrolling, the messages going by like a platform seen from a train,

to reach the top, his on one side, hers on the other, and above them both, small and gray, Aug 22, 2024.

9:47 PM. Nolan: "This is Nolan. You gave me this number for if you missed a Thursday. You didn't miss a Thursday. I wanted to see if it worked."

Leona: "It works."

Nolan: "Great. That's all I had. Sorry."

Leona: "Goodnight, Nolan."

That was the whole of the first night. Thea read it twice, as she would have read a vendor's first email, for tone, and it had none. At 9:47 that Thursday she had been at this desk doing the late books, eight blocks from the bathroom he'd been sitting in with the fan on.

By the end of that first week it was every night, and the messages got longer while the apologies got shorter. By the second week they were Hale and Moravec, signing off *Goodnight, Hale* and *Goodnight, Moravec*.

Then September, 10:58 PM.

Nolan: "I never told you the end of the funeral. She had it planned by Thursday. Two hundred chairs, a florist who didn't cry, a slideshow she cut at 3 a.m., and it was perfect. I stood in the receiving line thinking, this is the kindest thing anyone has ever done for me, and I want to lie down on the floor of that hall."

Leona: "Did you tell her that?"

Nolan: "I told her the slideshow was great."

She had sat at this desk until three on the Friday night with two hundred and twelve photographs, and the studio door had opened on a shape in socks with a thermos. *Want coffee?* he'd said, and she'd said, *Go to bed, I've got it*.

She wrote nothing under CRUEL.

Two days later, 7:02 AM.

Nolan: "I put a passcode on my phone yesterday. Eleven years without one."

Leona: "Why yesterday?"

Nolan: "You know why."

Thea read it once. She drew a second line on the pad, beside the first, and after a moment wrote at the top of it *CHOSE*: and put one mark underneath.

In October Leona had a bad day behind her. *Does Thea ever just sit?* she wrote, and then, eleven minutes later, before he'd answered: *She sounds exhausting*.

Nolan: "Don't."

Nolan: "She's the best person I know. That is the entire problem."

Leona: "That was cheap, I'm sorry. Take it back."

Nolan: "Taken."

It was the nearest thing to a cruelty in two months of thread, and the man she had come to catch had caught it himself and handed it back. CRUEL stayed white.

Her own phone buzzed face down on the blotter. Odessa: "Alive?"

Thea: "Reading."

Odessa: "I am not coming over. I am on my couch, not coming over. Eat a cracker."

She did not eat one. The dog sighed against her ankle, and she went back to the glass.

• • •

The twenty-second of October, 2024, the first anniversary, 11:20 PM.

Nolan: "I used to think, if I ever came apart, there was one person I'd get to do it in front of. I don't know when that went. I stood in that line and said 'I'm fine' to two hundred people and I looked at her and she looked so relieved. And I thought, oh. She needs me to be fine. And I've been fine ever since, and I don't know how to stop."

Leona: "Did she say she needed that?"

Nolan: "No."

Leona: "Then you decided."

Nolan: "Yes."

She had been relieved. She had said so herself, in this room, with a timer running. She read *Then you decided* and *Yes* and put a mark in the second column, and the pen pressed harder than she meant it to.

December, Christmas Eve, 11:58 PM.

Nolan: "Merry Christmas, Hale. I'm in Ma's driveway with the engine running. Everybody inside thinks I came out to warm up the car for Thea."

Leona: "Go back in."

Nolan: "Two more minutes."

She remembered the warm car. She remembered saying, in the front seat, with the heater blowing on her feet, *You're so thoughtful*, and him saying, *It's a short walk*. Mark.

January, a Wednesday, 9:40 PM.

Leona: "Does it bother you that she doesn't know about me?"

Nolan: "No. That's the part that's mine."

Leona: "That's what I was afraid you'd say."

Mark.

On Friday the seventh of February, 2025, a little after nine, he wrote, *I'm sorry about the door. The hug.*

Leona: "I held on. You didn't."

Nolan: "I'm not sorry it happened."

Leona: "It was a hug at a door. Go home to your wife."

Nolan: "I always do."

A hotel is something you can point at, Leona had said in the car, and here there was nothing to point at but a man typing *I always do* to a woman who had told him to go home, and going home, and being fed.

A Tuesday morning in April, 6:41 AM.

Nolan: "She drove to Traverse City at midnight to save a bride's cake and got in at three. When I came down at six she had made my lunch. There was a note on it. 'Quiz day. Eat the protein.' I keep meaning to tell her and then she does something so competent I can't."

Leona: "Eat the sandwich."

The cake had been a three-tier almond-orange and the van's refrigeration had failed outside Cadillac, and she remembered every minute of it. She did not remember the note, which she must have written standing up with her coat on and her keys in her teeth.

"'Eat the protein,'" she read aloud, and Biscuit lifted one ear. "Who writes that?"

Biscuit put the ear down again.

October again, a year on, 9:20 PM.

Nolan: "Thea left ginger ale and saltines outside the bathroom door. She thinks it's the flu. I'm on the tile being looked after by a woman I'm lying to."

Leona: "Open the door."

Nolan: "I can't, she'll have a thermometer."

Leona: "Nolan, open the door."

Nolan: "I took the ginger ale."

Mark. She moved the sleeve of saltines six inches farther from the lamp, then moved it back, because that was ridiculous.

A Thursday in December, 9:31 PM, and her pulse knew it.

Leona: "I meant what I said in the car. Bring Thea, or tell her, one or the other."

Nolan: "After Christmas."

Leona: "That's what you said about Thanksgiving."

Nolan: "I can't give her a bad Christmas. She does the whole thing. There's a laminated schedule inside the cabinet door."

Leona: "You can't give her a true one either."

There was a laminated schedule inside the cabinet door, on the second shelf in Margit's kitchen. She had made it in 2017 and replaced it twice, and she had thought it was a gift. Mark.

• • •

At 12:30 Biscuit got up and went to the door and put his nose to the crack. He did not whine, being an old dog who had learned to ask by standing there.

"Ten minutes," she told him. "Don't make it a long one."

She left the phone under the lamp and took him down past the third stair and out into Water Street, her breath going in front of her. Mrs. Haskell's shovels stood in the hardware-store window with their red handles out, waiting on weather that hadn't come. Eight blocks up the hill, on Alder Street, a bungalow had one downstairs light on over the kitchen table, and she had put in the dimmer herself.

"Come on," she said to the dog, "we're not done."

• • •

March, a Tuesday, and she had been in Detroit and proud of herself for going.

9:12 PM. Nolan: "Thea's in Detroit till Thursday. The house is so quiet I can hear the furnace thinking. I'm in the garage again. You're the only place I can breathe."

The line she had been told about in the green chair was smaller on the screen than it had been in his mouth, and worse, because it had a timestamp and a woman's silence under it. Eleven minutes passed, and then:

Leona: "I know. That's the problem."

Leona: "I'm not a place, Nolan. I'm a woman in a Subaru with a lanyard."

Nolan: "You're the only one who doesn't need me to be okay."

Nolan: "Don't tell me to tell her. Not tonight."

Mark.

Two days later, 4:10 PM.

Nolan: "Asked Gus to say we had a meeting if Thea ever calls. He didn't ask why."

Leona: "Nolan."

Nolan: "I know."

Mark. She remembered the thumbs-up she had sent Gus.

In April he wrote, *I think I'm in love with how I feel in your car.*

Leona: "That's a sentence about you. It's honest, and it isn't enough."

Leona: "Go inside. Eat something she made."

Nolan: "I keep the phone face down at dinner now. She thinks I've gotten polite."

Mark. Then a long flat stretch through the summer.

Nolan: "Callum's whistle is in my coat pocket. The coaching one. I don't take it out. I just check that it's there."

Leona: "Is it there?"

Nolan: "It's there."

There was one night in August.

Nolan: "I'm so tired."

Leona: "I know."

They wrote nothing else for forty minutes, and then this:

Nolan: "Hale?"

Leona: "Here."

That was the whole exchange, and there were hundreds like it.

Then the last month, October 28, 2026, 10:05 PM.

Nolan: "Ten years on the eighth. Thea's running it, with a run-of-show, laminated. At 3:35 I'm allowed to cry. She left me eight seconds."

Leona: "That's the funniest and saddest thing you've ever sent me."

Nolan: "She's trying so hard to give me something."

Leona: "Tell her before Sunday."

Nolan: "Vow one is 'I'll tell you the truth, even the small ones.' I wrote that one. At a diner counter, with a pen off the register."

Leona: "Then you know what Sunday is."

Nolan: "Yes, I do."

Mark, she wrote, and then sat for a while with the pen above the paper, because that one had cost him something to type and he had typed it anyway and then done nothing.

The radiator had stopped ticking without her hearing it stop. The thread ran out under her thumb, the second and the third of November, a gap, and then one more line at the bottom of the glass.

Nov 8, 2026. And under it, at 6:12 in the morning:

Nolan: "I can't stop it and I can't do it."

Under it, in small letters, one word. *Delivered*. And two minutes later, four minutes and two seconds of a call she would never hear.

At 6:12 on the morning of the eighth she had been in the Subaru in the boathouse lot with a gas-station coffee, early so that nothing could go wrong, while across town he sat in a garage with the door down. Nine hours later he'd said *Never mind, after*, and she had said *After is on the run-of-show*.

• • •

She stood up without deciding to and carried the phone across the studio to the window, where she stood with her arm cocked, the phone in her fist, over Water Street and the dark hardware sign.

"You had a kitchen," she said.

Her voice was flat and loud in the empty room, and Biscuit's head came up.

"You had a table, an oak one that you carried in the back door by yourself and said this is where we'd sort things out. Two years of nine o'clock, Nolan. You were eight blocks away. You put a passcode on it. You put your phone face down at my table and let me think it was manners."

The phone said nothing.

"I'd have made a plan," she said. "Yes, I would have. I'd have had it by Thursday. And you could have hated it. You could have said, Thea, put it down, I don't want a binder, I want to lie on the floor. And I'd have put it down. That's all I wanted. To know where you were on a Thursday."

She was furious, and she was entitled to be. He had lied on a calendar and across a bathroom door, over a can of ginger ale she had set down outside it herself, and he had chosen a car in a church lot over a kitchen with a table in it, and he had chosen it again every week, in writing.

And she had cut the picture of the lawn chair and the fishing hat so he wouldn't see it coming. She had left him eight seconds. That was hers. She had said so in the hour, with the timer going, and it was still true, and it did not move a single mark from one column into the other.

Her knees went before she had finished the thought. The floor was close, and she was sitting on it between the stacked white chairs with her back against the cold slats, and a sound came up out of her chest that she knew. She had heard it once in a room full of ninety people with a lake in the windows, and she had thought it belonged to somebody else.

It did not stop, and when she pressed her fist against her mouth it came through anyway. She dragged the go-bag toward her by the strap and could not find the tissues because she could not see the pocket, and used the sleeve of the navy fleece instead, MORAVEC EVENTS over the heart. She cried in long hard pulls that bent her over her knees, and a chair slid on its stack above her and clanked, and she did not care.

At some point there was weight in her lap. Biscuit, eleven years old and heavier than the vet liked, had climbed in with a grunt and turned around once and put his chin on her wrist. His nose was cold, and he licked the salt off her fingers and left it at that.

“You’re not allowed on laps,” she told him thickly, “stay anyway.”

“I’m not forgiving him,” she told the chairs.

She said it out loud to test how it sounded, and it sounded exactly true.

When she could, she got up, and the dog got off her lap with great dignity. At the desk she put on the glasses from their cord and looked at the legal pad under the lamp. *CRUEL*: and the white space after it, exactly as wide as it had been at seven o’clock. Beside it, *CHOSE*:, and the marks running down to the bottom of the page in fives, crossed, like a prisoner’s wall.

She left the first column blank. She did not count the second. She knew roughly, and roughly was enough.

It was five past three. She picked up her own phone and found his name and typed with one thumb, and read it over once the way she read everything before it went out.

I read it. I saw the call. Don’t answer.

She sent it. Then she laid her phone face down on the desk, on top of his, and turned off the lamp.

Chapter 15 — What Isla Saw

“You didn’t answer,” Thea said.

Nolan stopped at the tailgate of the CR-V with a milk crate of spring scales hugged to his hip. It was ten past seven on Monday morning in the staff lot at Port Ellery High, under a sky the color of a dishpan. He had backed into the last space by the chain-link fence, nose out, as he always did, and then sat a full minute with the engine idling because the Subaru was two spaces down. At six she had walked Biscuit up to Alder Street, looped the red leash over the outside doorknob, knocked once and gone back down the steps.

“You said don’t, so I didn’t.” He set the crate on the bumper and the scales rang against each other, small brass sounds. “Was that the right call? I couldn’t tell if not answering counted as answering.”

“It was the right call,” Thea said.

He dragged a hand down his face. He had shaved and nicked himself under the jaw and stuck on a square of tissue and forgotten it. “One thing, and then nothing about what you read. I’ll let you bring it up.”

“Good.”

“I just don’t want you to think I’m not—”

“Nolan.”

“Right. Stopping.”

She had written the questions at five that morning in pencil on an index card, and then written them again, because the first draft was a list of things she wanted to know and the second a list of things she should have asked. The card was in her coat pocket, pressed so flat against her thigh that its corner dug in.

“I have three questions,” she said. “I should have asked them three years ago. You can answer them badly. You can’t answer them ‘fine.’”

“Fine’s out, then,” Nolan said, and she nodded.

A bus sighed into the loop. A girl in a puffer coat the size of a sleeping bag cut between the parked cars with her eyes on her phone and said, “Morning, Mr. Moravec.” “Morning,” Nolan said, in his teaching voice, bright as a refrigerator light, and when she had gone past it went out of his face like a switch.

Thea said, “How are you?”

He opened his mouth, and *I’m* arrived on it, and he looked it over and set it down.

"I put ninety envelopes in the box at the post office at six-forty," he said. "Eleven of them are going to people in this building. Gus. The principal. Two of my kids' mothers. By Wednesday they'll have read it, and I teach six periods, and in every one of them I'm going to think, now they know." He laughed, and the laugh had no floor. "That's not an answer, I know. That's a schedule."

"Keep going."

"I dropped a ring stand on Friday, and nobody was under it, and Gus said I should go home." He looked at the scales. "I'm scared. You read it and you're done, or you read it and you're not done, and I can't tell which one I'm more scared of. And I'm tired, and that's the whole real list." He winced. "That was bad."

"It was true, which is the assignment." Her thumb found the ridge of the Subaru fob and ran along it. "What was it like since Callum? Not the line, not what you did. What it was like to be you."

A custodian in a gray work jacket carried a bag of ice melt past them without looking up. Nolan waited until the gym door had closed behind him.

"Sundays." He said it to the gym door. "He called every Sunday at five o'clock to tell me the score, whether I'd asked or not. He'd just start talking. 'Nolan. We lost four to one and the ref was nine years old.'" His voice had dropped half a step and gone slow. "I have the phone in my hand at five every Sunday. I know it's not going to ring. I pick it up anyway, and it's been three years."

Thea had four things ready: a phone alarm at 4:55 that said something kind, a standing walk at five, Dunmore Point if he wanted it, the name of a book. Every one of them stood up in her throat like a chair at a graduation, and she kept her mouth shut around them.

"I didn't know that."

"I didn't tell anybody. That's what it's like. It's a phone." He shook his head. "I don't know why that's the one when there's a hundred."

"It's the one you said." She let the quiet run. "Last one. What do you need?"

"Coffee," Nolan said, and when she only looked at him: "It's a joke." The tissue on his jaw had come loose at one corner and fluttered when he breathed out. "Nobody's ever asked me that. You'd ask what I wanted for dinner, and I'd say whatever and you'd say, 'That's not a meal, that's a surrender.' I don't have a, I haven't got a list for this one."

“Then give me the bad version.”

He put both hands on the crate lid, and the scales went still.

“I need you not to make it better,” he said. “Not today, not yet. I need to be bad at this where you can see it and have you not fix it. And I need you not to leave.” He closed his eyes for a second. “Those are two, which is more than one, so I’m over my number.”

“There isn’t a number,” Thea said.

“There’s always a number with you.”

“Not for this one,” she said, in a voice smaller than she had planned, and let it be small. “That was all three.”

“All three,” Nolan said, and opened his eyes. “Can I ask you one?”

“Not today, I’m a night into not being fine, Nolan. Ask me when I know.”

He picked up the crate. At the corner of the building the first bell began and he flinched at it, a short, honest flinch, and then stood holding forty spring scales as if they were his to answer for. “Thank you for asking, Thea.”

“I should have asked in October.”

“I wouldn’t have answered in October.”

“That’s not what I’d have been asking for.”

He went in through the gym door with his shoulder against the bar. She stayed by the Subaru until the door had shut, and he had not turned around, and she had not wanted him to.

• • •

“Both of them are on easels,” Dimitra said. “Walter dropped them off this morning in the dish towel. He wanted them in our hands before Saturday, and he made me promise to say it’s a sardine.”

It was Tuesday, a little after two, and the studio smelled of the Italian place on Third that Dimitra had ordered lunch from and then forgotten to eat. On the conference table, side by side, stood Walter’s wife in her green cardigan on a marina dock in 1989, an eight-by-ten in a plain oak frame, holding up her perch, and Esther’s husband in the Tigers cap, squinting into the low sun with one hand raised to correct somebody.

“Same height, eye level for somebody sitting down,” Thea said.

“I measured, thirty inches between.” Dimitra wrote it on her list and, without looking up, said in the same tone, “You’ve got a bag under each eye. I could put a rental chair in each.”

“I didn’t sleep much last night.”

“Where, and for how long?”

“The couch, and I’m not answering the second part.”

“There are spoons in the break-room freezer. Cold spoon on each lid, ten minutes, I’ll cover the phones.”

“I’m fine,” Thea said, and Dimitra’s pen stopped.

“I’m not fine, I’m upright,” Thea said.

“Upright goes on the form.” Dimitra put the pen down and gave her the look she gave a banquet manager who said *probably*. The index card was in Thea’s coat on the hook by the door. She took a breath, and it sat there like an item on a list she hadn’t made.

“Dimitra,” she said, “how are you?”

“Why, did somebody die, is this a test?” Dimitra glanced at the phone and back.

“I’m practicing. You were closest.”

Dimitra stared at her for a long second. Then, slowly, she said, “I’m tired and I’m good. Hana’s mother sent a fruit basket with a card that says ‘For the girl who runs the hotel,’ and I would like it carved on my headstone.”

“And what do you need?”

“Now you’re scaring me.”

“What do you need?”

“A day off,” Dimitra said. “One that I take, and you don’t call about.”

“Which day do you want?”

“I’ll tell you when I know.”

“Tell me when you know.”

“And don’t say ‘done’ or ‘on it.’” Dimitra picked her pen back up. “That was nice, actually,” Dimitra said. “Do it again sometime, maybe not on a Tuesday.”

Thea’s phone buzzed on the table. A text from Isla, with no greeting, lowercase, the way she wrote everything: *can you drive me somewhere tomorrow. not grandma.*

She typed *Where, what time, do you need anything, is it safe*, and deleted it, then typed *Yes, what time?* and sent that.

5:30, dont ask me what yet

Okay, I’ll be there at 5:30, Thea wrote.

“Who died?” said Dimitra.

“Nobody. A sixteen-year-old asked me for something.”

“That’s worse.”

“I know,” said Thea, and went to find a spoon.

• • •

Isla was waiting at the curb on Cooper Street at 5:25 on Wednesday with a duffel the size of a calf and the porch light behind her. It was already full dark, and the air had the flat metal smell of the snow the forecast promised by morning. The kitchen curtain did not move.

She got in and dropped the duffel between her feet. “Grandma’s at altar guild until seven and Jonas has band, and I left a note.”

“Where are we going, exactly?”

“The field house, for the goalkeeper clinic. The league runs it Wednesdays in the winter.” She put her seat belt on without looking. “Grandma used to drive me. She sits in the top row with her coat on and her purse in her lap like it’s a bus station. She doesn’t watch, she watches the clock. I can’t do her watching the clock tonight.”

“All right.”

“You don’t have to say all right. It’s a ride.”

“It’s a ride,” Thea agreed, and pulled out.

Thea drove the speed limit. There was a skin of ice on the bridge by the marina and the heater took a mile to come up. Isla ran her thumb along the zip of the duffel, where a gray and red glove had worked out of the gap, its fingers still curled around a ball that wasn’t there.

“You can go over,” Isla said. “Nobody’s going to put it in a binder.”

“Ice.”

“It’s one patch of ice.”

“It’s a bridge.”

“Okay, there’s no essay Sunday and I did the fifth draft anyway, and it’s still a glove.”

“Send it to me tonight.”

“It’s fine, you don’t have to.”

“Fine’s out.”

“Since when, and whose rule?”

“Since Monday, and it’s mine, mostly.”

Isla turned her head and looked at her, the full look, the one from Callum’s face with the volume cut off. “You look like a haunted house.”

“Thank you.”

“It’s a compliment, haunted houses have a lot of work put into them.” She went back to the window.

They crossed the bridge, and Thea drove the county road under its orange streetlights with both hands at ten and two. Normally she would have read the road as a run of cues; tonight it was taillights and dark, and she did not fill the car with anything.

At the light by the Dairy Queen, shuttered for the season behind a paper banner that said BACK IN APRIL, the car in front of them stopped and Thea stopped behind it. The red went on and on.

“I saw him crying,” Isla said.

She said it to the window. Her voice was so quiet that the heater almost had it.

“In his car outside school, twice.”

Thea kept her hands where they were and did not turn her head. One dry flake came down out of the dark, touched the windshield and did not melt.

“Once in April,” Isla said. “I was waiting for the late bus, the bus loop, three-fifteen. He was in the far corner by the fence with his forehead on the steering wheel. And the other time was October twenty-second, a Thursday this year, at four o’clock. He had his hands over his whole face and he was making this sound like a kettle before it’s a kettle.” She stopped, and went on in the same small voice, “He never saw me, I went around the long way both times.”

“Isla.”

“I didn’t say anything, because I thought if I said it, it would be real.”

“Did you tell anyone?” Thea said.

Isla’s head came around, slowly. “Who would I tell, you?”

She said it the way you ask someone whether the store is open. It went in under Thea’s ribs and sat down.

The old sentence was right there, fully built, with a doctor’s name in it and a time. *You could have told me, sweetheart, I would have* and then a plan. Every word of it was there. She left it where it was and kept hold of the wheel and waited for the end of the girl’s sentence.

“You’d have handled it by dinner,” Isla said. “He’d be in some office on Friday with a pamphlet, saying ‘I’m fine’ to the pamphlet.” She turned the duffel zip a quarter inch and let it go. “And it’d be my fault it was real.”

The red light held, and the car ahead had its blinker on for a left turn it was not going to make.

“I’m listening,” said Thea, which was all she had.

Isla looked at her hands. “I’m almost done, I promise.”

Behind them the light went green and Thea did not move. A pickup leaned on its horn once, thought better of it, and swung around them, throwing a sheet of gray slush against her door.

“It’s green,” Isla said. “And I’m not crying, so you don’t have to look over.”

Chapter 16 — A Chair for the Second One

“Don’t touch the chair,” Thea told her own hands, and then, aloud, because Dimitra was watching, “Nobody touches the chair.”

It stood at the head table in the Ellery Grange hall, a ladder-back from Esther’s front room with a cane seat and a cushion tied on with ribbon, two and a half inches taller than the rental chair beside it. Thea had measured twice.

“Haskell’s nephew can take an inch and a half off the legs in four minutes,” Dimitra said. “He’s got a saw in the truck.”

“No.”

“She’ll sit up there with her feet off the floor for an hour.”

“She said it isn’t the chair.”

“Then is it the chair or isn’t it?”

“No.” Thea went down the table checking the gaffer tape under the easel feet. The woman with the perch faced the man in the Tigers cap across thirty inches of white cloth, and Walter’s folding rule lay between them, opened to thirty, because he had asked if he could leave it there. “Put a plain footstool under the skirt on her side. Low, so nobody points at it. If she wants it, it’s there.”

“And if she never touches it?”

“Then she doesn’t.”

Dimitra wrote it down with the care of a person pretending not to be impressed.

The hall smelled of floor wax and radiator dust. The stage curtain had faded to the color of a tired vein, and the four tall windows along the west wall were filling with the snow that had started at noon, fat and slow, on top of Thursday’s gray inch. Thea had set the head table against the north wall so the glass lay to the guests’ left and nobody’s late husband would turn into a white flash at four o’clock. Fifty-two chairs in two blocks, an aisle two feet wider than code.

Pilar Duarte came through the kitchen door stamping her boots, robe over her arm, plum stole around her neck. She looked at the easels, the two chairs, the rule on the cloth. Then she looked at the lapel of her own robe, where nothing was clipped.

“No microphone,” she said, as if reading it off a label.

“Fifty-two people and a room the size of a church supper, so they’ll lean in.”

“They will.” Pilar smoothed the stole with both hands. “Where do I stand when nobody tells me to begin?”

“Wherever you like, you’ll know.”

“I have officiated two hundred and some weddings, and at every one I knew because I looked at you. So where will you be?”

“At the back, not looking at my watch.”

“God help us,” said Pilar, quite comfortably, and went to find a mirror.

“Walter’s list says Moravec, Nolan, plus zero,” said Dimitra, who had been at her elbow for some time. “Seated or lost?”

“Seated, wherever he asks to sit.”

“And if he asks for the kitchen?”

“Then the answer is no.”

• • •

The Grange ladies’ cloakroom had a coat rail and a space heater that smelled of burning dust, and a long mirror with a chip out of one corner. Esther Baptiste sat before it in a cream wool dress with her coat across her knees, and the pearl comb in her braid was not holding.

“Hold still,” Thea said around a pin.

“I have held still for seventy-four years, ask anyone,” Esther said to the mirror. “Walter tells me he invited the physics teacher.”

Thea slid the comb out, set two pins crosswise through the braid and settled the comb back over them. “I saw the list.”

“His granddaughter has second period. She says he’s the only teacher who doesn’t pretend friction is exciting. Walter said he’d like that man at his wedding. I asked if that was kind or nosy. He said both.”

“He’s a guest, and it’s a free country.”

“What would you like him to be?”

“I’d like him to have a plate and a chair and no job.”

“That is a very exact answer.” Esther tipped her head to let Thea at the last pin. “Walter read his letter, you know. Half the Grange has. Doris Haskell has it under the glass on her counter, next to the key machine, where people sign for propane.”

Thea’s hands stopped in the braid.

“She asked him first,” Esther said to the mirror. “She told me so herself. She says he said yes before she’d finished asking, and then he bought a snow shovel he doesn’t need, so that it wouldn’t look like a favor.” She touched the

comb. *"Thea ended the ceremony, and she was right to.* That's the line people read aloud at the register. I thought you should know what the town is saying, since I expect nobody has told you."

"Nobody has."

"Well. Now somebody has."

"It's what I do."

"Mm." Esther touched the comb with two fingertips. "I have an opinion, if you'd like it."

"No."

"Good, I'll be quick." She turned on the chair so that she faced Thea instead of the glass. "When Walter brought my dish back washed, I told him to bring it back full. He thought I was being kind. I was being specific. I didn't want a casserole every Tuesday forever, and I didn't want one on the day I decided I didn't need one. I wanted one, full, on my porch by the first of April, and I'd know it when I saw it."

"And did he?"

"First of April. Chili, with too much cumin. I cried into the cumin and I let him in. Dear, nobody has told you this because you work with brides. Don't make him earn it forever. Make him earn it exactly."

Thea closed the lid of the sewing kit on the spare pins.

"I don't have a number," she said.

"No."

"I don't know what exactly is."

"Of course you don't. You're in the middle of the piece." Esther stood, shook out her coat, and looked down at her navy pumps. "Is my chair still too tall?"

"Yes."

"Good. Leave it."

• • •

By twenty to four the vestibule was a bog of boots. Dimitra stood at the guest book with the walkie on her hip and the programs in a fan, saying "Bride's side, groom's side, nobody's counting, sit" in her warmest voice. The cousin from Escanaba had come after all, in a snowsuit.

"Fifty-two," she told Thea, going by. "Do I get a point?"

"You get a point."

Esther's daughter had arrived from Grand Rapids in a camel coat with snow on the shoulders. She was about fifty, with her mother's eyes and none of her mother's cheer, and she went straight to the head table and stood a long time before her father's photograph. Then she put one finger on the frame and moved it an inch toward the second chair. The tape came up with a small ripping sound. She pressed it down with her thumb, crooked.

Thea, ten feet off with a roll of tape in her hand, did not cross the room.

"The daughter moved the frame," Dimitra murmured, back with her programs. "The tape's crooked, if you want it straight."

"It's her father, and it's an inch. Leave it."

"Who are you and what have you done with my boss?"

"I'm right here. I'm just standing farther back."

Odessa came out of the kitchen in chef's whites, her face red from the ovens, and spoke into Thea's ear. "I have been asked, professionally, to make a tuna noodle casserole, once, by a seventy-four-year-old woman with a very specific pan. I used the good tuna."

"Dead center on the buffet, in her own dish."

"It's the star. The hens are in the wings." Odessa looked past her toward the doors, and her face changed. She said nothing and went back to the kitchen.

Nolan stood in the vestibule with snow melting in his hair, in the brown corduroy jacket with the elbows gone pale and a coat folded over his arm. Thea knew how long he had been standing there by how little snow was left on his shoulders.

She crossed to him, since nothing in the room needed her for ninety seconds.

"I'm not going to help," Nolan said, low. "I want to be clear about that. I saw the box of chairs by the coat rail and I'm not touching it."

"Thank you."

"It's a heavy box."

"There are forty heavy boxes, and it's a wedding."

"Right." He looked at the programs, ivory, folded, and did not touch those either. "Walter asked me through his granddaughter. If it's wrong, I'll go home."

"It isn't wrong."

"Where do you want me?"

"That's not a question for today. Sit anywhere that isn't a job."

“What’s the seat nobody wants?”

She looked at the hall as she looked at every hall, a set of exits and a set of needs. “Back row, aisle, by the door.”

“That’s the exit seat.”

“I know what it is.”

“Okay,” he said. “I’ll take the exit seat.”

“Biscuit sends regrets,” he added. “He was told he isn’t a plus-one.”

“He’d have eaten the cake.”

“He’d have eaten the dish.”

“Did you eat?” Thea asked, and nearly bit her tongue. It was his question, and it had always been his.

“Toast, eaten standing up.”

“That counts.”

“That’s what I hear, apparently.” He shifted the coat. “Thea, I’m not here to be seen. An old man asked me. If I’m in the way, say one word and I’m gone, and I won’t make a thing of it.”

“You won’t be in the way.”

He went and sat in the last row by the door with the coat over his knees. His hands hung between them, and then he laid them on the coat, where she could see them from anywhere in the hall.

• • •

At four o’clock the hall was full and quiet and nobody told anyone to begin.

Walter and Esther came out of the kitchen door, not through the front, not to music. Walter wore the anchor tie. Esther’s hand lay in the crook of his arm like a glove somebody had folded there. They crossed the floor at the speed of two people who had measured it and sat thirty inches apart, looking at the room.

Thea stood behind the last row with her hands empty and no earpiece. The walkie sat on Dimitra’s hip forty feet away, hissing to itself. She could feel the watch on her wrist like a coin under a tablecloth, and she left it there.

The radiator ticked while a child in the fourth row asked a question in a whisper that carried to the stage. Esther’s feet in their navy pumps hung an inch above the floor and did not move toward the footstool, and Thea did not look at that either.

Pilar stood at the front with her hands folded, looking down the length of the hall at the doors, at Thea, with the look she had given her at two hundred weddings, the one that said *now*?

Thea shook her head a quarter inch. Pilar's mouth tightened on something that might have been laughter, and she turned to the couple instead.

Seven minutes went by, maybe nine, and snow came down past the four windows and nobody coughed.

Walter said, "Well."

"Well," said Esther.

That was the cue, and a sound went through the room like a held thing set down gently on a table. Pilar said four plain sentences and then, "Walter, you've written something, I believe."

He had, in block capitals on index cards, and he took the folding rule off the cloth as if he might need to measure the sentences. "Esther. I'm going to read it, because if I don't I'll say something else."

"Read it," said Esther.

"I promise to bring the dish back full. Every time." The hall laughed, wetly. "I promise to wave, not nod. I promise to put the porch light on when your daughter's car is late, even if you've told me not to." In the front row the daughter put a hand to her mouth. "I promise I'll be next door when you need to sound like you're fine and when you don't. And I promise."

He turned a card over. The room heard it turn.

"I promise that I will say goodnight to—"

He said the name. It was a short one. He said it plainly, the way you say the street you live on.

"Every night, out loud. You'll hear it through the window, and I'd like you not to mind, I'd, I would like—"

His voice went all at once, without a crack to warn anyone, like a light when the whole street loses power. His mouth stayed open on the next word. The cards slid in his fingers and the folding rule clattered to the floor and rolled and rolled and stopped against the leg of the front row.

Nobody moved. In the third row a man began to half rise, to bring water, and a woman put a hand on his sleeve and he sat. Pilar looked toward the back doors again. Thea gave her nothing.

At the head table Esther did not reach over. She laid her right hand on the white cloth in the middle of the thirty inches, palm up, and looked straight ahead at the room as if she had been put there to hold a place.

Thea stood perfectly still at the back wall and did not look at the man in the last row to see what it was costing him. That was his to spend.

At the front, Walter put his hand in the palm.

"I'd like you not to mind," he said, to the table, with Esther's fingers around his. "That's all of it. That was the last card."

"I'll say it with you," said Esther. "I've got a window, too."

The hall laughed, and Esther's daughter cried out loud without covering it, and by the door a big man with a coat over his knees put his forehead in his hand and breathed.

• • •

"Chicken," said Odessa, "or the tuna that cost me a night's sleep."

"Both," said Thea.

"Esther's daughter just asked me for the tuna recipe. I nearly wept into a hotel tray. Don't tell anyone, and take a hen."

"I'm not hungry."

"I didn't ask if you were hungry. I said take a hen."

She stood at the buffet in her good shoes, holding a plate she had not meant to take. Esther's casserole dish sat at the center in a nest of towels, a battered blue enamel oval with one chip, full to the brim, and Walter had already been to it twice. Somebody's grandson was eating a roll very seriously.

Odessa served potatoes with her chin tucked. "Did anybody cry?"

"Everybody."

"And did you cry, standing back there?"

"I stood at the back."

"That's still not a no." Odessa ladled gravy and glanced toward the coat rail by the vestibule. "Thea, he's been standing by the coats with his on for twenty minutes, and he took no plate. He hasn't spoken to a living person except the old man, and the old man shook his hand for a very long time."

"I saw."

"Did you talk to him?"

"Ninety seconds, about a heavy box."

"Romantic, in a hardware-aisle kind of way. He looks like a man at a bus stop."

"He's waiting."

"For what?"

Thea took a roll she didn't want. The plate was warm under her hand. By the door Nolan stood in his coat with his hands in his pockets, not leaving, and the snow behind him in the glass came down so steadily it looked arranged.

"To see if I get on," she said.

"Then he'd better have exact change," said Odessa, and went back to her potatoes.

Thea took a second roll, laid it beside the first, and carried the plate down the length of the hall toward the door.

He saw her coming at about forty feet and took his hands out of his pockets.

"That's a plate," he said.

"It's Esther's tuna and one of Odessa's hens. Somebody has to eat the hens." She held it out. "It isn't a job. You can eat it standing up. I'm told that counts."

He took it, and their fingers were in the same place for about a second, and neither of them made anything of it in a way that both of them noticed.

"Two rolls," he said.

"You looked like a two-roll man."

"I've been told I look like a man at a bus stop."

"Odessa."

"She said it to my face, by the coats. She said I should have exact change." He broke a roll and gave her half without asking, the way he had at every buffet for ten years, and she took it the way she had. "Doris Haskell sold me a shovel."

"I heard."

"It's a good shovel. It has a lifetime warranty. I asked her whose lifetime and she said, mine, so I'd better look after myself." He ate a forkful of the tuna standing up and closed his eyes. "Oh, that's terrible. That's wonderful. Esther should be arrested."

She laughed. It came out of her before she had checked where she was, in the middle of a Grange hall, beside the coats, with a man she had not forgiven, and it was a real laugh with her head going back. Two of Esther's piano mothers turned around to look, and she let them.

He was watching her with the fork halfway to his mouth, the way he used to watch her across a room at somebody else's wedding, when she was working and he was a plus-one with nothing to do but that.

"What," she said.

“Nothing. You laughed.” He looked at the tuna. “I’d forgotten it goes all the way up like that.”

“Eat your casserole, Nolan.”

“Eating,” he said, and did, and she stood beside him by the coats until the plate was clean and the snow outside had filled in their tire tracks.

Chapter 17 — Callum's Tuesday

“That’s a clarinet,” Isla said.

Nolan had stopped inside the lobby doors with snow melting on his shoulders, holding a black hard case out in front of him like a casserole. It was 6:41. The lobby smelled of wet wool and the PTA’s cinnamon rolls, and the line at the card table had turned to watch.

“It’s a case,” Nolan said.

“With a clarinet in it.”

“It’s got a latch.” He thumbed the latch, and the lid came up an inch. Inside, on blue velvet, lay three pieces of black wood and a reed in a plastic sleeve, and on the barrel a strip of masking tape said ISLA M. in a twelve-year-old’s marker. “That’s yours.”

“I quit that in seventh grade. The band director asked me to.”

“You texted, hall closet by the boots. There were two cases, and I took the one on top.” He looked at the clarinet as if it had lied to him. “Where’s Jonas?”

“Backstage since six-fifteen, because Grandma drove.” Some of the deadpan went out of Isla’s face. “He said he’d just use the school’s if it came to that. He said it like he’d already decided it would.”

“Is it at least in tune?” Thea asked.

“It’s a clarinet, it’s never in tune.”

Nolan shut the case and, without setting it down, looked down the hall at the stage door. “I’m going to go tell him.”

“Tell him what?”

“That I brought a clarinet.”

He went down the hall at a careful walk with the case against his leg, and nobody in the cinnamon-roll line said a word until he turned the corner. Two of them had been at the boathouse. Carla Benning, who taught Spanish down the hall from him and had cried in the second row on the eighth of November, watched him all the way with her mouth set. Then she said, to nobody in particular, “Well. He signed it,” and went back to the rolls, and the woman beside her nodded as if that settled something.

Thea stood by the trophy case with her coat buttoned. The band room would have a loaner and the director a spare mouthpiece, and she could be backstage in ninety seconds. She held the car key in her pocket until it went warm.

“You’re doing the thing,” Isla said.

“I’m not doing anything.”

“Your whole face is a run-of-show.”

“You said it was a ride. Wednesday. You said it was only a ride.”

“That was Wednesday, and this is a concert.” Isla took a cinnamon roll off the table without paying, then went back and paid. “He’s done two of these, Tuesdays, since the first one after Thanksgiving. He showed up at the Y at 4:45 with a bag of oranges.”

“Oranges.”

“Dad did oranges at halftime. Winter’s a running clock, so there’s no halftime, and nobody ate them. He stood on the sideline where Dad stood and ate all eight.” She picked at the icing. “Then he drove us to Gino’s and ordered wrong.”

“Wrong how?”

“Dad got half pineapple, half olive, which is disgusting. Uncle Nolan got pepperoni and apologized to the waitress.”

“Does he talk, in the car?”

“He asks if I’m warm. Then he asks if I’m too warm. Then he turns the heat off and on like a lighthouse.” Isla shrugged with one shoulder. “He never asked Grandma if he could. He just came.”

“What did she say?”

“Nothing, not a sentence since the pie. She said get your shoes on, and I got my shoes on, and he was in the driveway, and then it was Tuesday again.” She wiped her thumb on a napkin. “Come on, she’s holding six seats and she’s going to start charging.”

• • •

The seat stuck, and Thea found it out by sitting on it. She did the room by habit: two exits a side, a green fire door by the stage, a plastic ficus in a Santa hat. An oboe went up and down a scale.

Margit sat at the far end of the ninth row, then Isla, then Thea, then an empty seat, then the aisle.

“You came,” Margit said, down the row, past Isla.

“Jonas said.”

“Jonas said nothing. Isla said.”

“Isla said Jonas said.”

“Good, somebody told the truth.” Margit pointed her chin at the stage. Her program lay folded in quarters on her knee with her purse on top. “Sit.”

“I’m sitting.”

“Sit more.”

Thea let her shoulders down. It took two tries.

“You have eaten?” Margit said.

“I brought your paprikás.”

“In the bag. Cold, in a yogurt tub.” Margit looked at the aisle, at the door where nobody had come through, and said nothing about it. “After. Isla, tell her it is after.”

“It’s after,” said Isla.

The program was one photocopied sheet. Under the eighth grade, fifth item, *Have Yourself a Merry Little Christmas* (arr.), trumpet solo: J. Moravec, somebody had drawn a pencil line, Margit’s soft pencil, the same line that went under the pills in the binder.

At 6:58 the aisle seat creaked and Nolan came down into it, damp to the collar and breathing as if he had taken the school’s stairs at a run. He shrugged out of the gray wool coat, the one with the whistle in its pocket, and laid it across the empty seat between them.

“Hi,” he said, and she said it back. “Isla said Jonas said.”

“I’ve been told that’s a chain of custody.”

“Reliable witnesses.” He kept his eyes on the stage. “He’s got a loaner, and the second valve sticks. The band director says it’ll hold.”

“Will it?”

“She says so.”

“That isn’t what I asked.”

He took a long time. On the risers the eighth graders were filing in, and Jonas came fifth from the end with the trumpet in the crook of his arm, black pants an inch too short, tie clipped on crooked. He found his chair and sat on the front half of it, the way a bird sits on a wire.

“I don’t know,” Nolan said. “She said it’d hold and I said great, because I say great to the face, and I’m trying to quit.”

“Thank you.”

“For what?”

“For not saying great.”

“It’s a lousy valve,” he said. Isla leaned across her lap and hissed, “Shh. They’re coming in.”

By the fourth piece Nolan’s hands lay on his thighs. Thea did not look at them, and she knew where they were. The director turned to the trumpets.

Jonas stood and lifted the horn without looking at the music.

The first eight bars were small and clean, a little breathy, a boy saying something to a ceiling. By the sixth Isla had gone still beside her and Margit's hands had closed on the program.

On the ninth bar the second valve stuck.

The note went flat and then was not a note at all, a thin goose sound that cracked across the room. Jonas took the horn from his mouth and stood holding it in front of him. Someone in the back coughed. The director's baton lifted a half inch, the way a baton does when it is about to wave a child on, and Thea, who had written that exact cue into two hundred timelines, felt her own hand come up off her knee.

Beside her Nolan drew a breath and leaned an inch toward her, and she knew what was coming up his throat because she had heard it two hundred times in a church hall: *He's fine. It's fine.* His mouth opened on the F.

He shut it. He let the boy on the stage be not fine in front of four hundred people, and said nothing at all.

Onstage Jonas pressed the valve with his thumb and played the last four bars on the sticking note, flat and loud, slower than he'd practiced, holding the final one until his face went red. The baton came down, the band came in under him like a floor, and nobody had needed anything from Thea at all.

They clapped, and row nine clapped hardest. Isla used her whole arms. From the far end Margit's voice rose over all of it, to no one, loud and certain: "Beautiful."

"That was bad," Isla said, under it.

"Yes," said Thea. "He finished."

"She'll say beautiful all night, it's the nicest lie she tells all year, and I'm going to let her," said Isla, clapping on.

• • •

The auditorium emptied slowly by the side doors. Jonas did not go out with the band. When the last eighth grader had gone through the stage door, Nolan stood, left the gray coat on its seat, and went down the slope of the aisle alone.

Thea stayed in her row with Isla and the empty napkin. Margit had gone along the seats to talk to a woman about a casserole dish, in a voice one notch too bright.

Jonas sat on the lip of the stage at the far left, where the curtain wing met the steps, the trumpet across his knees, looking at the floor between his shoes.

Nolan went up the side stairs, stood over him a moment, and sat down on the edge with his legs hanging, the way you sit on a dock.

"That was a good solo," Nolan said, and Jonas did not move. "The ending, you held it. It's hard to hold a note when you—"

"No. It was bad."

"It was—" Nolan stopped. In the long hush of the room Thea saw him set down every kind thing he had brought. "It was bad," he said. "The valve stuck, you stopped, everybody saw. That was a bad solo."

Jonas lifted his head, his eyes dry and enormous.

"I've been bad at a lot of things this year," Nolan said. "I brought a clarinet to a trumpet solo. I'm not saying it's the same. I'm saying I've been in a lot of rooms where it went wrong, and I know what it is to want the floor to open." He rubbed his thumb along the edge of the stage. "I'm still here."

"You brought a clarinet with Isla's name on it." Jonas turned the trumpet over once on his knees. "Dad would've bowed to the valve."

"He'd have thanked it by name," Nolan said. "Then he'd have told the lake."

The corner of Jonas's mouth went up. It didn't stay, and it was enough.

"Gino's is open till nine," Nolan said. "I'll order wrong."

"You'll order pepperoni."

"Is that wrong?"

"It's a coward's pizza," Jonas said, and looked at himself as if he had sworn in church.

"Fair," said Nolan. "Then I'll order wrong."

Jonas stood and tucked the horn under his arm. He said, to the floor, "Half and half is disgusting, but it's what he got."

"Then it's what we get."

"They won't make half and half for one person."

"I'm two people tonight," Nolan said. "Me and the guy who orders wrong."

He stood after the boy and started to put a hand on his shoulder, and held it an inch off. Jonas leaned back into it, once, like a foot testing a stair.

• • •

In the lobby the cinnamon-roll table had been stripped to its paper cloth. Thea stood with Isla by the doors, the yogurt tub going cold in her tote, while

the snow came straight down through the lot lights onto cars that had been warm an hour ago.

Jonas came through the stage door with the trumpet under his arm, went to his sister, and stood there. Isla fixed his tie without looking at it.

“Don’t,” Jonas said.

“I didn’t say anything.”

“You were going to.”

“I was going to say you stood up straight.”

“I didn’t.”

“For eight bars,” she said, flattening the knot with two fingers, “and then the valve.”

“Then the tie,” said Jonas, and Isla huffed through her nose, which in her was a laugh.

“Are you mad?” Jonas asked.

“At the valve? Yes. I’m going to write it a letter.”

“At him.”

“Which him?”

“Both of them,” said Jonas.

“Not tonight,” Isla said, “tonight there’s pizza.”

Nolan came behind them in his shirtsleeves, dark rings under each arm, and stopped beside Thea instead of his mother.

“You almost said it,” she said, low. “At the valve.”

“I had it on my tongue. *He’s fine.*” He looked at his hands. “I swallowed it. It went down like a pill without water.”

“My hand came up too,” she said. “Off my knee, like I had the cue.”

“I saw,” he said. “Gino’s after. Jonas wants half and half, and I’m going to get it wrong.”

“Get it wrong,” said Thea. “Not with me tonight, I’ve got a tub of paprikás in my tote. Go.”

He turned to his mother and stopped a few feet off with his hands where she could see them. “Ma.”

Margit crossed the lobby with the gray coat over her arm. She must have lifted it from the seat on her way along the row, while Thea was watching the stage, and Thea had not seen her do it. She did not look at his face. She shook the coat out once by its shoulders and held it open wide, lining out, as she had held every school coat on every February morning for twenty-six years.

Nolan turned around and put his arms in.

Chapter 18 — The Car

Nolan had not started the engine.

Thea could tell from the Subaru, forty yards off under the last light pole in the lot at St. Brendan's: the CR-V sat nose-out against the chain-link with no exhaust smoking behind it in the cold, and its windshield had fogged from the bottom corners inward, the way glass does when one person sits in a car and breathes.

She had been in the lot since 7:35 without going down the stairs. At 8:04 the side door opened and the Circle came up out of the basement in twos and threes. Harold first, a hand on the rail, then the woman in the State sweatshirt, then the boy of twenty. Abel came last with his ring of keys, switched off the stairwell light, pulled the door until it caught, and stood on the step a moment longer than he needed to, looking at the CR-V. Then he lifted the keys an inch toward it, the way you tip a hat to somebody leaving on a train.

Leona's Forester pulled out at 8:11, slowly, its headlamps raking over the Subaru's windshield. The face behind the wheel turned. She dipped her head once, and Thea did the same through two panes of glass and fourteen degrees, and the taillights climbed the hill toward Elm Street and were gone. The Forester had parked at the far end of the lot tonight, Thea saw, nowhere near the fence.

Then there was only the CR-V.

She walked the sixty-odd paces she had walked in November, from the other end this time, and she did not stop at forty. He saw her at thirty. His hands came off the wheel and went flat on his thighs, and he had decided to put them there, slowly.

She tapped once on the passenger window. The lock thunked, he leaned across and shoved the door open from inside, and a stack of paper slid off the seat into the footwell.

"Lab reports. Sorry." He scooped them up and heaved them over the headrest. "Don't read the third one. He believes friction is a personality."

She got in. The seat was run up for someone shorter, Jonas probably, who rode in front on Tuesdays with his knees against the glove box. She found the lever under the cushion and pushed it back until her legs had room, and when she shut the door the dome light held for three seconds, as if giving them time to change their minds, and went out.

The car smelled of wool and chalk and, faintly, of beagle. Through the fogged glass the church door stood forty yards ahead under its one yellow

bulb. From this seat you saw everyone who came out and which car they went to. It was the best sightline in the lot.

“That was the last one,” Nolan said.

“I know. You told me two more.”

“I told the room at the start, so nobody would have to wonder all night.” He looked at the door. “Harold said, who’s going to complain about the coffee now. The boy shook my hand, which he’s never done. Abel said the door will be open, which he says to everybody, and then he said it again, which he doesn’t.”

“And Leona?”

“Said okay. Then she moved her chair a foot toward the radiator, into where mine had been, and didn’t look at me for the rest of the hour.” His thumb found the seam of his cords. “Which was right.”

“How was it?”

“Like taking a cast off. You think you’ll be glad, and then you look at your arm.”

She let that sit. He had both hands on his knees, and he asked it carefully.

“Can I ask why you came?”

“To sit where you sat.”

“I sat in hers. That’s a different car.”

“It faces the same door.”

He looked at the church door as if someone had rehung it. “Yeah, it does.”

“Tell me what the car was,” she said. “Not what you wrote her. What it was for you.”

He watched a flake of snow wander across the lamp and vanish, and she kept in the sentence she had ready about starting anywhere.

“It was the one place I wasn’t holding something up,” he said. “At Ma’s I carve and at school I’ve got the keys. With the kids I’m the uncle who’s steady. And at home I’m the one who’s fine.” He turned the heater dial a quarter inch and turned it back. “The first night I got in, I said, ‘I don’t want to be the strong one.’ Out loud. I’d never heard what it sounded like.”

“Say it the way you said it to her.”

He took a breath that went all the way down. “I don’t want to be the strong one,” Nolan said.

A small crack ran across the last word, and he shut his mouth on it. She turned the sentence over. It fit her own mouth better than she liked, and she put it down without saying it.

“And it didn’t work,” he said. “That’s the worst part. I’d drive home light, and by Friday noon I was heavy again, and by Wednesday I was counting. She told me it was a dose, and the trouble with a dose is you build up. She said it to my face and I came back the next week.”

“Why?”

“Because it was Thursday.”

“That’s not a reason.”

“No,” he said. “It’s the reason.”

“You could have said it in our kitchen.”

“You’d have made a plan.”

“I’d have made a plan because I love you.”

“I know that.” He said it at once, and she turned her head. He was looking at her, his eyes red at the rims and his face only his face. “And it’s not true, what I just said. It’s what I told myself in the car so I could keep coming to the car. You’d have made a plan, and I could have said, Thea, no, put it down. I had a mouth. I used it every night, on somebody else.” He looked back at the door. “Don’t let me hand you that one. I’ve been handing it to you since the green chair.”

She waited to want to argue, and the wanting did not come. Under the not-wanting there was a flat clear thing like the lake in January, something she could stand on.

“I’m not angry tonight,” she said. “I looked for it in the lot.”

“Don’t tell me that like it’s good news.”

“It isn’t. It’s the weather.”

He almost laughed. “Start the engine,” she said. “It’s freezing.”

He turned the key. The CR-V shuddered, and something small and metal clicked in his coat pocket, and he put his hand over it quickly. It was the whistle; she had read about it at two in the morning among the folding chairs. She let him have his hand.

The heater blew cold, then lukewarm, then warm. Nolan eased the fan down until the car was warm and not loud, and what was left was the idle and the two of them breathing.

“Where do you go now?” she said. “Thursdays.”

“Home.” He said it to the windshield. “Mondays I drive to Holland and sit in a chair across from a woman with a box of tissues and a clock she puts behind me. That’s an hour. Thursdays I don’t know. That’s what scares me. I just gave back the best hour of my week, and there isn’t another room.”

Sitting in the dark of his car, the floor she had walked across for years turned out to be a roof. He had left the room. The car was going home to an empty house with a dog in it. If there was going to be a place where he came apart, it would have to be a kitchen, and the kitchen had her in it.

"I'm not a place either," she said. "I don't know if I can be the room."

"I'm not asking you to be." He kept his hands on his knees. "I'm asking if someday I can sit at our table on a Thursday and be bad at it with you there. Not tonight. I know not tonight."

She did not answer, and he did not need her to. Out past the fog a light went out in the church's upper window, and then, on its timer, the bulb over the side door. The lot had only the pole light now, orange through the frost.

"Do you always stay till that goes?" Thea said, to the glass.

"Every Thursday. It was the only thing that could make me leave."

"And tonight?"

"Tonight it went out and I'm still here."

His coat had come open, and the smell came off it, the plain animal warmth of a big man in a small car, and her body knew it before she did, the way a hand knows a banister in the dark. In the corner of her vision his hand lay on his thigh, with the white scar across the back of it where a wrestling mat had once taken the skin. She had warmed that hand inside her coat on a train platform in Chicago when she was twenty-seven. She did not think the thought through. She looked at the glass, and her face was warm, and it was not the heater.

He did not reach toward her, and she did not move her hand the eleven inches across the console. They sat with two feet of air between their shoulders, and neither of them closed it, and neither pretended not to see it.

"Thea."

"Mm."

"Can I say a small true one?"

"Yes."

"I'm glad you're in the car."

"That's not small."

"It's the smallest one I've got," Nolan said.

At 8:52 she put her hand on the door.

"I'm going home now," she said. "Nothing's wrong. I just want to see what it's like to leave a room on my own because I feel like it."

"Okay."

“Eat something. Text me when you have, one line.”

“That’s still the rule?”

“It’s still the rule.”

She pushed the door open and the lot came in, a hard clean edge of winter against her face, and she sat one second more with a boot on the salt, looking at the place where the church door used to be.

“Thursday,” she said.

He looked at her.

“Next Thursday’s Christmas Eve,” he said.

“I know what it is.” She stood up into the cold. “Thursday.”

“Thursday,” said Nolan, and his voice did a thing it had not done all night, and he let it.

Chapter 19 — The Agenda

Thea squared the fourth folder to the edge of the table, stepped back to the doorway, and checked the sightline again.

Five white resin chairs stood in a horseshoe, open toward the window so nobody sat with a back to the door. Four manila folders, one to a seat, carried names in the label-maker's plain black type: MARGIT, NOLAN, ISLA, JONAS. She had put no one at the head, which had taken twenty minutes and a horseshoe, because a horseshoe had no head. On the desk the white dial timer sat set to five, and beside it a bakery box from Third Street, tied with string, because Margit liked a thing in the middle of a table.

Eleven pages in each folder.

Three days ago she had sat in a parked car and let a man finish his sentences, and she had done it right. On Friday morning Dara's email had come.

Dara wrote twice a year, from Lisbon, in lowercase, about flights. She had left when Jonas was three, and when Callum died the children had asked to stay in Port Ellery with their grandmother, and Dara had said yes from six time zones away and had kept saying yes, which Thea had always privately counted in her favor. This one was not about flights. *landing the 28th for two days. the kids tell me callum is still in a closet. margit won't answer me about it. either we do something while i'm there or i take him home with me. he always said the sea.*

Thea had read it at her desk with her coat still on. She had seen it all at once, the way she saw a ballroom from the door: a pine box going through airport security in a carry-on, Margit at the window on Cooper Street, the children at the gate. Margit never having said one word over him. The label on the shelf in her own handwriting, HOLD, and nobody having held him at all.

That night she had run the printer until it ran out of paper.

At ten to two Nolan tapped twice on the open door, which did not stop him.

"Is somebody being deposed?"

"It's a family meeting."

"Right." The snow had not quite melted off the shoulders of his gray coat as he looked at the horseshoe and the folders. "You set chairs. Is there a seating chart?"

"Page nine, and it's only a suggestion."

"Where am I?"

“Near the door.”

“Because I like to know where it is,” Nolan said, mildly. “That’s a fair read. Did you eat?”

“I’m about to.”

He picked up the folder with his name on it and held it by the edges, as he held a lab report he suspected had been copied. At the fourth page his thumb stopped.

“Item two. It has a date on it.”

“It’s a proposal, and a proposal needs a date.” She heard how that sounded and kept going, because the rest was true. “The twenty-seventh. A Sunday, the day before Dara lands, so it’s done and nobody has to fight about a plane. The township will plow the lot at Dunmore if somebody asks by Friday, and I asked. Ashes are allowed. Nothing can be left in the water.”

“You asked.”

“Somebody had to.”

His eyes went past her to the desk, to the white dial with its sixty at the top. “That’s the one from the hour.”

“It’s a good timer.”

Nolan sat in the chair nearest the door and put the folder face down on his knee.

• • •

The third stair told on them at two o’clock exactly: Isla first, two at a time, then the lighter tread of Jonas, then a long gap, then Margit, a hand on the rail. Isla and Jonas went around her in the doorway. Margit stopped in it.

She had not unbuttoned her coat. She held her handbag in front of her in both hands, with something folded in foil under one arm that had come out of an oven that morning, and she looked at the horseshoe, then at the box with the string.

“Margit, thank you for coming. Can I take your coat?”

“No.”

“There’s no head of the table. I made it so there isn’t one.”

“There is always a head.” Margit’s gaze went over the chairs and the dial. “It is where the person stands who set the chairs.”

“Grandma,” Isla said.

“You bought,” said Margit, to the box.

“From Third.”

“I brought.” She lifted the foil an inch and did not put it down. “What is the paper?”

“The agenda.” Thea held the facilitator’s copy against her chest. “Christmas Eve first, then Callum, then where everyone is, then next steps, so nobody has to guess what we’re doing.”

Isla looked at the word on her page and did not say it. Jonas looked at the floor, Nolan at his knees.

Something went across Margit’s face and was put away. “I will not open it.”

“It’s a draft, and nothing’s decided, which is why we’re sitting down.”

“You have a clock on the desk.” She tipped her head at it. “Four days before Christmas Eve you invite me to a room with a clock.”

“It’s for fairness, so nobody goes long.”

“I know what it is for.” Margit’s voice had no heat in it, which was worse. “I did the school lunches twenty-six years. I know what a bell is for.”

“Grandma.” Isla had a hand on the back of Jonas’s chair. He stood behind it gripping the top rail. “Please sit. He won’t until you do.”

Margit crossed the room, coat buttoned to the throat, and sat as far from her son as the chairs allowed, the folder closed on her knees beneath the handbag and the foil.

Jonas sat, then Isla, and Thea took the fifth chair.

“Are those the cheese ones?” Jonas asked. It was the first thing he had said.

Margit folded back a corner of the foil. “Eat.” She handed Jonas a pogácsa without looking at him, and another to Isla, who took a third and passed it down the horseshoe to the chair by the door, where Nolan held it in his palm as if it might go off. Nobody touched the bakery box.

The dial went off like a bicycle bell. Nolan flinched, and nobody looked away fast enough.

“It’s a bell,” said Nolan. “It’s allowed to be loud.”

“That’s five minutes.” She switched it off with one finger. “Welcome, I’m glad you came. Item one is Christmas Eve. I’m not hosting, that’s settled, but nobody has said who is, and it’s four days away. Page three has options.”

Isla opened her folder with two fingers. “Option A,” she read, in no voice at all. “Cooper Street, Margit hosting, simplified menu. Option B, Alder Street, Nolan hosting, children assist, Thea to advise.” She looked up. “Advise.”

“By phone,” Thea said.

“Remote advising,” Isla said, and turned the page. “Option C, no gathering, not recommended.”

“Why does that one say not recommended?” Jonas asked.

“Because the other two have more steps,” Thea said, and stopped. “It’s a column. I put one on all of them.”

“I’d have picked C,” said Jonas.

“Jonas,” said Margit.

“It’s an option on the paper.”

“Who asked for options?”

“Nobody, which is why.” Thea heard her own pace pick up. “Nobody has said one word to me about Christmas Eve, so I thought somebody should.”

“You saw a hole. So you filled it with a column.” Margit shifted the foil on her arm. “I have Christmas in my own house, forty years, and I did not need a column.”

Nolan opened his mouth, and Margit looked down the room at him until he shut it.

“Then item two,” Thea said, and the next part came out smooth, because she had practiced it at the bathroom mirror. “Isla, you’re in the order of service. Would you read the draft through? Page four.”

Isla sat forward with her elbows on her knees and read it as she read the Pledge, every word the same size.

“Draft order of service, Dunmore Point, Sunday, December twenty-seventh, eleven a.m. Eleven-oh-five, welcome, Grandma, one minute. Eleven-oh-eight, reading, me, two minutes, poem or my choice.” She turned the sheet. “Eleven-twelve, remarks, Uncle Nolan, three minutes.”

Three minutes. Thea had once given that man eight seconds and called herself generous.

“Eleven-fifteen, scattering, Jonas, first handful, no speaking required.”

“It says first,” said Jonas.

“Eleven-twenty-five,” Isla went on, fast, her eyes on her brother, “closing, Grandma, blessing optional. Eleven-thirty, coffee in cars. Thermoses, Thea.” She laid the page on her knee. A column ran down the right-hand side headed *Weather*. “You ran Dad’s funeral like a wedding,” she said, in the same voice, “and you’re doing it again.”

“That isn’t what this is.”

“There’s a contingency for sleet.”

“That’s what a contingency is for.”

Isla did not raise her voice. “It’s a tab in the binder. Nobody turned to it.”

“I did it so nobody has to hold it.” It came out fast and wrong. “Your grandmother can’t, and Nolan can’t go near the box, but I can. I’ve had him three years in a closet, and your mother lands on the twenty-eighth, and if somebody doesn’t decide, he goes to Lisbon in a carry-on and nobody here ever—”

“Mom emailed you?” Isla said. “Not us?”

Thea had no answer to that, and it showed.

“I don’t want a plan.”

Nolan said it to the folder on his knee, his hands whiter than the paper.

“That’s all I’ve got,” he said. “I want to be sad, and I don’t want it to be at eleven-twelve.”

She had heard that sentence in the staff lot, with a milk crate of spring scales on the tailgate. *I need you not to make it better.* She had written the card herself, and it was in her coat on the hook by the door.

“It’s built in,” she said, because her mouth was still running. “There’s room in the schedule for it. That’s the point of the three minutes. You can take all of them.”

“You have planned it,” said Margit, “so that no one can say no.”

Thea turned to her.

“A time and a bell, and a pastry to sweeten them. You put my son in a box and the box in a schedule, and now if I say no, I am the one who spoils your page.” She had not moved her hands from the handbag. “That is not a family meeting. That is a funeral with chairs.”

“I planned it so nobody has to decide.”

“Yes,” said Margit. “That is what I said.”

The radiator knocked, and nobody looked at the dial.

Jonas had gone white, and Thea had not seen it happen. The page he had pulled from his folder was folded in quarters, then eighths, small as a stamp, his thumb working the crease.

“Jonas, it’s all optional. You don’t have to do the handful.”

“Optional,” said Margit, flat. “It has a time next to it.”

“It’s got a number on it,” Jonas said. “Me.”

“Jonas,” said Nolan, and put down the pogácsa.

“It’s okay. I’m just. I need to go and.” He set the folder on the seat, squared to the edge, the way he put down anything he had built, and walked to

the door. His sneakers went down the stairs at an even pace, then fast, and then the street door banged.

His parka hung on the hook with the gloves in the sleeve. It was twenty-three degrees on Water Street.

Nolan was up, the folder sliding off his knee, and across the room before the door had stopped moving. Thea went after him. He stopped on the landing with a hand on the rail and his heels up again, breathing through his nose as if he had been told to.

“Nolan.”

“Yeah.”

“He’s thirteen, he can’t have gone far. Go.”

“I’m going.” He did not go. “What if I go the wrong way? Give me a second.”

She gave him one, and it was a long one. She watched the muscle in his neck and did not say *breathe* or *look at me*. He looked down the stairwell at the street door. Then he went out, fast.

From the window Water Street lay gray under a lid of cloud, the plow ridges gone black with salt. There was no boy in either direction. Nolan stood beside the CR-V with a hand on the roof, looking left, looking right, and then he got in.

The brake lights stayed on while she counted forty seconds. She knew the shape of it from November, a parking lot, the nose pointed out. Then the CR-V pulled away from the curb and went left, toward the lake road.

• • •

“Right,” Thea said, with her coat off the hook and one arm in it. “Isla, take Third down to the marina and text me every block. I’ll do Water Street north. Margit, you should wait here.”

“Thea. Sit.”

She stood with her hand on the knob and her weight gone onto the front foot.

“Somebody stays where the boy can find,” Margit said. She had not got up. “That is you and me. Sit.”

Thea sat, the coat half on, one sleeve hanging.

Isla had her phone to her ear. From the hook, inside the parka, a small buzzing started and went on against the wall until the call gave up. “He left it,” Isla said. “Of course he left it.”

Margit stood slowly, as if the floor were farther down than she had counted on. She set the handbag, the foil and the closed folder on her seat, took the parka off the hook, and sat again on the edge of the chair with it across her knees.

“Margit,” Thea said. “I only meant to help. I should have asked first.”

“Not now. Now we wait.”

“I could call Dimitra. She knows every alley between here and the marina. She’d have the whole block in ten minutes.”

“It’s Jonas,” Isla said, to the window. “It’s not a cake.”

“Isla,” said Margit.

“Sorry.”

“No,” Thea said, looking at her own hands. “That’s fair.”

Isla stood with her arms wrapped around herself and her breath on the glass. “He does this. He goes where it’s loud and sits in the middle of it. The boiler room at school. The bleachers during pep band.”

“Where’s loud today, on a Sunday?”

“I don’t know, and if I knew it wouldn’t work.” Isla wiped a circle in the fog. “What works is somebody finding him and not talking. Uncle Nolan’s good at that. He did it at Thanksgiving.”

“Where is he?” said Margit. Her eyes had gone to the empty chair by the door.

“He went out in the car,” Thea said. “He’s looking.”

“Hm,” said Margit, and laid her hand on the sleeve. “He is thirteen. He will not feel the cold until he is home.”

Her lips moved without sound, in a language that was not English. Thea looked for the places a boy might be, and the studio was only a room with chairs in it. She could not have said which wall had the door.

At 2:49 the street door opened below, and two sets of feet came up, one heavy and one light. The third stair told on them.

Jonas came in first in Nolan’s gray coat, which fell to his knees, the cuffs over his hands, snow in his hair and his ears bright red. Nolan stood behind him in the doorway in his sweater and did not come further in.

Margit was on her feet. She had the gray coat off the boy and the parka around his shoulders before anyone spoke, both fists in the front of it, as if she were pulling him out of water. Isla put a hand on the back of his head.

“Are you hurt?” Margit said.

“No.”

“You’re blue,” said Isla.

“I’m not blue.” Jonas looked at the floor. “I wasn’t going anywhere. I was just sitting.”

“I didn’t know that,” said Nolan. “I should have.”

Nobody said anything, and then Nolan said it again, to the room, in short pieces, the way he said whatever he meant.

“I left. I got in the car and drove to the marina and sat in the lot with the engine on for ten minutes. Ten minutes, with a thirteen-year-old out in twenty-three degrees in a sweatshirt. Then I came back and walked it, Third Street, the alley. He was on the loading dock behind the bakery, with his feet over the edge. No coat.” His breath showed in the warm room. “If he’d gone to the lake instead of the bakery, ten minutes is a long time. I know exactly how long. I left. I came back. I’m sorry I left, and I don’t get credit for coming back.”

“Okay,” said Jonas, to his shoes.

“It isn’t okay, but thank you.”

Thea had stood up, and the half-worn coat slid off her arm to the floor. “Nolan, Jonas, I’m so sorry.”

Margit zipped the parka to her grandson’s chin. She did not look at Thea. Her gaze went over her the way a lamp goes over a wall on its way to the door. “Isla, get your bag.”

“Grandma.”

“Your bag.” Margit picked up the handbag and the foil bundle and left her folder where it lay. She stopped in front of Nolan with his own coat over her arm. For a second Thea thought she would say something to him, and she did, one word, the one she had used at Thanksgiving. She held the coat out.

“Carry,” said Margit.

He took it. He looked over his mother’s head at Thea.

“Thea.”

“Go,” she said, and he went, down the stairs behind his mother, a man in a sweater carrying two coats.

Isla was the last. She lifted her folder, held it a second, and then folded it in half and pushed it inside her coat, against her chest, and zipped the coat over it without looking at anyone.

Thea gathered the three folders left on the chairs. Margit’s had never been opened. She squared the stack against her thigh, and squared it again.

Chapter 20 — Everything Printed

The stack sat in her lap, three folders, eleven pages each, stapled top left at a slant because a slanted staple looks deliberate. Margit's was on the bottom with the staple still bright. Thea's own copy lay on its clipboard beside her knee, the highlighter uncapped, the yellow gone through to the back of page nine, the seating chart that was only a suggestion. She had been on the floor long enough for the heat to come on twice and go off again, and she had not turned on a light. Haskell's neon laid a red stripe across the boards, and the desk lamp made a small gold room in the corner.

The five white chairs stood in their horseshoe with nobody at the head. On the desk by the dial the bakery box from Third Street sat open, the string cut, fourteen pastries fanned inside, and nobody had eaten one.

She pulled her own copy out from under the clip and found page four without meaning to.

ORDER OF SERVICE: Sunday, December 27, Dunmore Point, 11:00.
Under it, in a column she had spent forty minutes aligning:

11:05 Welcome (Margit, 1 min).

11:08 Reading (Isla, 2 min).

11:12 Remarks (Nolan, 3 min).

11:15 Scattering (Jonas, first handful).

11:25 Closing (Margit).

11:30 Coffee in the cars.

She read the line about the first handful three times, then turned the page face down on the floor.

She found her phone under the couch fringe and typed with one thumb. *Can you come. Not work.* She looked at the word *can*, left it, sent it, and listened to the building tick.

The third stair announced Dimitra in eleven minutes. She wore a parka and a knitted hat with a pom-pom that Thea had never seen, which Dimitra snatched off as if it had been caught on camera. She stopped in the doorway and looked at the room the way she looked at a ballroom after a Rotary lunch: the chairs, the open box, the woman on the floor.

"Is anyone hurt," said Dimitra, "or is anyone coming?"

"Neither."

"Okay," said Dimitra, and came in, closed the door, and switched on nothing. She stuffed the hat in her pocket, laid the box lid over the pastries, crimped it down all the way around, and set the box on the sill.

“Dimitra,” Thea said. “The folders. There’s a master on the shared drive, if you need to.”

Dimitra crouched in front of her. She did not say *oh, honey*. She put two fingers under the edge of the stack in Thea’s lap and lifted, and Thea’s hands let it go, which she noticed the way you notice you have put down a bag. Dimitra took the clipboard copy too, and the spare set off the printer tray, and carried it all to the break room. Thea heard the lid of the blue bin and paper going in, a softer sound than she had expected, like somebody sitting down on a coat.

When Dimitra came back she capped the highlighter and set it by the lamp.

“I called Odessa from the stairs,” she said.

“You didn’t ask.”

“You wrote ‘can.’” Dimitra pulled the parka tighter and did not take it off. “In all the time I’ve worked for you, you have never once used that word with me. It’s ‘I need the cars at four.’ It’s ‘put this on the board.’ I figured whoever wrote ‘can’ needed somebody with more experience than me.”

“I’m fine.”

“Not on this one,” Dimitra said, not unkindly. “Tonight or tomorrow, any hour, I’m at my phone. Not ‘on it.’ Just at it. And don’t eat the pastries,” she said from the door. “They’re bad, and Odessa’s bringing real food.”

The stair creaked once, going down. Thea counted the places where the red stripe crossed the boards, four, and the room went on being a room without her.

• • •

Odessa came up the stairs the way she came into everything, with both arms full and her shoulder against whatever was in the way. She had a Dutch oven wrapped in two towels and a sleeve of paper bowls under her chin, and she kicked the studio door shut behind her.

“Macaroni,” she said. “Baked, three cheeses and a breadcrumb crust. It’s a long way from a hen. It’s carbohydrates.”

“You didn’t have to.”

“I’m aware.” She set the pot on the conference table, lifted the box lid on the sill with one finger, and looked. “Third Street, overpriced. The cannoli there taste like a handshake.” She let the lid fall. “Move over.”

“I’m not in the way.”

“You’re on the floor, honey. Move over.”

Thea shifted over. Odessa lowered herself against the couch with one knee cracking like a branch, and they sat with their backs to the green velvet and their legs out. She took the lid off the Dutch oven with her toe, and a ribbon of steam went up in the red light.

“Tell me like an incident report,” she said. “In order, no adjectives.”

“I printed an order of service for his brother’s ashes. With minutes.” It sounded worse out loud. “Jonas gets the first handful at eleven-fifteen.”

Odessa did not laugh, which was the kindest thing she had done all night.

“Did anybody get a vote?”

“I printed it twice. In case somebody wanted to take notes.”

“That’s a no.”

Odessa spooned macaroni into a paper bowl, laid a fork across the top, and set it on Thea’s knee. She ate a bite from her own and looked straight ahead at the butcher-paper timeline on the back wall, which still said, in Thea’s block capitals, *HANA/ROWAN. 6:42 TEARS (OPT.)*.

“Here’s the verdict,” she said. “You can hate it, I’m not taking it back.”

“Odessa.”

“You threw that man’s brother a funeral the way you threw your own wedding.” She said it slowly, a person laying down a hand of cards. “Perfectly. And with no room in it for anybody to be sad.”

For a moment it did not hurt at all. It fit, the way a key goes into the lock of a house you used to live in, and then the whole door gave.

“I was trying to give them something to hold,” she said.

“They didn’t need something to hold. They had four hundred things to hold, honey.”

“I don’t know how to build less.”

“No,” Odessa said, lower. “I was at that funeral. I stood by the coffee urn and watched you work the room like a goddamn orchestra, and I thought, God, she’s amazing. Then I went home and didn’t call you for eight days, because I figured you had it handled. That’s mine.” She pointed her fork at the face-down page on the floor. “The funeral’s yours to look at, honey. So look at it. The Thursdays aren’t. Don’t go picking those up off his floor just because you’re already down here.”

“I wasn’t.”

“You were reaching. I know the look. It’s the same one you get at a buffet when somebody else’s tongs are crooked.”

Thea made a sound that might have been a laugh and ate a bite of the macaroni, hot and salty and entirely itself.

"Is it good?" said Odessa.

"It's good."

"I know it's good. I made it."

It was what Odessa had said on the night of the hens, and she had said it on purpose. She took a second bite.

Her phone lit on the floor beside her hip, face up in the stripe of red light, a single line on the screen.

I'll stay away until you tell me.

No *I love you*, no *I'm sorry*. He had followed term three exactly.

"Good or bad?" said Odessa.

"It's the right sentence."

"Those are the worst ones."

Thea turned the phone over and set it on the boards. The bowl was empty. Odessa stacked it inside her own bowl and began to unfold herself in sections.

"I'm not sleeping on that couch again," she said. "It has a spring with a grudge. I'm going home to a husband who thinks the vacuum is a pet, and I'll be back at six with coffee, and you will not have organized anything."

"I won't organize anything."

"Say it like you mean it."

"I'm too tired to lie."

"Good enough." At the door she dropped the second towel over Thea's shoulders and left the pot on the table with the lid cocked. "Eat the rest or I'll know. I can tell from the crust."

The stair creaked, then the street door, and Thea was alone with the macaroni.

• • •

She called him without deciding to. Her thumb went to the name she had typed in a diner three weeks into dating him, with a coffee ring drying beside her cup, and never deleted, *Nolan, Do Not Lose*.

He answered on the first ring. "Thea."

"Nobody's hurt. I'm calling about your text," she said.

Something ticked near him, the porch light or the cold. "I'm on the front steps. I haven't gone in. I walked home from Ma's."

"You walked."

“She held her hand out for the keys in her driveway, and I gave them to her.” He said it without any shape on it. “She’ll give them back tomorrow. She says I don’t drive the kids Tuesday. She’s right. I sat in a car for ten minutes while he was out there with no coat. I told her, and I told Isla, so somebody young remembers: next time I’m like that, I hand somebody my keys before I get in the car, not after.”

“Stop.”

“Stop what?”

“All of it, for now.” She had to push the words out in order. “Not forever. Hear that I said not forever. I can’t do this with you while I’m like this.”

“Like what?”

“Like someone who prints an order of service for your brother. Don’t tell me it was kind. It was a run of show. I gave you three minutes.” Her laugh came out of her like a cough. “I gave you remarks, with a time. I put a number next to a thirteen-year-old’s name.”

“I read it, and it was in my hand.” His voice was steady and very short.

“Maybe you were right in the car.” It came out of her in the dark before she could look at it. “Maybe that’s why you went. I make it so nobody can say no. I made it so you couldn’t tell me.”

“No.”

It was the loudest word he had said to her since the boathouse.

“Don’t,” he said. “I said that in the car on Thursday and I took it back, and I’m not letting you pick it up now because you’re on a floor. You printed a bad agenda. That’s yours, you can have it. Three years of Thursdays are mine. I chose them every week. I put a passcode on them. Don’t put my Thursdays in your pile, Thea. I won’t let you carry those too.”

She sat with the phone against her ear and the macaroni bowl empty on her knee and could not, for a second, find a single thing to say back.

“I’ll leave it alone,” he said, quieter. “You told me what you need. You need me to stop. I’ll stop.”

It should have been enough. It was what she had asked for, in exactly those words, and the floor came up under her anyway, because he had not argued.

“I have a lawyer,” she said.

“I know,” said Nolan, over the small ticking on his end.

“I know her number by heart. Two-three-one, five-five-five.” She said the last four digits too, in the voice she used on a venue manager who had lost a

contract, and heard it land on the line and lie there. “I could call her tonight. It’s a Sunday, and she’d pick up. She gives clients her cell for a reason.”

“I know you could.”

“Say something.”

“What do you want me to say?”

She had the whole sentence ready and nothing inside it. She wanted him to shout, to say *you wouldn’t* so she could say *watch me*, to give her a fight with a floor under it. “Say anything that isn’t ‘I understand.’”

“I wasn’t going to say that.”

“You were.”

“I was going to say I’d understand, and I thought, she’ll hear it. So I didn’t.”

“I heard it anyway.”

“Yes.”

“It’s a hollow thing to say, Nolan, to someone who has a number memorized.”

“It’s what I’ve got.”

Out on Water Street a plow went by with its blade down, and the windows hummed with it. When the sound had gone she found that she had said the lawyer’s number out loud to her husband and had not meant a single digit of it.

“Is Jonas all right?” she said.

“He’s warm. He ate. He wouldn’t look at me, and he was right not to. Isla sent me one word on the way home. I won’t tell you what it was, because it’s hers.”

“Okay.”

“Thea, I’m not going anywhere. I’m just not going to be where you are. That’s different.”

“It is different.”

He did not say goodnight right away. He said, a little lower, “Did you eat?”

“Odessa brought macaroni, the baked kind.”

“Good.”

“Goodnight, Nolan.”

“Goodnight.”

She ended the call before he could, and stood with the phone in her hand and the warm towel sliding off her shoulder. The studio was as she had left it,

fourteen pastries under a lid, a tears cue on the wall for somebody else's wedding.

She sat down on the floor again and opened her contacts. She typed *Ber*, and the rest filled itself in, Bernadette Roy, Attorney, with the number under it that she had just said out loud to a man on a dark porch. Her thumb came down above the green button and stopped a quarter inch from the glass. She had the sentence ready for when the woman picked up: *I've decided*. It was a good sentence, concise, with a verb in it. She lowered her thumb and lifted it, twice more, the way you check a door you know is locked.

She set the phone on the floorboards, face up, and watched Bernadette's name go dim in the red.

"All right," Thea told the Dutch oven, over its slow ticking. "I'll eat the rest. She'd know if I didn't."

Part Four — The Carrying

I'll let you carry me, and I'll carry you.

Chapter 21 — The Closet

The key turned on the first try. Thea had half hoped it wouldn't.

She stood on the porch of the bungalow on Alder Street with the storm door braced against her hip. The porch light was on in broad daylight. Nothing hung from the eave and no tree stood in the front window, though every December since 2018 she had put up the first strand on the first, and the house looked like something that had been told the date and decided to ignore it.

Nolan had a records day at school and would be there until three. She had typed it into the family calendar herself in August, in teal.

"Biscuit?" she said into the hall.

Nothing came, no nails on the oak, no thump of a beagle falling off a bed. The hook by the door was empty where the leash lived. She stood on the mat and listened to the house.

The house smelled of Nolan and dog and a thermostat set to sixty-two. Her gray slippers sat by the radiator, toes to the wall, exactly where she had stepped out of them on the morning of the eighth. Nobody had moved them.

In the kitchen there was one mug in the rack and one plate. On the second shelf of the refrigerator stood three yogurt tubs with masking tape across the lids, MON. TUES. WED., in Margit's block capitals. Margit, who in four weeks had not said a sentence to her son that didn't begin with a verb, had been leaving paprikás on his porch.

Thea shut the refrigerator. She had come for clothes: six weeks out of a go-bag and the studio's emergency drawer had left her with eleven identical black T-shirts, and she wanted jeans that were hers and socks nobody had ordered in bulk.

In the bedroom Nolan had made the bed, which meant he had pulled the quilt up in one motion and let it lie. On her side the pillow held a dent the exact shape of an eleven-year-old beagle. From the second drawer she took jeans, two sweaters and a fistful of socks and dropped them on the bed.

Her boots were in the closet.

It was the only deep closet in the house, built in 1926 for somebody's trunk, with a shelf over the rail the full width of the wall and a bulb on a pull chain. She pulled the chain. Nolan's side came first, corduroys, then the charcoal suit in a dry cleaner's bag with the receipt stapled to the plastic, dated the ninth. Her side held garment bags and a coat she hadn't worn since a funeral.

She bent for the boots. She straightened, and her eye went to the top shelf and stopped.

It was a good eye. It could take in a ballroom from the door and find the one chair out of true, and now it held on the shelf while the rest of the closet went soft around it.

The box sat at the back, behind a bag of Christmas lights and two winter hats: plain pale pine, not much bigger than a toaster, with a brass hasp and a white card hanging from it on a wire. Along the front edge of the shelf ran a strip of tape from the studio label maker, white letters on black, which she had stuck there herself. C.M. — HOLD.

Margit had said she could not have him in her house and could not scatter him, and Nolan could not so much as touch the box, so at the funeral home Thea had said, *I'll take him*. She had set him up there that first November and had not touched him since. She had labeled him. She had put a person on a shelf and filed him.

She set the boots down and reached up, and the box came toward her over the lip of the shelf with a small dry scrape.

It was heavier than she had thought.

She had thought, when she thought of it at all, of a box of tea. Her arms dropped an inch under it and she brought it in against her stomach. Seven pounds, eight. The binder weighed eleven. Now she stood holding her brother-in-law while the bulb swung on its chain.

She went down against the wall between Nolan's shoes and hers, the way you go down a ladder, and put the box in her lap.

The card on the hasp was typed: MORAVEC, CALLUM, a number, a date in October. In three years she had not read it, and it was shorter than she would have thought.

"Hello," Thea said.

The closet gave nothing back.

"Callum."

She had said the name a hundred times in six weeks, to Nolan across a desk and once to a windshield, and never to him.

"It's me. I put you up here." Her thumb went toward the label above her, out of reach now, and she let her hand drop. "It says HOLD. I made a label. You'd have lost your mind."

She laid her hand on the lid.

“I should have said this in October. The first October. I was busy.” She heard it and shook her head at herself. “That’s not a reason. Ruth Ann Pruitt cried when I read her your order. Danny’s mother, Cal, the boy with the braces on your Saturday team. She cried into the buckets, and I replaced her. I still buy my ribbon from her.”

The bulb ticked as it cooled.

“I cut your picture out. The lawn chair, the fishing hat.” Her voice had gone low and flat and slow, a voice with no work in it. “I’d put it in the middle now.

“You’d have driven him out to the lake and asked him. You’d just have asked.” She stopped. Her mouth had begun to do something she couldn’t control, and she let it. “Nobody calls me Clipboard anymore. They say, ‘Thea, do you have a.’ That’s the whole sentence. Do you have a.”

She bent over the box until her forehead lay on the lid. This time she made no sound, because there was no wall to tear out. It came out of her slowly, like water from a tap somebody had forgotten to turn off, and she let it run onto the wood and did not wipe it.

She stayed there until her knees went numb. Somewhere in it, she heard the front door.

Nails came first, quick and clicking, a little uneven in the back left. Then Biscuit’s whole face was in the closet door, ears forward. He came in, turned twice on a pair of boots and lay down across her shins with a groan.

“Hey, bud,” Thea said into his ears. “Who brought you?”

“Told you,” said Isla’s voice from the bedroom. “Her car’s in the driveway.”

“I said that. I said it was her car.”

“You said it was a car.”

Thea lifted her head and wiped her face once, hard, with her sleeve. “In here,” she said. Isla stood in the doorway in a gray knit hat with her hands in her coat, snow melting on her shoulders. Jonas stood behind her with the end of a green leash wound twice around his fist. His hat was too big for him. It was Callum’s, blue, with a faded block M.

“I’m getting clothes,” Thea said.

Isla looked at the pile on the bed, then at the tape on the shelf and the box in Thea’s lap.

“That’s a lot of clothes,” she said. Her face did what it always did, which was nothing, but it took longer than usual.

“Six weeks of the go-bag,” said Thea. “I wanted my own socks.”

“Isla, how did you get here?”

“We walked. It’s a mile and a half.” Isla unzipped her coat an inch and zipped it up again. “Uncle Nolan dropped Biscuit at six-forty. He rang the bell and left him on the mat like a casserole. Grandma took him in and didn’t say a word.”

“Not one,” Jonas said.

“Then around nine she was sitting at the table with her coat on, not going anywhere, and I said we’d walk him home. She said, ‘Wear the hats.’”

Thea’s eyes went to the blue hat on Jonas’s head. “She said that?”

“Like a weather report,” said Isla.

“It fits,” Jonas said, to nobody. “It only looks big.”

“It’s down to your nose,” said Isla.

“I can see out of it.”

“Does she know where you are?”

“She knows we’re walking Biscuit home. I left a note on the pad by the phone. ‘Alder Street. Back by four.’” Isla’s chin came up a fraction. “We were going to bring him in and leave. That’s what I told myself the whole way.”

“And then you saw the car.”

“And then we saw the car.”

Jonas hadn’t moved. He looked at the box from under the blue hat the way he looked at a device he hadn’t built yet.

“Is that him?” he said.

“Yes.”

“It’s smaller than I thought.”

“It’s heavier than I thought,” said Thea.

Jonas took that in slowly. Then, in a voice with the ends worn off it: “Can I?”

“Can we hold him?” Isla said. Her chin was up.

Thea looked down at the lid, where her fingers had left their prints in the damp. She had never once been asked.

“Yes,” she said. “Of course you can.”

She tried to stand and her knees wouldn’t do it.

“They’re asleep,” she said. “Give me a second.”

“You don’t have a second.” Isla crossed the closet in two steps, took her arm and pulled, and Thea came up out of the shoes with the box against her chest. Biscuit rolled off her shins and followed.

“Sit,” said Isla, pointing at the bed, in her grandmother’s exact voice. “Sorry. It just comes out.”

They sat. Thea took the middle, because the kids had made it the middle, Isla on her right and Jonas on her left.

“Is it okay to just sit?” Jonas asked.

“It’s the only thing on the list,” said Thea.

“Here,” she said, and set the box across her knees, and then, because it was too much for one lap, across all three.

“It’s on my leg,” Jonas said.

“It’s on everybody’s leg,” said Isla.

Jonas put his hand on the lid and left it there. Biscuit jumped up at the foot of the bed and sat.

“It’s pine,” Jonas said. He ran a thumb along the grain at the corner. “It’s not good pine. There’s a knot.”

“I never looked,” said Thea.

“He’d say it looks like a loaf,” said Isla.

“He’d say it looks like a loaf of bread,” Jonas said, “and then he’d eat off the lid.”

Isla made a sound that was half a laugh and half a hiccup. “Stop it,” she said. “I can’t do this if you’re funny.”

“I’m not funny,” said Jonas, and turned his face to the window. His hand stayed on the lid. Thea kept both of hers where they were.

The radiator ticked. Biscuit sighed through his nose.

“Grandma won’t say his name,” Isla said.

She said it to the box.

“What does she say instead?” said Thea.

“She says ‘your father.’ She says ‘your brother.’ She gave me his jersey to put in the wash and said, ‘Take this.’ I said, ‘Whose is it?’ And she said, ‘Just take it.’” Isla’s thumb moved on the quilt. “Uncle Nolan won’t touch him. He told Grandma once he gets dressed with his back to that closet. Every morning. Like it has a smell.”

“Like it’s wet paint,” said Jonas.

“And you.” Isla finally looked up. “You kept him. For three years. Where else would we go?”

“Storage,” Thea said. “I put a label on it.”

“That’s what keeping is. Only meaner.” Isla looked at the tape, then back. “I saw the label. It’s the first thing I’d have done, honestly. I’d have done the label.”

“You’d have done a better label.”

“I’d have done a font.”

“Comic Sans,” said Jonas, flat.

“Don’t,” said Isla, and her voice cracked down the middle.

Jonas made a noise that could have been a laugh or the other thing. Biscuit got up, walked the length of the quilt and lay down against his hip, and Jonas let his free hand drop onto the dog’s back.

“Are you cold?” Thea asked. “You walked a mile and a half.”

“Biscuit’s warm,” said Jonas.

“I’m cold,” said Isla. “Nobody asks me.”

“I’m asking,” said Thea.

“Is it okay that we came?” Jonas asked.

“It’s my house too,” Thea said, and was surprised by how steadily it came out. “I came for jeans. I stayed for this.”

“The jeans are on the bed,” said Jonas. “You can still take them.”

“I might leave them,” said Thea.

“You didn’t plan it,” Isla said.

“No.”

“That’s weird to hear.”

“It’s weird to say.”

Isla let go of the corner of the box and put her hands under her thighs. She was looking at the lake photograph over the dresser, which Nolan had hung crooked in 2019 and Thea had never fixed.

“I have to say something to Grandma,” she said.

“Whenever you’re ready,” said Thea.

“I wrote it down. It’s four pages, it’s bad. It’s more of a list, of things I saw.” Her voice thinned. “I tried it in the shower. I got through two lines and had to turn the water up. I don’t know how to do it. I don’t know when. I’m scared. I’m so scared I threw up Saturday, and Grandma thought it was the ham.”

“It wasn’t the ham,” Jonas said, to the lid. “I had the ham.”

“You had two helpings,” said Isla. “That is how we know.”

“Okay,” Thea said, and kept her hand on the lid beside his.

“Okay?”

“That’s it.”

Isla stared at her. “You’re not going to make me a plan.”

“No.”

“You’re not going to tell me what to say first. Or when, or where.”

“I don’t know what to say first, and I don’t know when. I don’t know what you saw. I’m glad you told me you’re scared.”

“That’s all you’ve got?”

“It’s what I’ve got today.”

“It’s more than the binder had,” said Isla.

Isla shook her head, once, at nothing. “Weird,” she said, with no edge on it at all, and leaned. She did not lean far. Her shoulder came to rest against Thea’s arm and stayed there, lighter than the box.

On the other side Jonas had pushed his hat back. His hand lay spread on the pine.

“The note says back by four,” he said.

“I know what the note says,” said Isla.

“I’m saying we have time.”

“You have time,” said Thea.

Biscuit put his chin on the lid.

Snow came down past the window. The three of them sat on the bed with the box across their knees, and nobody got up.

Chapter 22 — Potatoes

“Peel,” Margit said, and put the peeler into Thea’s hand before she had her coat off.

It was the old kind, a steel Y with a wooden handle gone gray from sixty years of dishwater and a spot of rust where the blade met the frame. Thea had used it at ten Thanksgivings. She had never been handed it like a summons.

“I said ten,” said Margit. “It is ten-oh-six.”

“I was in the car.”

“Six minutes, and I watched from the window. Hands on the wheel like a girl waiting for the examiner.” She lifted the coat off Thea’s arm, hung it on the hook by the back door, and pointed at the end chair. “There.”

Thea sat in the chair that had been hers for ten years.

At ten past seven that morning Margit’s voice on the phone had said, *Ten o’clock. Wear something you can ruin. Bring nothing.* Thea had begun “Margit, about Sunday,” and the line had gone dead. She was wearing the gray sweater with the bleach spot. She had brought nothing, and had still sat in the Subaru for six minutes, wanting a clipboard.

The kitchen had been cleared down to the oilcloth, the near half of the table papered with this week’s *Courier*, sports section up. A ten-pound sack of russets slumped beside Margit’s chair. Two paring knives, two mugs, and a colander waited on the oilcloth, and a stockpot sat on a cold stove. At the far corner, where Thea had left it five weeks ago, the navy binder sat closed under a casserole lid with a mug ring beside it. She read the room as she read every room, and it looked like a stage after a strike.

“Where are the children?”

“Out.” Margit sat, hoisted the sack onto her knee, and counted potatoes into a bowl with her thumb. “Jonas has twenty dollars and Gino’s. Isla has the field house until three. It is Tuesday, and his uncle does not drive them this Tuesday. I said so on Sunday in my driveway, with my hand out for his keys, and he put them in it before I had finished the sentence.” She looked at the potato. “I told the children not to come home before dark. They did not ask why. That is new.”

“Margit. About Sunday.”

“Peel.”

“I’m sorry. The agenda, the run of show. I put his time on it. I put the day on it.”

“Eleven o’clock on the twenty-seventh, at Dunmore Point.” The peeler in Margit’s hand did not stop, and a long pale ribbon dropped onto the newspaper. “Isla brought hers home inside her coat. She thinks I did not see. When she was asleep I took it off the hall table and read it here, twice, with my glasses.”

“I should have asked you first.”

“It had a hymn.”

“It had a hymn.”

“You put me a blessing in the middle so I would not have to make a speech.” The potato turned in her palm. “It was a good order of service, Thea. That is the worst of it.”

Thea looked down at the one in her own hand. “I thought if it was written down, nobody would have to carry it.”

“Yes. I know what you thought. I invented that.” Margit took another potato. “Away from the thumb. Ten years you peel toward the thumb, and I never said, because I thought you would learn.”

Thea turned the blade around. The skin came off in short, stubborn curls.

“The children went to you yesterday,” Margit said.

“They did. I didn’t ask them to.”

“Isla left a note on the pad by the telephone. *Alder Street. Back by four.*” Her mouth moved. “She was back at ten of. Both of them had washed faces. Nobody washes a face at four in the afternoon unless there is a reason.”

“We sat on the bed. They wanted to.”

“I know what is in your closet, kicsim.” Margit did not look up. “I have known since the night you took it to your house. I did not ask, and I did not want to know which shelf.”

“No.”

“Did they hold it?”

“Yes. It’s heavier than I thought.”

“Of course it is,” said Margit, and put a potato in the pot, and a second, and did not speak again for nine minutes by the stove clock.

Thea counted, because it was the only thing she had. The enamel bowl with the chip filled like a buffet line, one cover at a time. Margit’s skins came off in single ribbons, thin as paper. Thea’s came off in chunks with little white hollows where she had gone too deep, and the hollows were starting to show.

At fourteen potatoes, Margit said, to the one in her hand: “I knew he was somewhere on Thursdays.”

The peeler stopped in Thea's hand.

"Go on, peel. A mother knows, not what, only that." The knife in Margit's fist worked an eye out of a russet in one flick. "He came on Fridays for the soup and he had a face. I thought, what is that face. A face that has been held under the water and let up. A rinsed face."

"I thought it was the department."

"A clever woman, and you thought the department. So." She shrugged, one shoulder. "I did not say. A mother does not say. I thought, it is a woman. And I prayed it was a woman."

"You prayed for that."

"Every Friday. Nothing big, a woman in a hat with a bad perfume, a mistake with a name I could say." The knife came down. "Someone I could scold. I had the speech ready two years. I would have gone to her door in my good shoes."

Thea laughed, once, before she could stop it, and heard it go wrong in the middle.

"It is not funny."

"It is a little funny." Margit's thumb pressed a green spot out of a potato. "It was a basement. It was a car. My son sitting in the one and then the other, crying where his mother could not see him. I cannot scold a basement, Thea. I have nowhere to put the speech." She laid the potato in the pot very carefully, as if it could bruise. "Nolika, in a car, with his hands on the wheel. I see it when I close my eyes. I have seen it every night since Thanksgiving."

"He told you at Thanksgiving. He told you it was a group."

"He told me at my table, with my turkey. I heard *car* and *crying* and nothing after. I am an old woman. I stood at the front of that church and thought, what a strong boy, good boy, four hours." Her voice did not rise. "Three years I fed a drowning man soup."

"He wasn't the only one who didn't say."

"No?"

"I asked nobody," Thea said. "I wrote the thank-you notes. I ordered the sunflowers. I didn't ask him, and I didn't ask you."

Margit looked at her over the bowl at last. Her black eyes were wet along the rim, and she did nothing about it.

"Peel," she said, but gently. "It is only potatoes."

The furnace came on in the cellar with a thump and a long breath, and the oilcloth shivered under Thea's wrists. Outside, the driveway lay under its old

snow, shoveled to a narrow path and no further. Nobody had been down it. She noticed it as she would an unlit exit.

Margit's pile of skins had grown to the size of a loaf. She picked up a long dry curl with the brown just starting at one end and turned it in the light.

"Callum ate the skins," she said.

Thea did not move.

"Not raw. I fried them. A little oil, salt, paprika, in the black pan, while the potatoes boiled. He stood where you are sitting and took them off the newspaper before they were cool. He burned his mouth every time." She held the curl very still, as though it might break. "Thirty years he burned his mouth, and he said, Ma, it's the best part. I said, then peel your own. He said, Ma, you do it better."

The knife lay on the newspaper. The stove clock ticked over. A car went by on Cooper Street with chains on, and the sound went on a long time after it had passed.

"Callum," Margit said again, to the table, trying it like a stair that has been out of use. She put the skin down on the pile and looked at her own hand. Then she picked up the knife and took another potato from the sack, and her voice came back in its working register. "The black pan is in the bottom cabinet. I will want it."

"I'll get it."

"Later." Her eyes were on the potato. "Rinse these, they are going gray."

Thea stood, lifted the bowl, and took it to the sink.

She turned the tap on, set the colander in the basin, and tipped the potatoes in, and the water ran over them, loud against the steel. She reached to turn the first one, and her hand did not go there. It lay on the edge of the sink, and then both hands lay on the edge, and the window gave her the mailbox at the end of the shoveled path and a gray hump of snow where the lilac was, and she could not find the edges of any of it.

It came up in the order it wanted, the shoulders first, then a noise, low and unhurried, from a mouth that had opened with nothing in it. She held the sink. The water ran on the potatoes. She had no idea how long it went on, and for once in her working life she was in a room with a person in it and nobody was holding the schedule.

The floor creaked behind her, once.

Margit, five foot one in her house slippers, put both hands on Thea's arms and turned her around. Thea folded at the waist, there being nowhere else to

go, and her forehead came down against the wool of Margit's cardigan, which smelled of onions and Jergens. A small strong palm settled between her shoulder blades and stayed there. It did not pat.

Margit reached behind her with the other hand and turned off the tap, and then the hand went back to where it had been.

"Jól van," she said. "Jól van, kicsim. Jól van."

"I didn't cry," Thea said into the wool. It was less a sentence than a thing falling out. "I didn't cry for him. I did the *flowers*, Margit."

"I never said goodbye to him."

"I know. I watched you not say it, and I was grateful, God forgive me. Somebody was doing the thing, and I did not have to." The hand moved up, and down, one stroke. "You think you are good at carrying, so nobody should carry you? I did that sixty-eight years. It is stupid."

Thea laughed again, and it was wet and ugly, and it went straight into the cardigan. "Nolan said I'd have made a plan. That's why the car. Then he took it back. He said it was the thing he told himself so he could keep going to the car."

"Good. It is a thing a man says when he wants the car to be somebody else's fault, and he took it back, so he has learned one thing this winter." Margit's voice shook, and she let it. "He has a mouth. I gave it to him. He could have used it on you, and he used it in a parking lot. I will tell him so at my table. And I am ten minutes from making a fool of myself in front of a sack of potatoes, so you will stop, please, so that I do not have to start."

"I'm trying."

"Try with your whole face."

It took a while longer. When it was done it was done all at once, and Thea stood with her glasses fogged on their cord, breathing hard.

"I have something of yours," she said. She straightened, hunted for the coat on the hook, and put her hand into the left pocket. "I found it in the go-bag last night. I should have brought it back weeks ago. I didn't know how."

She held it out. The white cotton had gone soft with handling, and at one corner the blue thread had come loose in a little hanging loop.

Margit took it between two fingers and looked at the corner. "It comes undone," she said. "Since before I was born. Josef's mother sewed it with thread she carried out of Szeged, and it comes undone, and somebody fixes it. I have fixed it three times." She shook it out once, then took Thea's chin in her

free hand and wiped her face with it, not gently, the way you do a child's on the church steps. Thea stood and was done to.

"There," Margit said.

She pressed it back into Thea's palm and closed her fingers over it, as she had in the net loft six weeks ago.

"Keep it till Thursday. Bring it with you. I may need something to hold."

"Thursday."

"I will tell you. Sit."

Thea sat, and a plate arrived at her elbow without having been seen to travel: rye with lard and shaved onion and a red dust of paprika. Margit put the kettle on and stood at the stove with her arms crossed and her back turned, and Thea ate the first slice because it was in front of her and the second because it was good.

When Margit turned around her face was her own again, shut and sure.

"Now I will say what I want, since nobody asked. You made a paper. My granddaughter made a face. My son made a speech about being sad. Nobody said, Margit, what do you want."

"What do you want?"

"Nothing planned." She sat and folded her hands on the oilcloth as if for grace. "Christmas Eve. Here, in my kitchen, with the door not locked and the porch light on. Whoever comes, comes. Whatever there is, there is. If it is a ham, it is a ham. If it is bread and a jar of pickles, it is bread."

Thea's hand went to her hair for the pen and found only hair. "You need a count for the ham."

"I need no count. I have counted the meals of Moravec men since 1986." Margit's eyebrows went up a quarter inch. "I would like to be surprised."

"What about the cousins?"

"I have told nobody. If I tell, it is a plan."

"What about Nolan?"

"He comes if he comes. I handed him a coat. It was not enough, and he knew it, and he took it anyway, in both hands. I will speak to him at my table, with a plate in front of him, not in a lobby or over a turkey. I have a great deal to say." A sniff. "Some of it is not a speech."

"And Isla?"

"Isla has a face like a girl with a letter to mail. I will wait until she mails it."

"I don't know if I can sit at a table and not run it," Thea said.

“Then sit on your hands. I will give you a chair.”

“I did that at Thanksgiving.”

“You did it badly, so do it again.” Margit poured the tea. “I have a question for you, since we are being honest in my kitchen. Are you going back to him?”

“I don’t know.”

“Did I ask?”

“You just did.”

“I asked what you were *doing*. It is different.” The cup came across the oilcloth. “That is yours. Mine is Thursday. We will not mix the two, like the salt and the sugar.”

Thea drank. It was bad tea, boiled, strong enough to stand a spoon in. She opened her left fist and slid the handkerchief into the pocket of her sweater, where it made a small square against her ribs.

“Who is feeding you?” Margit said. “On the studio couch.”

“Odessa, with soup, mostly. Dimitra brings lemon bars and stands there until I eat one.”

“The loud one with the towel,” Margit said. “A good woman for a person who swears at poultry.” She studied the ceiling, tallying. “Tell her there is a chair for her too. Tell her I did not say it with enthusiasm.”

“She’ll bring hens.”

“Then she will bring hens, and I will be rude about them, and we will eat them.”

Margit stood and took up the peeler. She set it in front of Thea again, handle first.

“Ten more,” she said. “Away from the thumb.”

Thea took it.

At the door, twenty minutes later, with her coat on and the pot of potatoes ticking on the stove behind them, Margit stopped her with a hand on her sleeve. She did not hug her, and looked at the buttons.

“Thursday, four o’clock,” she said. “Bring nothing. If you bring a dish, I will put it in the yard.”

Chapter 23 — Say It In Front of Me

Thea had squared nine chairs before the sexton said anything.

“Ma’am.”

“They were off.” She was already on the tenth. The folding chairs ran down the side aisle of St. Brendan’s, extras for tomorrow night’s ten o’clock Mass, and whoever had set them out had done it by eye. Her hands knew the fix without her, a heel to the seam in the floor tile and a nudge. “By half an inch. The back row is drifting.”

“It’s a church.” He was a stooped man in a knit watch cap, laying hymnals at the end of each pew, thumb under the spine. “It’s been half an inch off since 1951, and nobody’s come to harm.”

“I’m not trying to harm anybody.”

He looked at the chair under her hand, and then at her. “No, ma’am. You want to do hymnals? I’ve got eighty more.”

She almost said yes, and said instead, “I’m waiting for someone.”

“Pew’s free,” he said, and went up the aisle with the box on his hip, humming something with no tune in it.

She sat in the third pew from the side door with her coat on and her hands in her lap. Four candles burned in the Advent wreath, three purple and one pink. On a table by the altar rail the crèche stood with its manger empty and the straw laid in a tidy square. She had found all three exits before she sat down.

Left of the rail was a small side chapel with a window of a boat on a green sea, and its door stood open, held by a kneeler.

At nine the night before, from the studio couch, she had typed *Stop is over. One line. Where will you be tomorrow?* He had answered inside a minute, and it was not one line.

St. Brendan’s. 5:30 with Abel. At 6:15 I’m saying goodbye to Leona in the lot, out loud, not in a car. I asked Abel on Monday to ask her if she would hear one thing from me with you standing there. She said yes if you come. I’d like you to come. I’ll say it either way.

She had read it three times and written *Where do I sit.* He had written *Anywhere. It’s warm.*

The chapel was twenty feet from her pew. The church had been built so the back row got every word.

“I wrote it out last night,” Nolan was saying. “Four pages. Then I tore it up.”

“Why?” said Abel.

“Because I’d have read it to her off the paper so I wouldn’t have to look at anybody. It was for me.” A chair creaked. “I asked Thea to come. And half of me hopes she doesn’t. So she doesn’t have to watch me do the thing with my face again. She’s had six weeks of it. She ran a whole funeral around it.”

“And whom is that hope for?”

The radiator knocked twice, and Thea counted it without meaning to.

“Me,” Nolan said. “I know. I asked her anyway. That’s the part I could do.”

Nobody spoke while the sexton set down six hymnals in a row, softly, as if the sound might be a problem.

“She is in the third pew,” said Abel. “I propped the door. It was a kneeler. I would not call it a plan.”

Abel came out slowly. He stopped at the end of her pew and did not sit.

“I do not carry messages,” he said. “But I will not pretend about a door.”

“I heard that.”

“Yes.” He studied the Advent wreath. “He came to me on Monday with the whole of it already decided. I only had to make a telephone call. In thirty years that has happened to me perhaps four times.” He went off toward the sacristy, and a drawer scraped open.

She crossed to the chapel door and stopped, because Nolan was sitting on the front bench with his hands between his knees, looking at them.

“You came,” he said.

“You asked.”

“I’d have said it better if I’d known you were out there.”

“You’d have said it like that, to him. That’s why it worked.” She laid her palm on the door frame, which was cold, and left it there. “Do you want me next to you, or behind you?”

He looked up at her as if no one had ever asked him where he wanted anybody.

“Next to,” he said. “A little to the side. Where I can’t see your face, or I’ll do it for your face.”

• • •

At six-fourteen it was snowing the fine dry way it did once the cold had settled in for good, a few flakes at a time through the cone of the one lamp. The Subaru and the CR-V sat side by side, noses out. Nolan stood at the CR-

V's bumper in his school coat with his hands in his pockets, and Thea stood a yard to his left with hers in her own.

"I don't have anything written," he said.

"Good."

"What if I do it badly?"

"Then you'll do it badly in front of me." Her breath rose through the cone of the lamp. "One rule for me. I don't cue you, and if I start to, you say my name."

"Start to what?"

"Fix it and move it along. Say 'Let's keep this to ten minutes.'" Her mouth had already half done it, and she almost laughed. "My hands stay in my pockets. If one comes out, say Thea."

"Okay." He looked at the lamp. "Thea."

"I haven't done anything yet."

"I wanted to practice."

Headlights swung across the snow at six-nineteen and came to rest at the far end of the row, nowhere near the basement door. The engine cut, and the green Forester sat a moment ticking before Leona got out in her navy fleece with the lanyard around her neck and did not lock the car. She did not come toward them. She stood at her own fender with her arms folded against the cold.

Nolan walked until he was six feet from her. Thea went with him and stopped a half step to his left, a little behind his shoulder.

"Thank you for coming," he said.

"Abel asked nicely." Leona's gray eyes went to Thea and came back. "I have twenty minutes. Felix is at the neighbor's till seven."

He took a hand out of his pocket and did not know where to put it. "Hale —"

It was out before he could stop it. Leona's face did not change, and her folded arms tightened by about an inch.

"Leona," he said, and started over. "I'm going to say how it goes from now on, so it's been said out loud in front of both of you, and nobody has to wonder. I haven't written since the eighth of November. Your number's blocked, and it stays blocked. I'm not at the Table anymore. The chair's yours." His voice held. "If we're in the same place, the IGA, the school, a funeral, I'll say hello like a person and keep walking, and I'll tell Thea that

night, even if it was nothing. Especially if it was nothing. I moved my prescriptions to the pharmacy at the other end of Fifth."

Leona said nothing. The snow settled on her shoulders.

"The twenty-second of October, and the ninth of February." He said the second date carefully, like a thing he had no right to hold. "I know both of them now. On those days, if it gets bad, I call the woman I see in Holland, or Gus, or my wife. Not you. Not ever you." And then his voice began to go, and he let it. "I'm sorry I made you carry it."

"You didn't make me."

"I'm sorry anyway."

"Don't take my half," she said quietly. "I'll want it later. I'd like to have it where I can find it."

"All right."

"And I was never your place to breathe, Nolan. I told you that in March."

"You told me in March, and I kept coming."

"So did I."

Thea's right hand had come out of her pocket and was halfway to his sleeve.

"Thea," said Nolan, without turning his head.

"Thank you." The hand went home to the pocket.

Then Leona turned her whole body toward Thea.

"I'll say one thing to you, and you can hand it back if you don't want it."

"Go ahead."

"I knew what it was. I told him to bring you, and then I kept the Thursdays anyway, because it was the only easy thing I had that year." She did not look away. "I'm not going to tell you it didn't help me. It did. It cost you, and I knew it would, and I kept coming."

"You told me you know what a slow overdose looks like."

"I did say that. I've read it off a hundred labels. It doesn't stop you."

"You could have called me," said Thea. "I'm findable."

"I had my phone in my hand more than a few Thursdays, and I put it down every time." Leona's voice stayed level and got lower. "If I called you, I'd have lost the car."

Thea let that stand and did not tell her it was all right. The snow ticked on the Subaru's roof behind her.

"I won't forgive you today," she said.

"I'm not asking you to."

“I know. I’m telling you the date, so you don’t have to wonder.”

Leona unfolded her arms and put her hands in her fleece. “I’ll be at the Table in January, in my chair. I’ve needed it since the March after Rafael, and I’m keeping it.” She looked at Nolan, once, all the way. “What he just said. It’s the right list. I’ll keep my end of it without being asked.”

She went back to the Forester and rested a hand on the open door.

“Goodbye, Nolan,” Leona said.

“Goodbye.” His mouth made an *H*. It opened on the letter, then closed, and he started over from the beginning. “Goodbye, Leona.”

She gave one small, tired dip of the head, and got in and pulled the door shut. The Forester’s headlights came on. It backed out of the space in a long clean arc and went straight to the mouth of the lot, where its brake lights held a second for the street.

Thea did not look at Nolan. She looked at the place where the car had been, a rectangle of dry asphalt already filling with white.

The Forester’s taillights turned onto Fifth and were gone. His keys stayed in his fist. The CR-V stayed dark.

“You said ‘my wife,’” Thea said, to the empty rectangle.

“I did.” He did not look at her either. “Was that wrong?”

“I don’t know yet.” The snow went on coming down between them through the lamp. “It wasn’t a lie. I checked.”

Chapter 24 — The Binder, Again

Dimitra tore a strip of blue painter's tape off the roll with her teeth and slapped it across the corner of the sign.

The sign was a sheet of the good cream stock, and in Dimitra's square capitals it said MORAVEC EVENTS IS CLOSED UNTIL MONDAY, JANUARY 4. FOR EMERGENCIES, SEE BELOW. Below that there was nothing.

"There's no below," Thea said.

"That's the emergency part." Dimitra pressed the tape flat with her thumb. "If you have an emergency at a wedding planner's on Christmas Eve, you called the wrong person."

It was twenty to nine. Frost had grown up the inside corners of the studio windows, and downstairs, in the window she passed every morning, Mrs. Haskell's pyramid of snow shovels wore a red bow nobody had asked for. The couch was folded back to its green velvet self; the blanket folded in thirds on the cushion like an exhibit.

"The phones," Thea said.

"Forwarded to mine, ringer off, voicemail updated."

"The walk-through for Tess and Will is the ninth, boathouse, ten o'clock, and both their mothers will call about the cake."

"I know all of it. It's in my phone and my planner and my body." Dimitra stepped off the stool and looked at her. She was in the parka again, the pom-pom hat stuffed in the pocket where she thought nobody could see it. "I'm going to my aunt's in Toledo. Forty cousins and a lamb. Somebody will hand me a peeler within ten minutes of the door, and I'll be fine."

"Everyone keeps handing people peelers."

"It's the season," Dimitra said. She pulled the lamp's plug out of the wall and wound the cord around her fist, then stood with the lamp in her other hand and read the sign again, out loud and slowly. "Closed until Monday, January four."

Her voice went at *four*. She turned her face to the window and rubbed at it with the back of her wrist.

"It's the dust," she said.

"Of course it's the dust."

"Haskell never sweeps that landing."

Thea went to the go-bag by the couch, unzipped the side pocket, and held the sleeve of saltines out across the desk. "Eat a cracker."

Dimitra stared at the sleeve. Then she laughed, a wet laugh that cracked in two places, and took the sleeve and ate one with great dignity, looking at the ceiling.

“That’s stale.”

“It’s older than the boathouse.”

“It’s a crime,” Dimitra said, and ate another. “Good,” she said thickly, to no one.

The bag sat open at Thea’s feet, with the tape and the pins and the sewing kit on top, then four safety razors, two spare pairs of reading glasses, the steel ruler, and a spare white shirt folded flat underneath. She had carried it into every room for ten years and had never once walked out of a building without it on her shoulder.

“Are you taking that?” Dimitra said, pointing at it with the lamp.

“No.”

“There’s a lot of nosebleed in that bag.”

“Then somebody will have a nosebleed.”

“You’ll be at a table of Moravacs on Christmas Eve with no gaffer tape.”

“There’s a roll in the supply closet,” Thea said, zipping the bag. “And Margit has a junk drawer, which is very good.”

“What are you taking?”

“Keys, phone,” Thea said, patting her pockets.

“Charger.”

“No.”

Dimitra looked at her for a long second. Then she carried the bag by its strap into the supply closet and set it on the shelf above the case of white gaffer tape, handle turned out so it would be easy to pick up.

“I’ll keep it dry,” she said, and shut the door.

• • •

Odessa’s van was double-parked in front of Margit’s house with its hazards on, WYNN & TABLE down the side in curly green letters and a plastic wreath on the grille.

Odessa herself was on the porch in a hairnet and a parka, kneeling over a foil hotel pan with a second pan inverted on top of it for a lid. She set a red brick from the edge of Margit’s flower bed on the lid and tapped it down with two fingers, as if it had opinions.

“Don’t look at me,” she said without turning around. “I’m not here.”

“You’re standing on her porch.”

“I’m leaving a thing, and it isn’t a dish, it’s a delivery.” The Sharpie came out of her sleeve, cap in her teeth, and she wrote on a square of masking tape, pressed it onto the foil, and sat back on her heels. “She said bring nothing, so this is what nothing looks like when I do it.”

“She said if I brought a dish she’d put it in the yard.”

“You’re not bringing it, I’m leaving it. Different verb.” Odessa stood, and her knees cracked like walnuts. “Eight hens, same as last time, before you ask. I’m not superstitious, I’m a caterer. They’re glazed and cold and good cold. They were built for being ignored.”

Thea read the tape, block capitals with the last word underlined twice: DO NOT PLAN ANYTHING. EAT. “She told me to tell you there’s a chair for you.”

“Did she say it with enthusiasm?”

“She said she didn’t.”

“Good, I couldn’t take enthusiasm.” Odessa folded her arms inside the parka. “I have my husband’s mother tonight. Seven fishes and a lecture. Next year I’ll sit in that kitchen and be rude about the ham, but this year I’m a delivery.”

“The raccoons will get them.”

“The raccoons on this street are Hungarian. They’ll wait for the invitation.” She looked Thea over from the hair down, quick and not kind. “You eating?”

“A lemon bar.”

“Standing up?”

Thea studied the brick.

“That’s a yes,” Odessa said, and gripped her upper arm once, hard, as if testing a rope, and let go. “Go in there and sit down. Somebody hands you a plate, you hold the plate. I didn’t say a wise thing. If I said a wise thing, hit me.”

“Later.”

“Fine, later.” She went down the steps with her keys already out and turned at the van door. “And Thea, do not straighten my tray.”

The van pulled away with its hazards still blinking, and Thea listened to it all the way to the corner. The pan sat under its brick with the note facing the street, a hair off true with the edge of the mat, and her hand went toward it

before she knew it was going. She squared it to the mat. Then she nudged one corner crooked with her boot and rang the bell.

Nobody rang the bell at Margit's. The key sat on her ring, one of a hundred small copper-colored teeth. The door opened on the chain, then not, and Isla stood there in her goalkeeper hoodie and one wool sock, hair in a knot, holding half a piece of toast.

"She said four," said Isla.

"It's not four."

"She's at the store. Bread, pickles, and whatever she's calling a ham." Isla looked past her at the porch. "Is that Odessa's?"

"That's nobody's, it's a delivery."

"It looks like hens."

"It's nobody's hens." Thea stepped in, wiping her boots on the mat. From the cellar came a steady tapping, Jonas's hammer, a boy at work on something he would not explain. "I won't stay."

The kitchen had its Christmas Eve face on, the table bare, the oilcloth wiped, a clean white dish towel folded over the oven door handle. Nothing smelled of anything yet. At the corner, where it had sat for five weeks, the navy binder lay closed under a casserole lid and a mug.

Thea lifted the mug, leaving a pale ring on the vinyl, and then the lid.

"Don't," Isla said.

"I'm not doing anything with it."

"You're going to give me a talk. You've got a talk face."

"I'm giving you the binder."

Isla finished the toast slowly and wiped her hand on the hoodie. "It's heavy. You carried it in like an apology."

"It isn't yours. It's the family's. It lives on the counter, not in your room, and anybody can write in it. Your grandmother has a pencil. And it isn't for tonight."

"I don't want it."

"Okay."

"Don't say okay like that."

"Like what?"

"Like Grandma." Isla looked at the binder as she would look at a ball coming in low and fast from the left. Then she pulled it across the oilcloth with two fingers, flipped it open to a tab at random, and read in her handout voice:

"N: *garage, twenty minutes. Let him.*" Her finger stopped under it. "Why is this in pencil?"

"So I can change it. That one's from about eight years ago."

"He sat on the floor with Jonas for twenty-two minutes. I timed it."

"I know, I was there."

"You should cross it out. It's wrong now."

"No, it was right then. I won't touch anything in it." Thea kept her hands in her coat pockets. "It's all in pencil, Isla. Every page of it, wrong in places. Anybody who finds a wrong thing gets to fix it. Not just you."

Isla shut the cover and stood with her palm on the navy vinyl. Then, without a word, she hauled the binder up against her chest with both arms and her chin on the top edge, her sock-foot turned in, and rocked once. It was a small movement, and she plainly did not know she had made it.

"Tab two is Grandma's pills," Thea said, and heard it, and stopped. "Sorry."

"I know where it is." Isla was looking at the casserole lid. "I've been reading it at night. I was going to give it back and I didn't."

"You don't have to explain."

"I'm not." The binder shifted in her arms. "You're coming at four, without a dish."

"At four, without a dish."

"Then what are you for?"

"A chair," said Thea. "I'm told it's a very good one."

"Grandma says that to me when I'm bleeding on something," Isla said.

In the cellar the hammer stopped, and neither of them spoke until it started again. Thea went down the hall toward the door.

"Take the end chair," Isla called after her. "It's the one that doesn't wobble. Grandma checked."

Part Five — The Staying

I'll stay in the room.

Chapter 25 — Christmas Eve

At four o'clock by the stove clock the oven gave three clicks and a sigh and went out, and the smell of hot dust stopped coming off the vent.

"That's the thing it does," Nolan said from the floor.

He had the bottom drawer out and the floor panel off and a flashlight in his teeth, and the top half of him was inside the stove. From the end chair Thea had a view of corduroy legs and two gray wool socks, one with a hole at the heel. At ten to four he had said "Hi" and she had said "Hi," and Margit had told her to sit, and that was all the talking between them.

She sat with her hands flat under her thighs and her keys on the oilcloth beside her tea, fob out, nearest hand, having brought nothing else. In her own kitchen there would have been a roaster in the Subaru and Odessa on speed dial, and the Subaru had a parking pass in it.

"It is resting," said Margit.

She had the oven door down and was regarding the ham on its rack the way you regard a guest who has fainted at the table. It was a smoked ham, fourteen pounds, scored in diamonds with a clove in every diamond, the kind that only wants warming through, and Margit had warmed four hundred of them for the cafeteria Christmas lunch. Nolan had driven to the smokehouse in Zeeland for it on Tuesday, paid, and carried it in the back door himself. It was the one thing she had let him bring. It had gone in at half past one. Sometime after two the oven had quietly stopped trying, and nobody had heard it stop. Thea kept the arithmetic behind her teeth, along with the black pan in the bottom cabinet.

"That's what you said about the turkey," Isla said.

"The turkey was resting, and this is different."

"How exactly is it different?"

"The turkey was done. This one is still thinking about it."

Margit cut a slice from the thick end. The outside was hot and the glaze had caught, and the middle was as cold as the refrigerator it had come out of. On the piano bench by the back door Jonas leaned over to look, sawdust on both cuffs, and leaned back.

"It's a pig, Ma," said Nolan around the flashlight, "and it's cold."

"I can see what it is."

Isla had the binder open flat on the table, a pencil behind her ear, and read it in the flat voice. "'Oven failure. One, check breaker.'"

"It's not the breaker," said the stove.

"I did the breaker. 'Two, hold Cancel three seconds and restart,' and I did that twice. 'Three, do not open the door.'" She looked at the oven door, which was open, and said that one was late. "'Four, oven runs hot. N knows. If it quits, igniter.'" She stopped, and read it again. "It says N knows."

"I do know," said the stove.

"It's in the binder that you know."

The flashlight came out of his mouth. "It's the igniter. It glows, but it doesn't pull enough current to open the gas valve, and it's a forty-dollar part. Haskell's carries it, and Mrs. Haskell would open up if I asked in person, I could be there and back by—"

"No," said Margit, "you will not take Mrs. Haskell out of her house on Christmas Eve for a pig."

"Ma, it's twenty minutes. Then I'll go myself and leave the money on the counter."

"Nolan, up."

He came out backward on his elbows with the flashlight in his fist and a black streak down one cheek, and stayed sitting on the linoleum.

"Up," Margit said again, not louder. "Wash, and then sit."

"Five minutes, if I could just finish."

"Wash."

He got up and washed his hands and then his face at the sink and dried both on the towel from the oven door. He looked over six empty chairs and chose the one across from Isla, two down from Thea's, and sat in it with his hands in his lap and his eyes on the pickle jar.

Margit set a mug at his place. He looked at the color of it. "Is this supposed to be the coffee?"

"It is a menu," said Margit.

"'Five,'" Isla read, and her voice had gone thin. "'Gino's. On the twenty-fourth they close at three.'"

"It's four-oh-six," Jonas said from the bench, "so Gino's is closed."

"'Six. Odessa. She'll say no and then she'll come.'"

"Odessa has her husband's mother," said Thea. She had not meant to open her mouth; the sentence had gone ahead of her. "Sorry."

"'Seven.'" Isla's finger had stopped moving. "'Anything not covered, call T. Day or night. I mean it.'"

"You wrote 'I mean it,' in pencil," Isla said.

"I did."

The pencil came out from behind her ear and pointed at Thea across three feet of oilcloth, and shook. "You're right there and it would take one sentence. You'd have a ham in the black pan and a pizza from somewhere that doesn't close, and nobody would have to." Her face went wrong all at once, from the bottom up. "I did everything it said, all of it, and the last page is you."

"Isla," said Thea.

"Don't," Isla said, "don't you dare fix it."

"I'm not."

"Nobody asked you to read it," Margit said. "It is a book."

"Somebody has to!"

"No."

It was one word, set down like a cup. Isla stared at her grandmother, then shut the binder with both hands and put her forehead down on the navy vinyl and stayed there. Thea's right hand came out from under her and got as far as the edge of the table.

"Leave her," Margit said, without turning her head. "She is crying. Let her."

The hand went back under.

"Jonas," said Margit, "there is a pan on my porch with a brick on it. It has been there since this morning and I stepped over it with the groceries. Bring it in. Nobody carried it; it arrived."

"That's not a dish?" said Jonas.

"It is a hen. Go."

Jonas went down the hall at nearly a run, a boy glad of an errand, and the front door let in a long blade of cold. He came back with the pan in both arms, frost on the foil, and set it in front of his grandmother, reading the tape in pieces. "It says do not plan anything," he read, and turned his head. "Then it says 'Eat,' and that's underlined."

"Twice," said Isla, into the vinyl.

"Hm," said Margit, and lifted off the brick and then the top pan with its foil.

Eight of them, small and brown, tight in their skins, the apricot glaze gone to amber in the cold. Thea had last looked at eight like these on the studio desk, with a piece of one in a napkin in her fist.

"Margit, those are—"

"I know whose they are," said Margit, studying the foil. "I am surprised."

Isla lifted her head, her face a mess, and did nothing about it. “You said you wanted to be.”

“I did. Paper plates are above the refrigerator.”

Isla got down a sleeve of paper plates with a holly border, left from the altar guild’s Advent lunch, and dealt them round the table like cards. Margit sat in the corner chair next to Thea’s. Nolan tore a hen in half down the breastbone and put the larger half on his mother’s plate, and Margit let him.

“Are they cold on purpose?” said Isla.

“They were built for being ignored,” said Thea. “That’s what Odessa says.”

“She is a good woman,” said Margit, “who swears at poultry. Do not tell her I said it.”

“Can I have a leg?” said Jonas, and was told to take the leg.

Thea took a leg, cold, the glaze snapping under her teeth over rosemary and lemon, and ate it down to the bone and reached for another. Nobody in the kitchen looked.

“Too much lemon,” said Margit.

“It’s Odessa’s.”

“She puts lemon on everything. I will have a second,” and she took a second.

“These are good,” Nolan said to his plate, and Jonas said they were good, and Thea said very good.

“Good hens,” said Isla, in no voice at all.

Thea knew the register, low and even, having stood in it for four hours and ten minutes with a clipboard. She had never heard it come out of a kitchen.

Margit put down the bone and wiped her fingers on a paper napkin and stood up.

“Enough.”

Biscuit lifted his head from the hall doorway.

“Rules.” She laid both palms flat on the oilcloth. “One, nobody cooks: the stove is dead, let it be dead. Two, nobody fixes anything that is not bleeding. Three, nobody at this table says ‘fine.’”

“That’s Thea’s rule,” said Isla.

“Then it is a good one. I am taking it. Four, everybody sits.” She looked at Nolan, and at Jonas by the door that stuck, and at Nolan again for longer. “Nobody goes to the garage or under the table. Nobody goes to the car.” The eyes arrived at the end chair. “Nobody gets up to be useful.”

“What about the dog?” said Isla.

“The dog is a beagle, so he is exempt.”

Nolan took his keys from his pocket and set them down in the middle of the oilcloth, between the pickle jar and the rye, without looking at anyone. After a moment Thea set hers next to his.

“I did not ask for that,” said Margit.

“No,” said Nolan.

“Leave them,” said Margit, straightening. “And Isla has a letter to mail.” Isla’s head came up. “Grandma.”

“For weeks I have watched you carry it around this house, and I am sixty-eight and have run out of waiting. This table is the mailbox.”

“I’m not ready yet.”

“Nobody is. Mail it.”

Isla stood the way she came off her line, all at once, so that the chair rocked on two legs and settled. She took four folded pages from her back pocket, looked at her grandmother, and laid them on top of the binder.

“I wrote it, but I can’t read it. If I read it I’ll get to the end and still not have said it.” She gripped the back of her chair. “Uncle Nolan.”

“Isla—”

Margit’s hand came up off the table, palm out. “To the end of the sentence.”

Then Margit sat, and her left hand went down into her lap, open, and stayed there. Thea knew what the hand was for. She took the square of cotton she had checked three times in the car from her pocket and passed it under the edge of the table, and the small dry fingers closed on it.

“I saw you crying in your car outside school,” Isla said. “Twice. I went around the long way. I’m not telling you so you’ll feel bad. I’m telling you so it isn’t just me who knows.”

Across from her Nolan did not move. His mouth started on the short word and the word did not come.

“I didn’t see you,” he said, in a scrape of a voice.

“I know.” Isla turned to her grandmother. “On Thursdays you stand at that window.” She pointed at it, black now, with the lit kitchen laid over the dark. “At six, with the light off, you watch the driveway. I come down for water and you say, Go to bed, it’s a school night, and you don’t turn around. Every Thursday, for years.”

Margit’s face did not move. The fist in her lap closed.

“I’m almost done,” Isla said, to no one. “And Dad.” The name went out into the kitchen and the kitchen heard it. “Nobody says his name at this table. I counted. Not at Thanksgiving or the concert, and not in Thea’s handout, which had a time for it. It’s been three years and two months. The only person who says it anywhere I can hear is me, in the shower.” Her voice cracked on *shower* and she kept going over the crack. “He’s dead, and we all sit here being fine at each other, and we’re so good at it. I’m so tired of being good at it.”

She wiped her face with her wrist, hard.

“That’s it. I’m done.” A wet, awful breath. “I’m crying. You can look.”

“I am looking,” said Margit.

The refrigerator hummed and in the cellar the furnace came on. The stove clock said 5:22, and then 5:23. Thea looked for the room as she looked for any room, for the doors and who was holding what, and found a kitchen with five people and a dog in it and nothing hers to pick up.

“Dad,” Jonas said.

He said it to his knees, so low the refrigerator nearly had it. The bench scraped half an inch toward the back door, and he stopped, and stayed. “Dad,” he said again, to the floor, and his voice broke in the middle the way a boy’s voice is allowed to.

“Callum,” said Margit.

She said it flat and clear, like an instruction to the room. Then she lifted the handkerchief to her mouth, as if the name had left something there, and held it, and took it away. The blue thread hung in its small loop between her fingers.

“Callum,” she said again. “My son. He was late to everything and loud in church, and he dropped the dish, and he is dead.” Her voice did not rise. It went on working, the way you carry a full pan across a floor. “I did not say it in front of you. Isla said it in the shower, by herself, because I did not. That is mine. Sit down now, child.”

Isla sat. “Okay,” she said, and her chair took her weight like something she had been owed.

Nolan had both hands flat on the oilcloth as if the table might leave. It climbed up out of his chest, and she knew the word before it got there, and his mouth made the shape of *I’m*, and he let it go by. What came instead was a sound she had heard once before, from the front of a boathouse, through a microphone, though that one had gone down to the floor in a whisper, to a name nobody could see. This one went up. He did not bend or cover his face.

He sat in his mother's kitchen with it turned up to the light and cried out loud with his eyes open.

His heels came up off the linoleum and came down. Biscuit crossed the kitchen from the doorway and lay down on Nolan's feet.

Nobody moved to fix it and nobody said it was all right. She had given him eight seconds, once, and laminated it. The stove clock went from 5:26 to 5:29, and nobody touched him.

Thea half rose, her hands out from under her without being told.

"Margit."

Margit's eyes found her over the table. "I gave you a chair."

Thea sat.

Margit got up and came around the corner of the table, past the hens and the keys, and stood behind her son's chair and put both palms on his head, one over the other, as you test a boy of six for fever. "Jól van, Nólíka," she said. "Here. Stay here."

Isla came around the table and put her forehead against his shoulder. Jonas slid off the bench and stood against the back of Margit's cardigan, and she let him lean there without turning round.

It was 5:32 by the stove clock when it ran down, and nobody had hurried it.

"Now I say what is decided," Margit said, over Nolan's head. "This is not a vote."

"It never is," said Isla, into his sleeve.

"Tomorrow at sunrise, at Dunmore Point. Not the twenty-seventh. Tomorrow." She looked at Isla. "I telephoned your mother this morning, myself, from this kitchen. I said, Dara, he goes in the lake at home, and you are welcome to stand on the beach in the summer and say what you want to him. She cried, and then she said yes. She said it is ours."

Isla's mouth opened and shut.

"Is it even allowed?" said Jonas. "Like, legally."

Thea looked at the oilcloth. She had the answer, and it was the one useful line on eleven pages of paper in a blue bin.

"The township says ashes are fine," she said. "Nothing left in the water. No urn, nothing that floats away."

Margit considered her. "That is a fact," she said. "Facts you may keep. Thank you."

"Is there a program, and who talks?" said Isla.

"There is a lake. Whoever has something talks, and nobody has to."

"It's frozen," Jonas said.

"Then it is frozen. I have stood on worse."

"Does Biscuit come?" said Isla.

"The dog comes, because he is a Moravec."

Isla wanted to know what time the sun came up, and Jonas got out his phone and read it. "Eight-oh-nine."

Thea's mouth opened with a call time in it, and she closed it.

"Nolan carries him." Margit's palms did not move from his head, and she looked at the children. "Your father."

"Where is he?" said Jonas.

"Alder Street," said Thea, "in the closet, on the top shelf."

"I know which shelf," said Nolan, from under his mother's hands. "I get dressed under it."

"Then in the morning Nolan goes into his own closet and takes him down. He has not touched him in three years. He will carry him out of the house in his two hands to the water, and nobody will carry him for him."

"Ma," said Nolan, from a long way down.

"In your two hands."

"Okay."

"Okay." Margit's eyes went down the table to the end chair. "Thea."

"Yes."

"You do not plan one thing. Not a time, not a program, not a speech. Wear boots; that is not a plan, that is December. You come, and you stand where you stand. If you bring a dish I will put it in the lake."

"Nothing," said Thea.

"I made a thing in the cellar," Jonas said into Margit's cardigan. "It's not done."

"Do not ask," said Margit. "I have decided I like surprises. Finish it tonight, and quietly." She looked down at the top of her elder son's head. "I had a speech for you, Nolika. Three years it grew. It was a very good speech. I have lost it." She took her hands away. "Eat."

She went round the table, set a paper plate with a hen's leg on it at his elbow, and went back to her chair.

"It's cold," said Nolan, in a wrecked voice.

"It is a hen," said Margit. "Eat."

"What about the ham?" said Jonas.

“It can go on thinking.”

At the end of the table Thea took her hands out from under her thighs, one and then the other.

They lay in her lap, palms up, red from the edge of the seat. Nothing in either.

Chapter 26 — The Pulpit

Thea had worn the wrong boots.

They were black leather work boots with a quarter inch of tread, bought for loading docks and hotel carpet, and she stood in snow over the laces at the end of the Dunmore Point road. Margit had said boots, and these were boots. At five that morning she had stood in the studio supply closet with her hand on the shelf where the wool hats lived, and then she had taken the hand away, because a hat had felt like a plan.

Nobody had plowed, and the road ended in a white field with two sets of tire tracks pressed into it, and the gray CR-V sat at the end of them with its tailgate up, Margit's car behind it with the parking lights on. The sky over the lake was the color of dishwater going pink at the bottom edge.

Nolan stood at the tailgate in his gray coat, arms down.

"You came," he said.

"I was told to stand where I stand."

"Where's that?"

"Here, apparently."

On the back seat, belted in at the shoulder, sat the pale pine box with the brass hasp. The belt crossed it diagonally, like a child's.

"I put the belt on him," Nolan said. "Then I thought it was ridiculous, and then I left it."

"It's a long road."

"It's a very long road." He leaned in and undid the buckle. His hands were bare and red. "I sat under the shelf this morning. I didn't know a person could sit under something for forty minutes."

"Is he heavy?"

"Seven pounds." He straightened with the box against his chest, remembered, and held it level, a hand under each end, the way you carry a tray through a crowd. "It's not seven pounds."

"No," said Thea.

Car doors opened behind them. Margit got out in a camel coat to her shins, a head scarf knotted under the chin and Josef's black rubber galoshes, with a thermos under one arm. Isla came out with the green leash wound twice round her fist, and Biscuit leaped past her into the snow and vanished to the ears. Jonas came last, carrying something the size of a loaf in a dish towel.

"It's the good coffee," Margit told Thea. "I am not angry with anybody."

"Okay."

“I am only saying.” She set the thermos on the hood of the CR-V, looked at it, and left it there.

Isla looked at Thea’s head, then at her boots, and said nothing, which in Isla was a paragraph.

“Don’t,” said Thea.

“I didn’t say anything.”

“Don’t help.”

“I’m not helping, I’m standing here.”

The path down to the beach was a trench of old footprints under new snow. Jonas went first with the towel held level, Isla and the dog after, Nolan behind with his eyes on the box and his feet finding the trench by themselves. Margit stopped at the top of the bank, looked down at the stones, and put her hand through Thea’s elbow without turning her head.

“I am old,” she said, “and the stones are ice.”

“I know.”

“Do not hold me up. I only want to be next to something.”

They went down at Margit’s pace. Thea’s boots went out from under her once, and the hand in her elbow tightened, and neither of them said which of them had done the holding.

Dunmore Point was a hook of gravel that curled back on itself, so that its inside beach faced east across Dunmore Bay, the only place in the county where you could watch the sun come up out of water. It was a crescent of gray stones with a shelf of shore ice along the waterline, and past the ice the lake lay black and open, smoking in slow columns that leaned and came apart. Gulls stood on the shelf with their feathers puffed, watching the family come.

Thea’s eye did what it did. It measured the thin edge of the ice and the sixty yards of open beach to the cars, then found the flat rock at the water’s edge and went no further.

The rock was a slab of gray granite, waist high and glazed on top, its far end running out under the water. Callum had stood on it every summer to give the sermon whenever the perch quit biting.

“The pulpit,” Jonas said, to no one.

“Is it safe?” said Isla.

“It’s a rock.”

“It has ice on it.”

“Stand with your back to the shore,” Nolan said. “Wind’s light off the land. Anything that goes up, you want it going out over the water.”

Isla turned her head slowly. “Uncle Nolan, did you just plan something?”

“It’s physics.”

“It’s a plan.”

“It is a lake,” said Margit. “Not a laboratory.”

“It’s a little of both,” said Nolan, and his voice broke on *both*.

He took the last three steps and set the box on the flat of the rock the way you put down a sleeping child. His hands stayed cupped in the air a moment too long. He put them in his pockets and found the whistle.

Margit let go of Thea’s arm and walked to the rock on her own, in her husband’s galoshes. She stood at the box without touching it, hands together at her waist, and for a while there was only the small hiss of the lake smoking.

“Áldjon meg téged az Úr,” she said, “és őrizzen meg téged.”

It was the accent of a kitchen in Szeged that Thea had never seen, like something said over a thousand tables and a few beds.

“It’s ’bless you and keep you,” Jonas whispered to Thea. “Grandpa’s mother said it over Dad when he was a baby. I asked last night.”

“I didn’t know that.”

“Nobody did.”

“Nyugodj békében, fiam.” Margit’s voice stayed level through the first half and then it didn’t, and she stood in it. “Rest in peace, my son. That is all I have. It is not a speech.”

“It’s good, Grandma,” said Isla.

“It is short, and that is the best I can say for it.” She stepped back and laid her palm between Jonas’s shoulder blades. “Jonas.”

Jonas gave Isla the towel and put both hands on the hasp. The brass was frozen, so he breathed on it twice, and it opened with a small dry click.

Inside was a heavy clear bag, twist-tied, gray and a little paler than gravel. Nolan made a sound, and Jonas looked at him.

“Is it okay?”

“Yes,” said Nolan, and nodded. “Go ahead.”

Jonas undid the tie and put his hand in without looking, as he would have into a bag of nails. Half the handful went onto the granite before he reached the end of the rock, where the stone ran under the water, and he stood there with the steam round his knees.

“Hey, Dad, it’s me, and I’m in eighth grade. Uncle Nolan does Tuesdays, but he orders pepperoni, which is a coward’s pizza, so you’d be mad.” He

tipped his hand, and the gray lay on the black water in a pale skin before the lake took it down. "I made you a thing, but it's not very good."

Isla handed him the towel. Under it was a small wooden boat, flat-bottomed, with a dowel mast and a sail cut from a paint-stirring stick, a rough C and M burned into the stern. Sawdust was still in the grain. A spool of red kite string was tied off to a screw eye in the bow.

"It's supposed to be a boat," said Jonas. "It looks like a loaf of bread."

"It looks like a loaf of bread," said Isla, and her laugh came out wet and furious and went into her sleeve.

"He'd eat off it."

"He'd eat off the lid."

"It doesn't have a lid."

"He would *make* it one," said Margit. "Put it in."

"Nothing left in the water," Jonas said, to Thea, and held up the spool. "I heard you."

He knelt on the granite and lowered the boat to the water with both hands flat, and let it go out on the string. It rode the steam as if it had always lived there, and turned in a slow half circle at the end of its red line.

Isla took the second handful fast, like pulling a bandage, and stood on the end of the rock with her chin up.

"Hi, Dad. I said your name in the shower for three years, and now I'm saying it outside." She opened her fingers. "I'm still in goal, and I'm keeping the gloves. Grandma said your name last night and she's going to keep saying it, I'm going to make her."

"I will," said Margit.

"And I'm okay," she said. "Like, a five out of ten. Which is up."

She came back off the rock and wiped her eyes with her whole mitten. Biscuit returned from the drifts and sat on her foot.

Nolan walked to the pulpit and stood with his hands on its edge, either side of the open box, looking at the gray in the bag. His mouth stayed open some time before anything came out.

"Cal," he said. It came out hoarse and ordinary.

"I stood in that line four hours and told two hundred people I was fine. You'd have told me to sit down. You'd have told me I looked like a lamp." He laughed, one bark, and it went wrong in the middle. "Instead of sitting I went to a church basement every Thursday for three years and told strangers about you. I told a woman in a car what you'd have done to the urn. And I didn't tell

Ma or your kids or Thea, and they were the ones who'd have laughed in the right places. You were the young one. I'm the old one, so I was supposed to go first. That was the deal. I'm sorry I left you to be the one who was supposed to go first." His shoulders had started to go. "I'm sorry I'm standing on your rock and you're in a bag, and I couldn't touch you. Thea kept you in a closet for me, and I got dressed under you every morning and never put my hand up."

His head went down and he cried the way he had in the kitchen, aloud, with his eyes open, his whole big frame turned to the water. Margit made no move, and Isla put her fist to her mouth.

Thea crossed the gravel, though no one had asked and she had not decided to. She went to the rock, stopped beside him, and took his hand off the granite.

It was freezing, and it closed on hers hard enough to grind the bones, and she did not take it back.

"Callum," she said, and it came out in her work voice, and she let it.

"It's Clipboard." Isla made a small sound behind her. "I should have said this in the hospital hallway. I wrote an obituary instead." She looked at the black water. "The lawn chair picture is on a drive in my studio, and I'm having it printed, big, for your mother's kitchen. I ran your funeral so I wouldn't have to be at it." Nolan's hand pressed hers.

"I miss you. You were the only one at that table who made me put down the schedule. So I'm just standing here."

For a minute the only sounds were the gulls and the tick of Biscuit's collar tag against the leash buckle.

"Good," said Margit.

She had come up to the rock without a sound and stood a yard off in her galoshes and scarf, looking at their two hands.

"Now you two owe us an old promise."

Nolan lifted his face and said, "Ma."

"You started it in front of ninety people and a microphone, so the back row could hear." Her eyes cut to Thea with something close to a gleam. "Finish it here, in front of your family and a dog, and not in some room."

"I don't know if she wants—"

"Ask her."

He turned, eyes swollen nearly shut, nose running, and did not wipe it.

"Thea."

"Say them," she said.

Isla and Jonas stepped closer without being told, the way you step toward a stove.

"I'll tell you the truth, even the small ones." He swallowed. "Small one: I can't feel my feet."

"Neither can I," said Thea.

Jonas made a noise that was a snort and a sob together. "Those are *terrible* boots," he told her, hoarsely.

"I know."

"I'll listen to the end of the sentence," Nolan said, steadier now. "I still have eleven things I didn't say in that hour. They'll keep."

"Go on."

"I'll show up, even when it isn't my turn." He glanced at Jonas. "Even with the wrong clarinet."

Isla coughed into her mitten.

His hand tightened on hers. "I'll let you carry me," he said, and stopped. The breath went out of him white. "And I'll—" He shook his head. "I can say the words, but I haven't earned that one. I carried a box fifty feet. That's not carrying. Ask me in ten years."

"Ask me in ten," said Thea.

It was out before she thought, and it sat there in the cold, plain as a coat on a hook. His face broke open, and the smile it made was lopsided and mostly tears.

"I'll stay in the room," he said, and looked at the gray in the box. "I'm still here."

"You are."

She had one more, and she did not know it until her mouth opened. She did not look at the lake. She said it a foot from his face.

"I'll ask how you are," said Thea, "and I'll wait for the real answer, even when it's bad, even when I can't fix it. That one's mine." She held his eyes. "The Thursdays are still yours. I'm not taking those."

"I know," said Nolan. "I wouldn't let you."

Nobody applauded. Margit let out a long white breath.

"Good," she said. "That is done now. Jonas, the rest."

Jonas looked at the bag, then at Nolan, who still held Thea's hand with his left and put out his right, and the two of them took the bag between them. They carried it to the end of the rock, Nolan stooping, Jonas on tiptoe, and turned it over.

The gray went out in one long pour, and the steam took it, and for a breath you could not tell where the one ended. Then there was only the lake, black and open in front of the light.

Jonas held the empty bag in his two fists. "That's all of him."

"That's all," said Nolan.

"I thought it would take longer."

"So did I."

Isla came across the gravel with her scarf already off. It was long gray wool with a pulled thread at one end, still warm from her neck. She wound it twice around Thea's head and throat without asking and tucked the ends into her collar, hard.

"You're blue," she said.

"I didn't bring a hat because I didn't plan anything. I was told."

"It's a scarf, and nobody planned it." Isla stepped back and checked her work. "Now you look like a Moravec."

"Is that good?"

"It means you've got a scarf."

The little boat had drifted out to the end of its red string, as far as the first open water, and turned its stern to them. The glow behind the steam went gold at the bottom, then white, a seam opening along the far edge of the lake, and everyone on the beach turned toward it, even the dog.

The sun cleared the water all at once. Jonas said "Ow," put a hand over his eyes, and Margit said it served him right.

Then he wound the boat in, hand over hand, and lifted it out dripping and held it against his coat. Nobody had told him to.

Chapter 27 — Come In

“Take it,” Margit said, and pushed the thermos into Nolan’s chest. “I am not carrying home coffee nobody drank.”

They were at the road end again. Jonas was already in Margit’s back seat with the dish towel across his knees, and Isla studied Thea’s boots with great restraint.

“Ma, it’s yours, you made it for the lake.”

“It is the good coffee. It goes to the house of whoever needs it.” Margit looked at his bare hands, then at Thea’s feet, and her mouth went flat. “Both of you go home. Put on the heat. Drive slow, and eat something. I am feeding nobody today. I have a ham that needs to be spoken to.”

“We came separately,” said Thea.

“I saw. Like two Lutherans.” Margit opened her car door and stopped with one galosh on the sill. “Sunday I fry the skins. The black pan wants fat and a Sunday. You will eat the first one, Thea.”

“Yes,” said Thea, and waited for the rest.

Jonas leaned across his sister with the boat in his lap, still wet, the red string wound round the mast. “I’m putting it on the shelf over my bed,” he said. “The top one.”

Nobody said anything for a second.

“Not with a label,” said Isla.

“With a label,” said Jonas. “It says BOAT.”

“In the spring we’ll bring it back out here,” said Nolan. “Some Tuesday. If your grandmother says I can drive.”

“She’ll say,” said Margit, “when she says.”

Isla rolled her window down an inch. “Don’t lose the scarf,” she said, and rolled it up.

Biscuit would not get into Margit’s car. He looked at the three vehicles in turn and sat at the Subaru’s back door until Thea opened it, then climbed onto the seat where the go-bag usually rode.

“He picked,” said Nolan.

“He always picks.”

She drove with the heater blowing on her feet and got nothing from it. At the light on Lakeshore her blinker was going left, toward the studio, and it ticked until the light changed and she went straight.

Behind her the gray CR-V came through on the yellow. At Alder Street it signaled right, a half second after she did.

• • •

The porch light was on, as it had been for six weeks, yellow against the daylight. Thea had her key out before the engine stopped ticking. Biscuit shouldered the door open ahead of her and was gone down the hall, and the house breathed out at her, cold radiators and old coffee, with the dog underneath.

Nolan had stopped on the bottom step with the thermos in one hand and the empty box in the other.

"It's fourteen degrees," she said from the top step. "You can come up."

"Can I come in?"

"It's your house."

"It's our house. I mean the room, wherever you're standing." He shifted the box. His eyes were raw, a whole lake still on his face. "I don't want to walk into it just because I've got a key."

"The room," said Thea.

"I don't know how to say it better. Everything I said in that car for three years, I said the easy way."

Thea looked for a procedure. She had one for every threshold in the county, and when she went through the shelf it was empty.

Biscuit came trotting back down the hall with a black sock in his mouth, one of Nolan's, the toe chewed to lace. He sat on the mat between them and presented it.

"That's mine," said Nolan. "He's working through the drawer."

She took the sock from the dog, looked at it, and handed it back. "Keep it," she told him, and then, to the step: "Come in. You can stay in the room."

"For how long?"

"Don't push your luck."

"Right."

He came up the three steps and wiped his boots on the mat, left and right, and then again, as if the mat were what he was being tested on.

• • •

In the kitchen she sat in Isla's chair at the end of the table and found she could not undo her laces. They had frozen into black wire, and her fingers were white to the second joint.

Nolan said, “Hang on,” set the box on the counter as carefully as if it were full, and turned the thermostat to sixty-eight before he crouched on the linoleum in front of her.

“Sixty-eight,” said Thea. “You had it at sixty-two.”

“I leave it at sixty-two. In case you wanted to turn it up yourself.”

“It’s very cold in here. Can I?”

“They’re frozen.”

“I know, I teach this unit.” He worked the first knot with both thumbs, his hair full of snow that had gone to water. “Don’t rub them. Warm, not hot.”

“I know that.”

“I know you know. I’m saying it so I’m doing something.”

The boot came away with a wet suck. The toes inside were pale and stiff, and the rest of the foot had gone an angry red, cold as a can out of a cooler. He filled the speckled canning pot at the tap and tested it on his wrist twice before he set it on the floor.

“It’s lukewarm and it’s going to feel like a lie,” he said. “Put them in.”

She did, and it was only lukewarm and burned like fire, and she sucked air through her teeth while his hands closed around her ankles under the water, warm and perfectly still.

“Does it hurt?”

“Yes.”

“Good. It means they’re coming back.” He did not look up. “If they don’t pink up in twenty minutes, or anything blisters, we’re driving to urgent care in Holland, Christmas or no Christmas. That’s not a plan. That’s toes.”

“That’s what you say to the sophomores.”

“It’s what I say to the sophomores.”

“Tell me a small one,” she said.

“My knees hurt. I knelt on a rock.”

“Another.”

“At midnight I stood in the garage door and didn’t go in.” His thumbs moved once on her ankle bones. “Your turn.”

“At five this morning I stood in the closet at the studio with my hand on the hats. I wanted one so badly.”

“That’s not small.”

“It’s wool.”

He pressed one toenail with his thumb and watched the color come back under it, slow and then all at once, and did the next, and the next.

“Pink,” he said. “Fourteen minutes. You get to keep all ten.”

Her eye went round the kitchen for the exits and could not think what she wanted them for.

He did not look up. The crooked part in his hair showed, and a place on his neck where he had missed shaving. Ten years, and she had never once had him kneel to anything.

“Nolan,” she said, and he looked up. His face was a ruin, and it was looking at her.

“You look—” he began, grinning.

“If you say the first time, I’m putting my feet through this pot.”

“Wet,” he said. “I was going to say wet.”

She laughed, loud and short, and he was smiling at her with his whole raw face, and the smile wobbled, and she put her hand on his jaw, where the stubble was cold, and his eyes shut.

She leaned down out of the chair, a short way, and took her time over it. His mouth was cold at the corners and warm inside, and it tasted of salt. He held still, giving her room to stop, and she did not take it. Isla’s scarf slid off her head, and its pulled thread caught on his coat zipper and tugged them an inch closer than planned. He made a sound against her mouth that was almost a laugh.

“Hold on, you’re attached.”

“Leave it.”

He kissed her slowly, checking each time, and each time she answered he stopped checking. His wet hand found the back of her head and went into her hair, careful and then not careful, while she wound her fist in his coat. Her heel hit the pot and it went over, and neither of them looked. The radiator began to tick as it caught.

When they came apart she kept her forehead against his. He was breathing hard, as if he had run the trench path twice.

“Don’t ask what it means,” said Thea.

“I wasn’t going to.”

“You had your mouth open.”

“I was going to ask if you wanted tea.”

“Not yet,” said Thea, and kept her forehead where it was.

“Okay,” said Nolan, and did not move either.

“I’m still angry,” said Thea. “It didn’t go because I did that.”

“I know.”

“It’s in the room with us. I’m not pretending it stepped out.”

“I’d be worried if it had. Where’s it sitting?”

“On the counter, next to the box.”

He looked. “Hi,” he said to the counter.

His wet, warm hand had found her ankle again. She looked at the top of his head.

His thumb stopped on the bone.

“I’ve said sorry in the lot,” he said, to her ankle. “At the Circle, in your studio, on a rock. I’ve never asked you anything. I’m asking now, and you can say no, or not yet, and I’ll still be kneeling in this water.” He looked up. “Will you forgive me?”

“Not all at once.”

“No.” He nodded, to the floor. “Okay.”

“In pieces, and I’ll tell you which one. This is the first.”

“What’s the piece?”

“That you asked.”

He did not say thank you. Water from his hair ran down the side of his nose and he let it.

“The pot’s on its side,” she said.

“Yes.”

“The water’s all over the floor.”

“Yes, I’m kneeling in it.”

“Leave it,” she said, and did not take it back.

• • •

She stood up on feet that rang like struck bells and took his sleeve, not his hand, because the hand was wet and she wanted the cloth. He came up off his knees and followed her.

The hall was cold, and through the open bedroom door the closet stood a hand’s width ajar. On the top shelf was a clean rectangle in the dust and a strip of label tape that said C.M. — HOLD. She looked at it for the length of one step and went on.

At the bedroom door Nolan stopped with his palm against the frame.

“Thea.”

“I know.”

“Tell me, because I’m not guessing at this one.”

“There’s no plan,” said Thea.

“How do I know that?”

“I’d have laminated it. Come in.”

He came in, and Biscuit, who had come in with them, was already climbing onto her side of the bed with the sock.

“Out,” said Thea. “Hall. You can keep the sock.”

“He’s been on your side since the eighth.”

“He can have it Monday.”

Biscuit looked at her, then at Nolan, who held up both hands. He went out as if the decision had been his, and Thea shut the door and stood with her palm flat on the wood.

Beyond it, Biscuit’s nails circled three times. Then a long groan, and a chin settling against the door.

Chapter 28 — The Back Row

The runner was two inches off true, and Thea was on her knees in a navy wool dress fixing it.

“You are a guest,” Dimitra said from above her. “It’s on the run-of-show, line one: ‘Thea, guest.’ I laminated it.”

“Two inches.”

“Tess’s grandfather has a walker with tennis balls on the feet, and the tennis balls do not care.”

“I care about all of it.” Thea walked the canvas back to the chalk line, pinched it flat, and sat on her heels. Thirty-six chairs stood in nine rows of two a side, squared with the steel ruler, and beyond them the boathouse windows were full of lake, white to the horizon with one dark seam where the wind had it open. “There, now I’m a guest.”

“Now you’re a guest who kneels.”

“It’s not in the bylaws.”

Dimitra looked at the bulge in Thea’s coat pocket. “That the walkie?”

“Channel two, volume at one, as a courtesy.”

“That is not a courtesy, that is a leash.”

“Whose?”

Dimitra almost smiled, in black from collar to boots, with a clipboard under her arm that she would not need. “Fine, keep it, but if I ask whether you need anything, you answer in words.”

“I’m always in words, Dimitra.”

“You’re always in cues.” She checked the doors and the cellist tuning by the east wall. “Groom’s been reading his card to the bathroom mirror since two, and the best man says it’s fine. The best man is lying.”

“Leave him be.”

“On it. I mean, I’m leaving him.” She went off down the aisle, heels clicking.

Thea stood and brushed two gray ovals off her knees. Isla’s scarf, gray with a pulled thread at one end, hung over the back of the last chair, left there from the Subaru. The last bill from Bernadette Roy’s office had come on the fourth of January, one hour, no retainer. Thea had paid it online and left the paper copy in the glove box, in its envelope, under the registration.

Two taps on the doorframe, and a pause.

Nolan stood in the doorway in the charcoal suit, let out across the shoulders by a tailor on Third Street who had said nothing at all, a folding chair under each arm. “Where do you want these?”

“They’re not on the chart.”

“I know. I counted thirty-six and a grandfather.” He set them down and added, “Ma sent a thermos for the staff table.”

“Is it the good coffee?”

“She says she’s not angry with anybody. Where do you want me?”

“Last row, by the wall.”

“By the wall,” he said, and looked at the aisle seat beside it. “That leaves me the door.”

“That leaves you the door.”

“You’ve blocked yourself in.”

“I’m aware of the geometry.”

“I’m not going anywhere, you know.”

“I know.” She straightened his tie, which did not need it, and he let her. “Can you see the exit from there?”

“I can see the exit. Can you see it from there?”

“I’m choosing not to,” said Thea.

• • •

Two days before the wedding, on the Thursday, at a quarter to seven, Thea had opened the family calendar on her laptop at the kitchen table on Alder Street. The green series was gone. She had deleted it herself on New Year’s Day, every block, and the program had asked her twice whether she was sure. She had put nothing in its place, and Thursday ran down the screen white.

At seven Nolan came in from the garage with two mugs, set one at her elbow with the handle turned toward her hand, and sat down across from her with a stack of lab reports. At ten past eight he put his pen down and said, “Bad day,” to the table, the way a man sets down something heavy he has carried a long way.

She closed the laptop. “Tell me.”

He told her, badly, for forty minutes, at the table, with the overhead light on. She did not write anything down. Nobody went to the car.

• • •

Pilar, who had no microphone, stood at the front in her plum stole with her hands folded and her silver helmet of hair catching the light off the ice.

"Tess asked for none," she told Thea, low, when Thea slipped up to check the stand. "She said, let them lean in."

"That's the right call."

"Right? You moved that capsule down an inch three times."

"I was wrong about the capsule."

"Write that down, I want a copy of it."

"It's already on the run-of-show."

"Say that again for the lake." Pilar's eyes went over her face. "You're not working, I notice."

"I'm in the back, with my coat on. Dimitra has the floor."

"Does she?" Pilar's mouth twitched. "Then that's a start. Let it be slightly bad."

"Pilar, if he stops, don't look at me."

"I'll look wherever I like, I'm sixty-three."

At 3:30 Tess came down the true runner on her father's arm, small and fierce in a dress with sleeves, and Thea watched her walk as she had watched three hundred and some brides, then made herself stop and took the wall seat of the last row, with Nolan on the aisle beside her.

Will Renner stood at the front with his ears red and an index card in both hands, and when Pilar lifted her chin at him he looked at it for a long time.

"Tess." His voice was thin but it carried, and nobody needed a microphone. "I promised my mother I wouldn't cry. Sorry, Mom."

The room laughed gently, all together.

"I promise to learn the names of your plants, and to put the milk back, which I know I say every year. I promise to be the one at the door when you get in off nights at four in the morning, the one who—" The card had begun to shake. "Who has the light on."

He stopped.

It was not a pause, and Thea had written eight seconds for a pause. This was a man with his mouth open and the next word gone, the card jumping in his fingers and his shoulders beginning to go.

Her thumb was already in her pocket and had found the button before she knew where her hand was. At the front Dimitra had turned, and her eyes came the whole length of the room to the back row, asking. The cellist's bow hung over the string, waiting on Dimitra, who was waiting on her. Even Pilar

glanced over Will's shoulder, a quarter inch, toward the place where for more than two hundred weddings Thea's cues had reached her. *Cue me.*

Soft music, eight bars, and buy him the room. She had always had the sentence ready.

Her thumb lay on the button and did not press.

Pilar looked away from the back row. "Take your time, Will," she said, to him and the lake. "Nobody here is in a hurry."

Tess held Will's free hand in both of hers and waited with her whole face, offering no rescue. Eight seconds went by, Thea's eight, and then fifteen, while a child shifted in the fourth row and a man in the third blew his nose with great dignity. Thea counted, because she could not not count.

Her hand went sideways across the gap between the chairs.

His was already open on his knee, warm where hers was cold. His fingers closed over hers without squeezing, and he did not look at her, and did not need to.

Twenty-six seconds went by, and then thirty.

"Who has the light on," said Will, in a rush, like something he had found at the bottom of a pocket. He laughed and it went wet. "That's it, that's all of them. I had a better ending, but it's in the bathroom."

"I'll take it," Tess said. "I'll take all of it. Keep going, you're doing great."

The whole room breathed out at once, and under the laughter somebody in the second row said, "Oh, honey."

The walkie crackled against Thea's hip. She drew it out with her free hand and held it against her chin.

Thea. Dimitra, very low, from sixty feet away. Do you need anything?

With the room listening to Will, the answer sat in her mouth for a second and then was just a sentence.

"No," Thea said, "thank you."

Silence on the channel, and then: *Noted.*

Nolan bent his head toward hers. "Thirty-eight seconds," he whispered, "and I'd have cued the cello at nine."

"I know you would, and you counted too."

"I live with a planner, and it rubs off."

"Eight was the plan."

"I was generous."

“You were optimistic.” His thumb moved once across her hand. He was looking straight ahead, at a couple who had finished the hard part and did not know it.

She thumbed the walkie off. Up front Pilar said, “The rings,” and the whole room leaned in.

THE END

A Note Before You Go

Thank you for spending these weeks with Thea, Nolan and the Moravecs.

If this story stayed with you, I would be grateful if you left an honest review on Amazon. A sentence or two is plenty. Reviews help the next reader decide whether this is their kind of book, and they tell me which stories to keep telling.

If you would like to hear when the next book is out, follow Wren Blackspire on Amazon. Search for my name in the Amazon store, open the author page, and tap Follow.

Wren Blackspire